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IN BRIEF



Driving licence rule amendments seek to raise bar

NEW DELHI
The Union government has proposed changes to driving licence rules that could make the learner's test more rigorous while moving several services online and making some of them free. » Page 10

Bizarre entries in Council poll roll spark row in U.P.

LUCKNOW
After unusual names of voters cropped up in the electoral roll of a constituency where voting was held during the Legislative Council polls in Uttar Pradesh on Friday, State CEO Navdeep Rinwa sought an explanation from the electoral officials concerned. » Page 4

LAC 'disturbed' by PLA's behaviour, admits MEA

India, China are in touch to improve border management along the LAC, says Ministry; response comes after ITBP chief's remarks on the situation in Arunachal Pradesh; Congress slams Centre

Suhasini Haidar
NEW DELHI

> Both sides [India and China] continue to use existing diplomatic and military mechanisms to resolve outstanding issues and avoid misunderstanding and miscalculation along the Line of Actual Control
>
> **RANDHIR JAISWAL**
> Ministry of External Affairs spokesperson



The Line of Actual Control (LAC) has been "disturbed" by the People's Liberation Army's (PLA) patrolling behaviour, the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) said on Friday in response to questions about a report in *The Hindu* on skirmishes along the LAC in Arunachal Pradesh.

The report, which had quoted the outgoing Director-General of the Indo-Tibetan Border Police Forces (ITBP), Shatrujeet Kapur, expressing concern over "face-offs" underway since July 2026, led to the Congress criticising the Centre.

Despite the Ministry's confirmation, the video of Mr. Kapur's speech, delivered at an event in Alwar on Thursday, was deleted from the ITBP's official YouTube channel. This was the first time the government has officially accepted that, more than two years after Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Chinese President Xi Jinping announced a détente between their militaries, the border areas remain tense and "get disturbed" over patrolling routes.

"As we have noted in the past, the situation in the India-China border areas gets disturbed from time to time when Chinese forces diverge from established patrolling patterns," Ministry spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal told journalists at a briefing here, blaming the PLA for the divergences.

"Both sides continue to use existing diplomatic and military mechanisms to resolve outstanding issues and avoid misunderstanding and miscalculation along the Line of Actual Control," he added.

He reiterated the government's position since the beginning of the four-year military standoff at the LAC, including the Galwan clashes in 2020, that the "maintenance of peace and tranquility in the border areas is essential for the overall development of bilateral relations", and said that both sides were in touch about improving their understanding of the LAC for "better border management". The response came after the Opposition demanded a clarification on the situation in Arunachal Pradesh.

CONTINUED ON » PAGE 8

Students, farmers, and civil society groups step up stir against SIR, CEC in Delhi

Lavpreet Kaur
NEW DELHI



Security personnel detaining protesters demanding CEC Gyanesh Kumar's resignation, in New Delhi on Friday. SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP

Around 500 protesters from students, youth, women, farmers, and civil society organisations, under the banner of 'People Against SIR', marched through Central Delhi on Friday, demanding the rollback of the special intensive revision (SIR) of electoral rolls and the resignation of Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar. The march was part of a series of protests held across the country against the exercise.

The Delhi Police said around 20 protesters were detained and later released, even as protesters claimed that around 50 were rounded up. Police registered at least one FIR against protesters for violating prohibitory orders under Section 163 of BNSS.

The protesters assembled near the Gol Dak Khana roundabout at the intersection of Kali Bari Marg and Bhai Vir Singh Marg, before attempting to march towards the Election Commission of India headquarters. Ahead of the protest call, participants gathered in small groups around Bangla Sahib Gurdwara.

Political activist Yogendra Yadav, Communist Party of India leader Annie Raja, and All India Kisan Sabha vice-president Inderjeet Singh joined the march. Mr. Yadav said the movement would continue despite restrictions on demonstrations, including the denotification of Jantar Mantar as a protest site.

CONTINUED ON » PAGE 8

Winter blues



Temporary measures: Mist being sprayed on a road in New Delhi using pole-mounted spraying systems to curb pollution. The Capital's air quality remained "poor" for the second consecutive day, with no respite forecast for the next nine days. SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA (REPORT ON PAGE 2)

No role in deciding who can touch Durga idols during immersion: Kolkata Police

Press Trust of India
KOLKATA



CM Suvendu Adhikari visiting the family of a victim of the Chorbagan Durga Puja stampede incident, at Kumartuli in Kolkata on Friday. ANI

Kolkata Police has no role in deciding who can participate in the immersion of Durga idols, Police Commissioner Ajay Kumar Nand said on Friday, adding that the responsibility rests with the respective puja committees.

Mr. Nand, however, said the committees have been asked to follow the instructions issued by West Bengal Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari regarding who could touch the idols during immersion. "Police have no role. Police look after law and order. The puja committees decide among themselves who will come for the immersion," he said at a press conference.

Asked how the authorities would identify those who follow the Sanatana Dharma, Mr. Nand said it was not the police's responsibility to determine that. While inspecting immersion preparations on Wednesday, Mr. Adhikari had said only those who believe in Sanatana Dharma should touch the idols.

'Human error'

Meanwhile, Mr. Adhikari on Friday said the Chorbagan Durga Puja stampede that claimed 19 lives on October 17 was primarily due to "human error". He also described the loss of lives as "very painful".

Gunmen kill seven at Jordan church, king vows retaliation

Agence France-Presse
AMMAN



People and security forces gather outside a Greek Orthodox Church in Hammoud village in Jordan's Karak governorate on Friday. AFP

Gunmen killed at least seven people and wounded dozens at a church in southern Jordan on Friday, authorities said, with the king vowing retaliation for the rare attack on Christians in the majority Sunni Muslim kingdom.

Assailants stormed the compound of a Greek Orthodox church in the village of Hammoud in Karak governorate and opened fire, authorities said.

The gunmen got out of a vehicle and started shooting during a funeral procession, the public security directorate said in a statement, adding that a manhunt was under way for the perpetrators. "The terrorist attack against Karak will be met with the harshest retaliation," King Abdullah II said on X.

"We will strike with an iron fist against those who dare to threaten our nation."

After authorities gave a death toll of six, Director of Public Security Major General Abdullah Al-Maaytah said it had risen to seven with 34 injured. Between 150 and 200 people were in and around the church, the witness said.

Christian community

Karak is home to a significant Christian community in the Muslim-majority kingdom, where Christians make up between two and three per cent of the population.

The Greek Orthodox Archdiocese in Jordan said that if the attack was aimed at driving out Christians from the holy land, "it will only make us cling to it more firmly and deepen our roots in it".

"We are absolutely certain that Jordanian society will remain impervious to every dark, extremist ideology," it said.

Delhi Police reconsiders decision, grants nod for Dosanjh's concert

Lavpreet Kaur
NEW DELHI



Organisers said the concert at Jawaharlal Nehru Stadium in Delhi will now go ahead as scheduled. FILE PHOTO

Singer Diljit Dosanjh's October 30 concert at Jawaharlal Nehru Stadium in Delhi will go ahead as scheduled after the Delhi police reconsidered its decision and granted permission for the event on Friday, a day after withholding clearance citing security and law and order concerns during the festive season.

In a response to *The Hindu* on Friday, ticketing platform BookMyShow Live stated that reports suggesting that the concert had been cancelled were "inaccurate". It confirmed that permission has been issued following a "cordial and constructive meeting" with the police.

'Plan submitted'

The organisers said they had submitted a detailed plan addressing the safety, traffic and crowd-management measures sought by the authorities and assured them of compliance with all applicable requirements. "Following these discussions and the submission of the requisite plan, permission for the event has been reconsidered and issued," BookMyShow Live stated, adding that the concert would proceed as planned.

The development comes a day after Deputy Commissioner of Police (South District) Anant Mittal informed the organisers that their application to hold the Delhi leg of Mr. Dosanjh's Aura India Tour could not be accepted in view of specific threat-related inputs, festive-season security commitments and other law and order concerns. The police had examined the organisers' application dated October 14 for the concert at the stadium. The initial decision had cast uncertainty over the event, prompting the organisers to hold further talks with the police.

The earlier move to deny permission had drawn criticism from the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP), which accused the government of bias against the singer. "Real heroes like @diljitdosanjh supported the farmers' movement and spoke against police violence on students. A brave 'sardar' always troubles dictators, as did Shaheed-e-Azam Bhagat Singh. The government is biased against such brave Punjabis," AAP Delhi president Saurabh Bharadwaj wrote on X.



DEVASTATING IMPACT
16 killed as 7.0-magnitude earthquake hits Tibet
WORLD » PAGE 12

A FESTIVAL MARRED
Death in the time of Durga Puja
North Kolkata pandal stampede exposes gaps in safety arrangements
GROUND ZERO » PAGE 7



SECOND T20I
India looks to sustain the momentum
SPORT » PAGE 15

AAP flags 'irregularities' in textbook printing; BJP rejects allegations

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) on Friday alleged that NCERT textbooks supplied free to Delhi government schools were printed on substandard paper and did not meet tender specifications. It sought an explanation from Education Minister Ashish Sood and the ruling Bharatiya Janata Party.

At a press meet, AAP Delhi chief Saurabh Bharadwaj compared copies of the Class 8 NCERT textbook 'Malhar' (the new official Class 8 Hindi core book) sold in bookshops with those supplied to government schools, alleging a "scam" in printing.

"The specifications in these tenders are exactly the same as those of the books available in the market. The paper size is supposed to be A4, and the paper quality must be 80 GSM (grams per square metre).

However, the books printed are not of A4 size and are printed on substandard paper," Mr. Bharadwaj said, accusing the Education Department of corruption. He said a printer had told him that the prices of the two books differed by at least 40%. "The government must explain who all took this commission. Have officials or politicians taken commissions for books meant for schoolchildren?" Mr. Bharadwaj said.

'Deflecting attention'

Delhi BJP spokesperson Praveen Shankar Kapoor rejected the charge, saying textbooks had been supplied regularly for the past two years.

He alleged that during the previous AAP government, entire academic sessions often passed without textbooks being supplied to students. "It appears that Saurabh Bharadwaj considers himself an expert capable of judging the quality of paper as well," Mr. Kapoor said.

Delhi govt. directs officials to identify pollution hotspots amid decline in air quality

Air quality index remains within 'poor' category, no respite expected over next 9 days; transport largest contributor to pollution at 20.3%, followed by residential sources at 5.2%, show CPCB data

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI



Environment Minister Manjinder Singh Sirsa reviewing pollution control measures at the District Magistrate's office on Friday. X/@MSSIRSA

With the city's air quality remaining "poor" for the second consecutive day and no respite forecast for the next nine days, Environment Minister Manjinder Singh Sirsa on Friday directed officials to prepare hotspot-specific action plans, identifying the agencies responsible, and setting deadlines for corrective measures.

At a review meeting, Mr. Sirsa directed officials to use air quality index (AQI) monitoring data to identify local sources of pollution, focusing on road dust, heavy traffic, construction, unauthorised parking, and waste burning.

"Our approach is clear: identify the source of pollution and act at the spot. Every department must have a clear action plan, a deadline and accountability for results," Mr. Sirsa said. He instructed agencies to remove encroachments, repair potholes, treat exposed soil along roadsides and ensure regular water sprinkling at locations prone to dust.

A higher AQI means an increase in air pollution. Delhi's average AQI stood at 230 in the "poor" category, with Stage I of the Graded Response Action Plan in force. Three of the 56 monitoring stations recorded "very poor" air quality, with Pusa reporting the highest AQI at 324, according to the Central Pollution Control Board's (CPCB) Sameer app.

Data from the app also showed transport accounted for 20.3% of Delhi's air pollution, followed by residential sources (5.2%), industries (4.2%), construction (2.6%), energy (2%), waste burning (1.8%), road dust (1.4%) and other sectors (1.3%).

Mr. Sirsa called for better coordination between the traffic police and other agencies to regulate the movement of heavy vehicles, particularly during peak hours. Urging residents to help fight pollution, Mr. Sirsa asked them to avoid burning garbage or dumping waste on roads, keep vehicle Pollution Under Control certificates valid, and use public transport or carpool.

"Keeping Delhi's air clean requires government action and responsible public behaviour, including avoiding waste burning and reducing private vehicle use," he added.

CM: all 357 villages incorporated into urbanisation process

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI


CM Rekha Gupta at the implementation of 'Same work, Same pay' for MTS workers. ANI

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Friday said 48 villages have been cleared for urbanisation, bringing all 357 villages listed in the Capital's revenue records under the urbanisation process. Of these, 309 have already been declared urban.

The remaining 48 received clearance from the Delhi Development Authority in February and the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) Standing Committee in May, according to a statement from the Chief Minister's Office.

"Urbanisation will lay the foundation for development and help improve planning for roads, sewerage, and civic amenities," Ms. Gupta said. She added that development should improve residents' quality of life while preserving the villages' cultural identity.

However, urbanisation will not automatically lead to infrastructure projects or changes in land use, which will remain subject to applicable laws, approved plans, statutory permissions, and availability of resources.

MCD staff pay revised

Separately, Ms. Gupta disbursed revised salaries to around 4,000 Multi-Tasking Staff employees of the MCD's Public Health Department. Their monthly pay has been increased to ₹28,800, comprising the minimum ₹18,000 under Level 1 of the Seventh Central Pay Commission's pay matrix and applicable dearness allowance, MCD Commissioner Sanjeev Khirwar said.

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Police unearth cyber fraud racket; bank staffers among 6 held

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Delhi police have busted a cyber fraud network involving 37 suspected mule bank accounts that received ₹7.36 crore in connection with 99 complaints registered across India. Six people, including five bankers, have been arrested, officials said on Friday.

The arrested bankers included Shobhit Aggarwal, branch manager of Catholic Syrian Bank (CSB Bank) in Saraswati Vihar, and four members of the bank's sales team. The branch manager of the Tri Nagar branch, Sushant Kumar, has not been arrested yet.

The sixth accused, Mayank Kapoor, 35, allegedly used forged signatures and KYC (know your customer) documents obtained from unsuspecting daily wagers to facilitate the opening of fraudulent bank accounts. A portion of the proceeds was allegedly converted into cryptocurrency, officials said.

The investigation uncovered 17 suspected mule accounts at the Saraswati Vihar branch and 20 at the Tri Nagar branch of CSB Bank.

According to the police, the investigation began after scrutiny of mule account data identified the Tri Nagar branch as a suspected centre for such accounts.

"A preliminary inquiry revealed that the purported holder of one account had neither visited the branch nor applied to open it. The addresses linked to two other suspected mule accounts at the branch could not be verified," a police officer said. "A technical analysis of registered mobile numbers, e-mail IDs, linked devices and email connections led investigators to Kapoor, who was arrested from Baba Haridas Nagar in Delhi," the officer added.

'Loan approval calls'

Mr. Kapoor told the police that he had contacted daily wagers over the phone on the pretext of loan approval and obtained their KYC documents and photographs through WhatsApp. He also arranged SIM cards in their names and used the documents to facilitate the opening of mule accounts, the police said.

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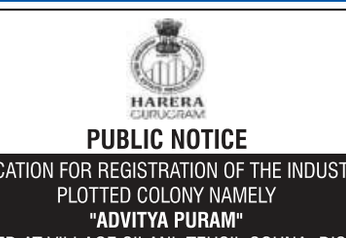
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1.We, Nitika Jain & Pawan Kumar Singh partners of M/s Trump International LLP., FF – 5 and FF-5A, First Floor Apsara Arcade, B-1/8 Pusa Road Delhi-110005 holding registration certificate no. B-1669/DEL/PART/1000+/5/10265/2023 under the provision of the Emigration Act, 1983 for export of manpower. We have closed our business with effect from 31ST August 2026.
2.In the event there is any claim against us, the same may be refered with in 30 days from the publication of this notice. Copyes of the complaints may also be sent to The Protector General of Emigrants, Ministry of External Affairs, Jaisalmer House, Canteen Block, 26, Man Singh Road, New Delhi – 110011.
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PUBLIC NOTICE
It is known and informing to the public at large and all concern that my Client namely Santosh Kumari W/o Late Sh. Tek Chand Ahuja, R/o WZ-641, Nangal Raya, New Delhi: -110046, having Aadhar NO. 740939904123 and voter identity card bearing No. NCJ0263434, hereby declared and affirmed that earlier she was known by various names like as Santosh Ahuja, Mamta Ahuja, Mamta Kumari, Bimla Devi and Mamta, but her actual name is only Santosh Kumari and she will be known publically as Santosh Kumari as all the above names as mentioned are same person. She further declared and affirmed that all the above mentioned names are her call names. All the above mentioned names are pertaining to only a similar and only one person like as Santosh Kumari who knows earlier by different names. She further declared and affirmed that she will be known as Santosh Kumari as mentioned above in place of her earlier names.
A.P. SAH (Advocate)
En. D-933-A/93
Seat No.6, Bar Room 2, Dwarka Courts New Delhi-110075

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PUBLIC NOTICE
HARERA GURUGRAM
PUBLIC NOTICE
APPLICATION FOR REGISTRATION OF THE INDUSTRIAL PLOTTED COLONY NAMELY
"ADVITYA PURAM"
SITUATED AT VILLAGE SILANI, TEHSIL SOHNA, DISTRICT GURUGRAM BEING DEVELOPED BY
M/S ADVITYA RESIDENCY LLP

It is for the information of the general public that an application dated 16.10.2026 for registration of the project under Section 4 of the Act of 2016 is submitted in the Authority for the project "Advitya Puram" being developed by M/s Advitya Residency LLP.

The Department of Town & Country Planning, Haryana granted license no. 166 of 2026 dated 18.08.2026 to M/s Advitya Residency LLP for development of Industrial Plotted Colony on the land measuring 082.05 acres at Village Silani, Tehsil Sohna, District Gurugram.

The applicant promoter has further obtained the layout plan approval of the project vide drawing no. DTCP 12510 dated 18.08.2026 and demarcation cum zoning plans for the project vide memo no. ZP-2433/JD(G)/2026/34667 dated 28.09.2026.

The Authority is considering the application of the promoter to grant registration certificate under Section 4 of the Act 2016 for this project.

The relevant application and related documents are available in the office of the Haryana Real Estate Regulatory Authority, Gurugram which can be seen by any concerned on any working day during office hours up to 05.11.2026 till 11:00 AM.

Also, if anyone wishes to appear, may appear before the Authority on 05.11.2026 at 11:00 AM during the hearing. Given under the approval of the Authority and its seal.

Sd/-
Secretary, Haryana Real Estate Regulatory Authority, Gurugram

Dated:22.10.2026

Govt. of Jharkhand
Jharkhand Combined Entrance Competitive Examination Board
Science & Technology Campus, Sirkha Toli, Namkum-Tupudana Road, Namkum, Ranchi – 834010
Website : https://jceceb.jharkhand.gov.in • e-mail : jceceboard@gmail.com

Advt. No. :–JCECEB/46/26-111 ,Ranchi/Dated: 23/10/2026

Indicative information regarding Merit List preparation for Special Round of Online Counselling for admission in All India Seats in M.B.B.S. & B.D.S. courses
PRESS COMMUNIQUE

In compliance with the directions issued by the Health, Medical Education & Family Welfare Department, Government of Jharkhand, Ranchi, regarding the preparation of the Merit List for the Special Round of Online Counselling for admission to vacant All India Seats in Laxmi Chandravansi Medical College & Hospital, Palamu; Netaji Subhas Medical College and Hospital, Seraikela-Kharsawan; Sido Kanhu Medical College & Hospital, Dumka; and Birsa Institute of Medical Sciences & Research, Khunti (for the M.B.B.S. course), and Vananchal Dental College and Hospital, Garhwa, under Babu Dinesh Singh University, Garhwa (for the B.D.S. course), the Board is going to invite online applications from eligible candidates at the All India level on the basis of the All India Merit List. The Merit list, thus prepared, will be forwarded to the concerned College/University for admission.

Detailed information in this regard has been uploaded under "Important Notice" column at **Board's website http://jceceb.jharkhand.gov.in.**

Sd/-
(Controller of Examination)

PR 392333 (Jharkhand Combined Entrance Competitive Examination Board) 26-27 (D)

KARNATAKA INDUSTRIAL AREAS DEVELOPMENT BOARD
(A Government of Karnataka Undertaking)
No.2, 2/1 and 2/3, Kalidasa Marg, 1st Main Road, Gandhinagar, Bengaluru-560009. Phone No. 080-22265383, Website: www.kiadb.in

No. IADB/ENGG/ETND-EP-41/2259/2026-27 Date: 22.10.2026

SHORT TERM NOTICE INVITING TENDER
(Through GOK Karnataka Public Procurement Portal Only)

Item Rate Tenders under two cover bid system are invited as per the Karnataka Transparency in Public Procurement Act 1999 and Rules 2000 through electronic procurement from eligible Contractors who have got adequate financial resources, state of the art technology, suitable construction equipments, technical man power & sufficient past experience for the work of :

Name of the Work: (1) Part-A: Establishment of 2x20 MVA, 66/11kV Substation at Gowibidanur Industrial Area Phase-3, Chikkaballapura District. Part-B: (i) Construction of 66kV SC line on DC towers from Kudumalkunte 66/11kV Substation to common tower for distance of 0.958 kms (ii) Construction of 66kV SC line on DC Towers from Vidhurashwatha 66/11kV Substation to common tower for distance of 3.355 kms. (iii) Construction of 66kV DC Line on DC Towers from Common Point to proposed 66/11kV Gowribidnur Industrial Area 3rd Phase Substation for a distance of 1.971 kms. Part-C: (i) Providing 1 No of additional line TB at existing 66/11kV Substation Kudumalakunte Industrial Area in Chikkaballapura District. (ii) Providing 1 No of additional TB at existing 66/11kV Substation Vidurashwatha in Chikkaballapura District. **(2)** Part-A: Establishing 2x31.5 MVA, 66/11kV Substation at KIADB Obalapura Industrial Area in Nelamangala Taluk, Bengaluru Rural District.Part-B: Construction of 66kV Over Head Line by LILOing the under construction Dabaspete-Doddabelavangala line near Hadhihosahalli Village up to proposd 66/11kV Substation at KIADB Obalapura Industrial Area for a distance of about 1.636 Kms using drake conductor. **(3)** Providing Power Infrastructure at Doothnur Kaval Industrial Area, Channarayapatna Taluk, Hassan District. **(2nd call)**

The last date and time of receipt of tender is : **11.11.2026** upto **4.00 pm.**

Applicants May Download Bidding Documents from the Karnataka Public Procurement Portal **https://kppp.karnataka.gov.in.**

Sd/-
Engineer in Chief, KIADB, Bengaluru

DIPR/CP/3327/SMCL/2026-27

Timings
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SATURDAY, OCT. 24	
RISE 06:27	SET 17:43
RISE 16:22	SET 04:19
SUNDAY, OCT. 25	
RISE 06:28	SET 17:42
RISE 16:56	SET 05:22
MONDAY, OCT. 26	
RISE 06:29	SET 17:41
RISE 17:35	SET 06:27

Delhi Weather	max	min
Delhi City	32	19
Safdarjang	32	19
Palam	30	18

Delhi Palam Today
32°C Pollution level to increase gradually.The dry weather to continue. Day will be little warm. Night will be slight cool.

Delhi Palam Tomorrow
31°C Morning will be slight cool with mist and haze. Day will be slight warm. Night also will be slight cool. Dry weather to continue.

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HC proposes surprise checks of public toilets

Soibam Rocky Singh
NEW DELHI

The Delhi High Court has proposed surprise inspections of public toilets across the Municipal Corporation of Delhi area by students from three social work institutions to assess their hygiene and structural condition. The court said access to hygienic public toilets was part of the right to life. It stressed that civic authorities were duty-bound not only to provide such facilities but also to ensure maintenance.

The court asked Jamia Millia Islamia's College of Social Work, Delhi University's Department of Social Work and Aditi Mahavidyalaya to form teams for the inspections.

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SWIFT

INBRIEF



Haryana power staff calls off strike after CM's assurance

Haryana electricity employees on Friday called off their strike with immediate effect after the State government decided to seek a review and cancellation of the Haryana Electricity Regulatory Commission's (HERC) order granting a parallel power distribution licence to a private company in Gurugram and Nuh. Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini assured the employees that the government stood firmly with them in opposing any move to privatise the power sector. The power employees had announced three-day strike starting Thursday opposing the grant of parallel licence.

Odisha rape-murder accused held; police officer suspended

The prime accused in the alleged rape and murder of a 14-year-old girl in Odisha's Balasore district was arrested on Friday, while a police officer was suspended for alleged negligence in handling the case.The girl's half-burnt body was found in a bushy area near her village. She had been missing since the evening of October 16, following which a case was registered at the Jaleswar police station, police said. SP Pratyush Diwaker said the accused allegedly strangled the girl to death on October 16 after she resisted his advances. Angry villagers blocked a road on Friday morning, demanding a speedy trial. PTI

Bizarre names in U.P. voter roll for MLC polls spark row; CEO demands explanation

Names like 'Ram *ne* Yadav *ko maara*', 'BCom' mentioned in place of a voter's father's name surface in voter list of Allahabad Graduates' constituency; CEO blames 'software glitch, human negligence'

Mayank Kumar
LUCKNOW

After unusual names and details of voters cropped up in the electoral roll of a constituency where voting was held during the Legislative Council polls in Uttar Pradesh on Friday, State Chief Electoral Officer (CEO) Navdeep Rinwa sought an explanation from the electoral officials concerned.

The discrepancies were found in the voter list of the Allahabad Graduates' constituency ahead of polling. Five districts fall under the constituency.

Five Graduates' constituencies – Lucknow, Agra, Meerut, Varanasi, and Allahabad-Jhansi – and six Teachers' constituencies – Lucknow, Agra, Meerut, Varanasi, Bareilly-Moradabad, and Gorakhpur-Faizabad – covering over 30 districts in Uttar Pradesh, went to the polls on Friday, with over 14 lakh voters exercising their franchise.

The elections concluded amid allegations by the Opposition of bogus voting by Bharatiya Janata Party supporters. The ruling party dismissed the allegations, calling them an "acceptance of defeat" before the results are announced.



Women electors showing their inked fingers after casting votes for the U.P. Legislative Council elections, in Prayagraj on Friday. ANI

The errors triggered an uproar on social media, with entries such as "Ram *ne* Yadav *ko maara*" and "Ram *ne* Sharma *ko maara*" listed as names and "BCom" mentioned in place of a voter's father's name surfacing in the roll.

A statement issued by Mr. Rinwa stated, "For the first time, an online registration facility has been provided in Uttar Pradesh for adding names to the voter list for the Legislative Council elections. There is a possibility of mistakes when doing any work for the first time."

'158 strange entries'

The statement added that out of the 14,81,310 entries in the voter list, there are 158 entries in which the names of electors or their relatives appear strange, and that "the strangeness of these names is one such mistake".

"The software was supposed to transliterate the names typed in English into Hindi but probably due to some error, it translated them. For example, when Ramhit Yadav was typed, the software translated it as 'Ram hit Yadav'," the statement read.

It also stated that there was a system to edit and correct such mistakes, but where people were not careful, such mistakes persisted, and that typing BCom in place of father's name is "human error or negligence".

The statement added that the Divisional Commissioner is the Electoral Registration Officer and the District Officer is the Assistant Electoral Registration Officer. "It said it is their responsibility to keep the voter list free from all errors and that an explanation has been sought from them in this regard. Instructions have been given to the District Officers to ensure that voters do not face any problem due to these mistakes," it read.

Two T.N. students apprehended over classmate's suicide

The Hindu Bureau
COIMBATORE


A protest at Coimbatore Collectorate demanding arrest of the headmaster and the teacher on Friday.

Two days after a Class XI student belonging to a Scheduled Caste ended his life in Coimbatore over the alleged caste-based harassment at a government-aided school, the police on Friday apprehended two of his classmates belonging to different dominant castes.

The two students were produced before the Juvenile Justice Board and lodged at an observation home for juveniles at Papanaickenpalayam in the city.

Harassed over caste

A senior police officer said the students were arrested after investigations revealed that they had subjected the deceased, A. Akilan, 16, to caste-based harassment. Women police personnel collected statements from Akilan's classmates and the teaching staff. Further investigation was under way into the allegations made by Akilan's mother against a teacher, P. Vijayakumar, and the headmaster, Arunkumar S.

The mother had accused the teacher of having harassed her son over his eating habits. According to the FIR in the case, she alleged that the teacher made her son and four others, who consume beef, stand up in the classroom two months ago. The two apprehended students had been harassing and torturing Akilan since then, and the school's headmaster did not act against them, she said.

The police officer said Akilan did not leave any note and the police were investigating all the allegations raised by his mother.

Meanwhile, Akilan's parents, members of the DMK, the CPI(M) and other organisations gathered on the Coimbatore Collectorate premises, demanding the arrest of all the persons accused of having harassed the student and abetted his suicide.

(Those in distress can contact Tele MANAS at 14416 to seek help)

Cong. ticket aspirant behind sting operation: Yathindra

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU/MYSURU


Congress leader Siddaramaiah and his son Yathindra. FILE PHOTO

The alleged sting operation targeting former Karnataka Chief Minister Siddaramaiah took a fresh turn on Friday, with his son and Urban Development Minister Yathindra Siddaramaiah alleging that a Congress woman leader was behind the episode.

Speaking to reporters, Mr. Yathindra said the woman leader was keen on securing Congress ticket to contest in the Puttur Assembly constituency in Dakshina Kannada district. He alleged that she had joined hands with the head of a media organisation to carry out the operation.

Mr. Siddaramaiah later identified the woman as Krupa Alva and the media representative as Rakesh Shetty, owner of Power TV.

Mr. Yathindra said an investigation was necessary to establish whether the Congress leader and the media representative had acted on their own or whether others were behind the episode.

Breaking his long silence, the former Chief Minister spoke later in Mysuru, and called for a fair investigation, alleging that the whole episode was aimed at "blackmailing" him. Mr. Siddaramaiah said he had lodged a police complaint against what he termed "a false case".

Soon after, KPCC chief B.K. Hariprasad said a show-cause notice would be issued to Ms. Alva, who is a KPCC spokesperson, seeking an explanation for her alleged role in the episode. Congress sources said the party was considering expelling her for allegedly embarrassing the government and giving the Opposition ammunition to target it.

Mr. Shetty, head of the TV channel, has obtained interim anticipatory bail in connection with the sting operation case being investigated by the Central Crime Branch of Bengaluru police.

Keralam Governor orders vegetarian-only menu at Lok Bhavan; Cong. censures move

G. Anand
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

Keralam's Governor Om Prakash Mathur, who was sworn in on Friday, seemed to have inadvertently stoked a debate over the socially touchy "food purity" politics in the State.

Mr. Mathur, who hails from Rajasthan and follows a strict vegetarian diet, "banned" the cooking of non-vegetarian dishes in the Lok Bhavan kitchen.

Lok Bhavan sources clarified that the ban applied only to the official kitchen and Mr. Mathur had not barred his staff from bringing their preferred food from home or outside.

'Right to decide'

Refusing to comment on reports that Mr. Mathur had brought cooks from Rajasthan to rustle up his daily meals, sources stressed he has the right to decide what he ate. However, the Congress has portrayed the Governor's directive as an attempt to resurrect the Hindutva imposition of food hierarchy, which allegedly sought to place a vegetarian diet followed by so-called "privileged communities" above non-vegetarian fare, which is a staple for minorities and also a significant section of Keralam's Hindu population.


Om Prakash Mathur


K.C. Venugopal

All India Congress Committee general secretary K.C. Venugopal accused Mr. Mathur of seeking to place food, a matter of personal choice and culinary culture, at the centre of Hindutva politics in "secular, progressive and inclusive" Keralam.

'Hindutva agenda'

The Congress leader said the Lok Bhavan's attempt to make vegetarian fare a mandatory choice for visitors and staff was a "first step towards imposing the Hindutva agenda in Keralam". He sought to link Mr. Mathur's stress on only vegetarian food at the Lok Bhavan to an attempt to portray non-vegetarianism as a marker of impurity and cow vigilantism. He also recalled the lynching of Mohammad Akhlaq in Dadri in Uttar Pradesh in 2015 for allegedly stocking beef for consumption in his house.

Mr. Venugopal said the order dovetailed politically with the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP)-led Central government's disenfranchisement of crores of voters, mostly those from marginalised sections of Hindu society and minorities, using the Election Commission's profoundly contentious special intensive revision of voter lists as a politically expedient cover. He alleged that Mr. Mathur's order affronted Keralam's cultural and culinary diversity.

Cong. holds meetings for INDIA bloc rally on Nov. 1

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Congress general secretary (organisation) K.C. Venugopal on Friday said the party held meetings to discuss mobilisation efforts for the INDIA bloc's mega rally against alleged vote theft on November 1.

In a post on X, Mr. Venugopal said he, along with party leader Priyanka Gandhi Vadra, met party in-charge for Uttar Pradesh Rajendra Pal Gautam, U.P. Congress chief Aradhana Misra, and senior leaders. He said a separate meeting was held with party in-charge for Haryana Sanjay Dutt, and State party chief Rao Narender Singh.

Mr. Venugopal said the rally at Delhi's Ramlila Maidan will be the culmination of a 'Delhi Chalo' march and at least 10 lakh citizens are expected to attend it.

Between rock and hard place, BJD's BJP-Cong. dilemma in Odisha

NEWS ANALYSIS

Satyasundar Barik
BHUBANESWAR


Challenge for Naveen Patnaik is carving an independent position without being drawn into BJP-Cong. political binary. FILE PHOTO

Former Chief Minister and Biju Janata Dal (BJD) supremo Naveen Patnaik's problem appears to be not how to take on BJP in Odisha, but how to oppose it without helping Congress recover its lost ground.

Mr. Patnaik's dilemma was evident this week when he backed the release of Cockroach Janata Party (CJP) leaders Saurav Das and Asutosh Ranka, the BJP was quick to brand him an ally of 'anarchists' allegedly seeking to create a Bangladesh-like situation in the country. The charge, increasingly directed at the Congress and Left parties in recent times, has brought the BJD into the crossfire.

The BJD responded by deploying one of its senior vice-presidents to counter the allegations. This was not the first time the regional party had found itself defending its political position. When two of its Rajya Sabha MPs joined an anti-Chief Election Commissioner protest march in New Delhi earlier this month, the BJP wasted no time in accusing the BJD of seeking a political alliance with the INDIA bloc. The BJD was subsequently forced to issue clarifications through multiple leaders, insisting that it had no alliance with the INDIA bloc but was merely supporting the cause.

The dilemma resurfaced on October 7, 2026, when the BJD clarified that it neither supported nor opposed the Odisha bandh called by INDIA bloc parties, maintaining that it had taken an independent and principled position.

These episodes point to a growing challenge for the BJD; carving out an independent political position in Odisha without being drawn into the BJP-Congress political binary.

Such positioning was relatively easier when the Naveen Patnaik-led party was in power and could align itself with issues under the broader umbrella of regional interests. As an Opposition party, however, it faces the challenge of opposing the BJP without appearing to gravitate towards the Congress.

At present, the BJD has grown to be strong anti-BJP force in Odisha while Congress has emerged principal opposition to BJP nationally.

"The dilemma of the BJD is bound to persist. If the party does not criticise the BJP, it cannot position itself as a strong Opposition in Odisha. If it lends support to Congress-led protests against the BJP, it runs the risk of eroding its anti-Congress base, which was a key premise of its formation," said Prasanna Mohanty, senior journalist and political commentator.

Mr. Mohanty further said BJD escaped close scrutiny of its political standing even though it extended support to BJP on the floor of Parliament on key Bills and elections.

After finding in Opposition space, the BJD has been very active as far as picking up issues to target State BJP is concerned. The party has, in fact, dented the reputation of Mohan Charan Majhi government by constantly raising issues such as errors in school textbooks, Odisha's financial interest in wake of Mines and Minerals (Development and Regulation) Amendment Act 2026 and general law and order situation in the State.

The regional party had taken precautions during last monsoon session of Odisha Legislative Assembly session by raising MMDR Act, leaving textbook error issue to Congress. Both parties were not seen following the same issue on same day during the session.

'Political compulsions'

Ruben Banerjee, author of 'Naveen Patnaik', a biography of five time CM, and longtime observer of Odisha politics, said, "Mr Patnaik has many political compulsions. He is part of extended BJP. That understanding with BJP exists which was proven by very recently during BJD's voting during Waqf Board Bill. And also the very fact that there is no CBI and Enforcement Directorate raids against any BJD leaders. There is a protection ring at works."

Keralam SIR: LDF seeks restoration of all deleted names

The Hindu Bureau
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

Representatives of the Left Democratic Front (LDF) walked out of an all-party meeting convened by Chief Electoral Officer D. Sajith Babu on Friday, demanding the reinstatement of all voters excluded from the electoral roll after the special intensive revision (SIR) in Keralam.

Senior Communist Party of India (Marxist) [CPI(M)] leader M.V. Jayarajan and Communist Party of India (CPI) leader Sathyan Mokeri later said they demanded that election officials restore the names of 24.08 lakh voters excluded when the draft SIR list was published. "The CEO expressed his helplessness. We have asked the CEO to convey the demand to the Election Commission of India (ECI)," Mr. Jayarajan said.

The meeting was convened in connection with the special summary revision (SSR) of the electoral roll currently under way in the State. Political parties demanded an extension of the November 2 deadline for rationalising polling stations. Mr. Sajith Babu said he had informed the leaders that he would convey their demand to the ECI.

While political parties claim that 24.08 lakh voters were excluded after the Keralam round of SIR, election officials say this was the number in the draft list. The number fell to 8.97 lakh in the final SIR list.

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Falling short

Marco Rubio's second visit to India this year yielded little in terms of results

The United States Secretary of State's three-day visit to India, his second in five months, came at a significant time in U.S. politics. Marco Rubio's Mumbai trip this week was just ahead of the U.S. midterm elections, which would mark the midpoint of President Donald Trump's second term in office – a point at which the incumbent normally begins to focus on legacy, and possible contenders for the next Presidential election (Mr. Rubio is expected to be one), and start to look for possible partners and friendships around the world. In addition, his visit also raised hopes in New Delhi of a reset in bilateral ties, battered by two years of uncertainty over the Trump administration's actions. This would include positive moves towards concluding the Bilateral Trade Agreement, reassuring India about U.S. sanctions on the import of Russian oil, preparations for upcoming Trump meets with Prime Minister Narendra Modi at the Manila (ASEAN) and Miami (G-20) summits, discussing plans for the Quad Summit (on the sidelines of the ASEAN summit) that India has been trying to host, and setting a date for Mr. Trump's India visit. External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar's invitation also offered Mr. Rubio an opportunity to meet their UAE counterpart, Sheikh Abdullah bin Zayed Al Nahyan, to discuss the Gulf situation and to restore energy security and connectivity. And finally, Mr. Rubio's visit to the Jamnagar Reliance refinery, led to speculation of some major deals on energy, possibly offering more discounts as he pitched for India to buy more American and U.S.-licensed Venezuelan oil.

Given all the high expectations, the visit was bound to come up short. The optics of his visit to Mumbai and Jamnagar, but not New Delhi, which was announced by the U.S. Ambassador to India, gave the Opposition fodder to question the real purpose of the visit. Despite Mr. Rubio's two visits to India and more than six by Mr. Jaishankar to the U.S. since Mr. Trump took office, relations remain on edge, with issues on trade, tariffs, H-1B restrictions and anti-immigrant measures unaddressed. Also, the U.S.'s narrative on Operation Sindoor (2025), growing ties with Pakistan, and the Trump administration's rhetoric on India's economy, diaspora and Russian oil trade have added to India's unhappiness. The two sides did not announce any agreements and Mr. Jaishankar and Mr. Rubio did not hold a joint press address. However, as they did at the U.S. Independence Day's 250th anniversary celebrations in Delhi in May, they attended the "Freedom 250" event in Mumbai. Mr. Rubio acknowledged that while no two countries would agree on all issues, he said the U.S.-India alignment on core issues of national interest was "extraordinary". From this point on, Mr. Rubio must walk that talk, with a view to ensuring that India-U.S. ties are able to move on from the difficulties of the last few years.

In the crossfire

India must adopt a pro-active position in the Saudi-Houthi conflict

The killing of an Indian national in a Houthi attack on Saudi Arabia's Dammam airport is a grim reminder of the dangers the kingdom's Indian community faces as the conflict between Riyadh and Yemen's Shia militants escalates. Since the fighting between Saudi Arabia and the Houthis resumed in July, at least two Indians have been killed and 14 others wounded. On Thursday, the Houthis claimed that a yacht with 14 Indians was targeted by Saudi forces near Yemen's Zuqar island in the Red Sea and that rescue operations were under way. As the Houthis, who control parts of Northern Yemen and its entire Red Sea coast, step up attacks on Saudi infrastructure, including oil facilities and airports, Indians, who are the kingdom's largest expat community, risk getting caught in the crossfire. With flights disrupted, thousands of Indian pilgrims are stranded. India has condemned Houthi attacks, saying that it "stands in solidarity" with Saudi Arabia. With no end in sight to the fighting and a high possibility of Israel and the U.S. resuming their Iran strikes, further violence and instability in West Asia could make India's choices increasingly difficult.

The Saudi-Houthi conflict dates back to the Houthi takeover of Sana'a, Yemen's capital, in 2014. A year later, Saudi Arabia began bombing Yemen to drive the Houthis out. But years of Saudi bombing of one of the poorest Arab countries have proved counterproductive; the Houthis consolidated support among the tribes of northern Yemen and built a powerful territorial army and naval force. The Saudi-Houthi ceasefire of 2022 collapsed in July 2026 after Saudi Arabia recklessly bombed Sana'a airport, to prevent an Iranian plane with a Houthi delegation from landing. The Houthis subsequently began attacking Saudi Arabia's critical infrastructure, and launched a ground offensive against the Saudi-backed forces in Yemen. The Houthi attacks pose the biggest security challenge to Mohammed bin Salman, Saudi Arabia's Crown Prince and the main architect of the war on Yemen, in decades. Massive Saudi air strikes have neither defeated the Houthis nor restored the kingdom's deterrence. With its wealth, natural resources, infrastructure and tenuous palace politics, the kingdom remains exposed to Houthi missile and drone attacks, with few good options for a way out. India must prepare a contingency plan for worst-case scenarios. Its immediate priority should be to evacuate stranded Indian pilgrims. It should also articulate a stronger position for stability and work with Arab countries and Tehran to push for a diplomatic settlement to the Iran crisis. For peace to prevail in the Persian Gulf, the guns directed at Iran must first fall silent.

BJP has no bad option, Congress has no good option



Varghese K. George

On October 16, 2026, Congress president and Leader of the Opposition in the Rajya Sabha, Mallikarjun Kharge, wrote to Prime Minister Narendra Modi, seeking an all-party meeting to discuss the government's delimitation proposals before they were finalised and introduced in Parliament. It was Mr. Kharge's fourth letter since April seeking such a meeting. On October 19, Parliamentary Affairs Minister Kiren Rijiju replied, saying that the government had repeatedly sought the Congress's cooperation, including through letters to Mr. Kharge in March and April and discussions with him and Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha, Rahul Gandhi.

Mr. Rijiju also said that the government had held consultations with several other Opposition parties. Yet, his reply showed once again that the Centre had no intention of disclosing its precise proposals on delimitation. Without explicitly saying so, Mr. Rijiju's letter suggested that the government planned to bring in legislation on delimitation while withholding the details, thereby preventing a possible public debate on the issue.

What the real debate is

Given the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP)'s plans to move the legislation by stealth, one has to go by what is publicly available to examine the options before the BJP and the Opposition, particularly the Congress, on delimitation. Women's reservation is an unnecessary distraction and fog in this debate. The issue is settled: one-third of the seats in the Lok Sabha and State Assemblies will be reserved for women when the next delimitation takes place, regardless of the total number of seats. The real debate concerns the increase in the size of the Lok Sabha and how it is distributed among the States.

In April 2026, the government said that it would retain the current proportion of States in an enlarged Lok Sabha of up to 850 seats. The proposal would increase the cap on the number of Lok Sabha seats by more than 50%, translating into a corresponding increase in the number of seats in each State while maintaining their existing proportions.

However, the government subsequently introduced Bills that required the distribution of Lok Sabha seats on the basis of the 2011 Census. It was a curious case of the government promising something and then pushing legislation that would render the implementation of that very promise unconstitutional, no less. Whether this was incompetence or duplicity, neither possibility was reassuring. The contradiction unravelled, and the Bills failed. One must now go by the BJP's publicly stated position: which is to maintain the current proportion of individual States in an enlarged Lok Sabha of up to 850 seats. Implementing this position would require a constitutional amendment. This analysis assumes that what the BJP says and what it writes in the draft Bills will be the same, unlike the last time around.

Delimitation leaves the Bharatiya Janata Party with political opportunities and the Congress party with limited options

The Congress is opposed to this position and has a counter-proposal. The Congress wants the current strength of 543 seats in the Lok Sabha, and their distribution among the States, to continue. This too requires a constitutional amendment, and hence, is dead on arrival. As it stands today, the Constitution requires Lok Sabha seats to be reallocated among States on the basis of the 2027 Census. The Congress currently considers the defeat of any BJP amendment as a success, regardless of the assured failure of its own proposal. But it needs to analyse more carefully what that would entail.

The BJP's expansion strategy

What could the BJP's political calculation be? In the absence of a constitutional amendment, the 550 seats possible under the present provisions of the Constitution can be reallocated, to the huge advantage of the heartland States, and potentially, the BJP. That being the reality, why does the BJP strongly push for a larger Lok Sabha? The party wants to increase the number of seats and is even willing to continue with the relative disadvantage of the heartland States unaddressed. That needs an explanation.

The Congress and adjacent entities are opposed to an increase in the strength of the Lok Sabha. The argument is that even if the proportionate strength of each State is maintained, a larger Lok Sabha would widen the disparity in absolute numbers between them. Lok Sabha majorities are determined by absolute numbers and not proportions, it has been argued. For a majority in the Lok Sabha, you need 50% plus one vote for usual majorities; for special majorities, two-thirds is needed. If current proportions are maintained, every State will retain its current relative strength in determining a Lok Sabha majority, and its influence in national politics.

The Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam is willing to support delimitation that maintains the current proportion, regardless of the total numbers. But the party wants clarity on how that will be legislated. The Centre is tightlipped and Mr. Rijiju's latest letter avoids any mention of this. The increase in absolute numbers while maintaining the proportion does not bring evident advantages for the BJP.

So, what might the BJP be calculating? A possibility is that the BJP is wise enough to decipher that pushing peninsular India into further marginalisation is not helpful for national integration or for its own ambition to be a truly national party that has legitimacy in all parts of the country. Therefore, it is willing to keep the proportion intact in exchange for a significant spike in absolute numbers for more populated States.

A second reason is a publicly stated one: the implementation of the women's quota can be done without impacting the existing male members, by adding 50% more seats. Some see a conspiracy to gerrymander constituency borders before the next general election. Another reason is that as demands for caste-based representation grow, expanding the Lok Sabha would create more room to accommodate competing claims. This is particularly relevant considering the BJP's focus on social engineering. The bigger the numbers, the easier it will be for the BJP in its social engineering.

The BJP is in a win-win situation as far as delimitation is concerned. If it manages to pass the amendment, it will have additional seats to play around with in its social engineering. If it cannot pass an amendment, a larger proportion of the existing seats will shift to its strongholds, while keeping its alleged gerrymandering plans equally viable. Any increase, if at all, in the probability of a national BJP majority through delimitation is linked to the reallocation of the seats, and not to an increase in the total number of seats while retaining the current proportion.

The Congress's difficult choices

Where does that leave the Congress? The Congress assumes success in preventing a BJP amendment. It must know that it has no viable path to keeping both the current strength and the shares of individual States intact. The only two options are: first, the number of Lok Sabha seats increases, but the individual share of States remains unchanged through a constitutional amendment, as the BJP says but has not written in a draft legislation. Second, the number of seats does not increase, but the existing seats get reallocated on the basis of the latest Census, leading to a massive slash in the representation of Keralam, Tamil Nadu and other States in similar positions both as absolute numbers and proportion. The BJP will blame the Congress and the Left, if the second option plays out, while reaping the advantage of the additional share in the heartland. The BJP has two good options from its vantage point; the Congress has two bad options to choose from, from its vantage point.

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U.S. midterms — Republicans face growing Blue wave



Anil Raman

A retired Brigadier and a research fellow in the Geopolitics Program of Takshashila Institution

With about 10 days left for the U.S. midterm elections on November 3, talk of a Democratic wave has shifted from opinion polls to voting reality. Every major forecast now predicts the Democrats will win the House of Representatives. Statistician Nate Silver gives them a 75% chance of winning the Senate, which Republicans held strongly just a month ago. The Grand Old Party faces five main problems: a President who is a liability, weak candidates, money not swaying voters, fissures in their heartland, and a party base turning against its own.

A President on the defensive

Let us begin with the President. Midterms are often a verdict on the White House. Donald Trump has made this election about himself, telling crowds to "pretend I'm on the ballot". His approval rating is below 40%. In September, he told Republicans in tight races that he would visit "every one of those 35 places". But he has campaigned in fewer than a third. Most stops have been in States he won easily, such as Oklahoma, Alabama, Tennessee, and Montana, which he said was his way "to thank them". When a President rallies supporters in States that he won by huge margins two years earlier instead of margin seats, it conveys a hint of desperation.

The next issue is candidate quality. Texas has not elected a Democrat to the Senate since 1988. This year, the Republican nominee is Ken Paxton, who was impeached by the Texas House in 2023 and later acquitted by the State Senate. He was also observed partying in 2025 in Dubai with two Pakistani-American federal fugitives who were also his donors. His Democratic opponent, James Talarico, a former teacher and State legislator, was leading by two points in a Fox News poll (but the latest Fox News poll listed for October 15-19 showed a 49%-49% tie); and by three points in a University of Texas poll (September 25-October 5).

The third problem is in the heartland. Kansas has sent only Republicans to this Senate seat since 1919, the longest streak for any party in U.S. history. Republican incumbent Roger Marshall is tied in the polls with Adam Hamilton, a Methodist pastor who started one of the country's largest churches. In Nebraska – a State Mr. Trump won by over 20 points – Democrats have stepped aside for Dan Osborn, a former union leader running as an independent. He is about three points behind Senator Pete Ricketts. When a party spends the last two weeks defending strongholds of Kansas and Nebraska, it is on the back foot.

Multiple Republican vulnerabilities are strengthening Democratic hopes

The fourth issue is money. Elon Musk, who split from Mr. Trump last year, is now the biggest known donor in this election, having given over $276 million to Republican groups since July. Recent filings show that Mr. Musk gave $158 million to the Senate Leadership Fund and a separate $10 million to Lone Star Liberty PAC, which supports Mr. Paxton's Senate campaign. Even so, Mr. Talarico, the Democratic candidate, is still ahead. Money can buy TV advertisements, but it cannot easily overcome a national mood shaped by high prices, an unpopular war with Iran, and immigration raids.

The lesson from Ohio

Ohio combines these issues, making it the most revealing race. Vivek Ramaswamy, a former presidential candidate backed by Mr. Trump, seemed confirmed for Governor in a State that the President has won three times. His opponent, Amy Acton, looked like an easy target. As Ohio's highly unpopular health director during the COVID-19 pandemic, she ordered lockdowns, faced armed protesters at her home, and had Republicans try to strip her powers before she resigned in 2020. Mr. Ramaswamy and his supporters have spent about $101 million on advertisements, including $36 million of his own money, about three times what Ms. Acton has spent. Still, he was trailing her recently by about three points on average. Among independent voters, his net rating is minus 25, the lowest for a Republican candidate for Governor in Ohio this century.

This week, his campaign announced plans to spend $4 million promoting an advertisement featuring Ms. Acton's estranged mother calling her a liar, drawing criticism from Republicans, including Governor Mike DeWine and Senator Jon Husted.

Much of this can be explained by the national mood, since the party's Senate candidate in Ohio is also behind by a similar amount. But some of Mr. Ramaswamy's problems come from within his own party. His rival in the Republican primary, Casey Putsch, posted a video of himself with a rifle inviting him to play "cowboys versus Indians". He called Mr. Ramaswamy an "anchor baby" and said that there was "nothing remotely American" about him. Still, nearly one in five Republican primary voters picked Mr. Putsch. Far-right commentator Nick Fuentes told his followers to oppose Mr. Ramaswamy, while students at a conservative youth event questioned whether a Hindu could represent a Christian State. The anger goes back to the H-1B controversy in December 2024, when Mr. Ramaswamy said American culture undervalued excellence, which angered 'Make America Great Again' (MAGA) voters. Now, the same party that once questioned who belongs in America is asking the same question about its own candidate.

Self-inflicted wounds

Ohio is an apt lesson for the Republicans. A party can get through having an unpopular President, a weak candidate, or a tough electoral map in any given year. But it is much harder when all these problems happen at once and the party's base starts judging its own candidates by their race, background and religion. If Democrats win Texas, Kansas, Nebraska, or Ohio on November 3, it will be a wave, and the Republicans will have helped make it. Perhaps they deserve that loss.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Persistent confrontation

It is a matter of serious concern that confrontations with Chinese troops continue to occur along the border, despite several rounds of consultations (Front page, "ITBP D-G says face-off with China continues in Arunachal Pradesh", October 23). While continuing talks with China to resolve border issues is important, Beijing's duplicitous approach should be brought to the attention of Chinese interlocutors. Further, it is unfortunate that India's imports from China have been growing rapidly and the trade deficit with its neighbour has widened in recent years. Unrestrained imports from a neighbour that continues to be confrontational along the border could embolden it to pursue even more aggressive border activities inimical to India's interests.

Kosaraju Chandramouli,
Hyderabad

Coffee first, tourism second

The feature, "Karnataka's coffee country: Inside its most immersive plantation stays" (October 23), shows coffee country discovering that the view can pay better than the crop. That trade-off needs watching. A plantation stay succeeds because the plantation itself works — the pruning, the pickers and the processing. Estates that convert too much land into accommodation risk discovering that the real attraction was the agriculture. Used well, tourism is a hedge against coffee price fluctuations, not a replacement for coffee cultivation. The estates most likely to endure are those where guests buy the beans as well as the bed, and where the ledger still puts coffee first. Income from stays that is reinvested in shade trees and soil health strengthens the attraction; income that merely adds more rooms dilutes it.

Jackie Omotalade,
Pittsburgh, U.S.

Postal services

Though communication has shifted to digital platforms, we must remember generations who depended on letters to connect with loved ones. The red letterbox symbolised bonds that united people across distances. The dedication of postal staff deserves appreciation throughout the year, not merely on October 10.

A.P. Thiruvadi,
Chennai

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address.



Police personnel deployed at the Chorbagan Sorbojanin Durga Puja pandal following a stampede, in Kolkata. PTI

Death in the time of Durga Puja

On October 17, a stampede broke out at a Durga Puja pandal in north Kolkata, claiming 19 lives. The pandal, erected in a narrow space with dim lighting, was filled with people soon after it started raining. **Shrabana Chatterjee** and **Shiv Sahay Singh** report on the lapses that led to the tragedy and the questions it has raised about accountability in West Bengal, where the new government's first Durga Puja celebrations have been marred by controversy

On the evening of October 17, Subham Sonkar, 32, was out pandal-hopping with a cousin, both of them dressed in festive finery. It was Saptami, the day of elaborate ritual worship of goddess Durga, when crowds throng the pandals. As a sudden, sharp spell of rain sent people rushing into the Chorbagan Sorbojanin Durga Puja pandal in north Kolkata, pandemonium broke out and the two cousins got separated. While Sonkar died in the crush, the cousin she was with survived.

Vishal Bhel, another cousin, was not at the pandal at the time. He received a call from an unknown number asking him to reach Medical College Kolkata, about one-and-a-half kilometres away from the pandal. Bhel stood shell-shocked outside the emergency building around midnight, having just seen Sonkar's body. "People had walked all over her after she had fallen down," he said. "Her whole body was bruised and her face looked like she had been in a lot of pain. I can't believe how a happy Durga Puja moment turned into her last moment on earth in just a second."



Scores of family members of the injured and deceased waited in nervous anticipation and grief as the rest of the city continued to celebrate. A woman sitting at the gate of the emergency building was inconsolable. "Call me Ma one last time," she cried. "I have nothing left to live for. Please call me Ma one last time, I beg you."

A few hours earlier, her daughter, Piyali Pramanik, 25, had made a video call to her mother when she was on her way to pandal-hop. Three members of the family died in the tragedy: Pramanik; her sister-in-law, 37-year-old Tager Bhej, and Bhej's child, 14-year-old Sandip. Both Pramanik and Bhej were from Purba Bardhaman district and had travelled 100 km to participate in the festivities in West Bengal's capital, where every year, temporary structures are turned into elaborate works of art, streets glow with lights, the sound of drums fills the air, and food stalls sell delicious Bengali *bhog* (food offering).

The stampede also claimed the lives of both parents of 25-year-old Pritish Ghosh, a resident of Kolkata's Baranagar area. Dilip Ghosh (59) and Dipali Ghosh (45) had gone to the puja pandal; neither survived. Moved by the plight of the young man, West Bengal Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari offered to become his guardian.

Among the 19 people who lost their lives in the stampede that occurred at 7:40 p.m., according to the police, 13 were female and six were male. Four were minors. Twenty-five others were injured. Preliminary post-mortem reports at the Kolkata Police morgue attributed most of the deaths to traumatic asphyxia caused by chest compression.

Mismanagement at the pandal

The Chorbagan Sorbojanin Durga Puja pandal was inaugurated by Chief Minister Adhikari on October 12 and generated a lot of attention on social media as a must-visit spot for puja revellers.

> There were no policemen and there was no security. The organisers made wrong announcements and spread panic, which led to the stampede.
> **RUNU DAS**
> Resident, Chorbagan area

The theme of the pandal was 'Aarav-Beyond Sound'. In the narrow by-lanes of north Kolkata, the artist of the pandal had created an even narrower, darker space, inviting revellers to experience silence in the presence of the goddess. Inside the pandal, the grey idol of goddess Durga rose nearly 10 metres above the ground. With 10 hands, two of them holding lotus flowers, she sat silently in *padmasana* or the lotus pose.

The pandal was in its 91st year. Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) leaders had taken over the organising committee only three months ago, following the party's victory in West Bengal. The pandal's publicity material, widely circulated in the public domain, identifies BJP Jorasanko MLA Vijay Ojha as the puja committee chairman; BJP north Kolkata district president Tamaghna Ghosh as its chief adviser; and Debdeep Adhikari, nephew of Chief Minister Adhikari, as its chief patron.

Several eyewitnesses and Adhikari claimed that a misleading announcement by the pandal organisers, accompanied by whistle-blowing, had triggered panic. "You all should leave at once; the pandal can collapse any moment," said the announcer, according to videos making the rounds on social media. In another set of videos, people can be seen holding umbrellas and entering the pandal minutes before the crowd crush.

The road leading to the pandal was not more than 16 feet wide and a part of it had been bifurcated for the movement of VIPs. "They only allowed VIPs to walk through, so where was the average person supposed to go?" an angry resident, who had helped in rescue and relief efforts, said to the media.

Rajesh Srivastava, a resident of Agarpara in Kolkata, who survived the stampede, said people had been packed inside the pandal for almost 30 minutes. "There was major mismanagement by the organisers. When it started to rain, more people rushed into the pandal. They were pushing in from one side, while bodies lay on the other," said Srivastava, who was discharged from a private hospital on October 19. "There were no policemen at the site for at least 45 minutes."



An ambulance carrying Durga Puja pandal stampede victims stops in front of the emergency building of Medical College Kolkata. AFP

Runu Das, a local resident of the Chorbagan area, said that the injured were taken away on bikes, in taxis, and in cars belonging to local residents. "There were no policemen and there was no security. The organisers made wrong announcements and spread panic, which led to the stampede," she said.

Nibha Kumari, from Muzaffarpur in Bihar, lost her husband, Abhishek Srivastava, 38, and their 7-year-old son, Ayansh. Lying on a hospital bed in Kolkata, Kumari cried while regretting her decision to go pandal-hopping. "There were no policemen to help transport my husband and child to the hospital," she said.

The West Bengal government constituted a Special Investigation Team (SIT) led by Justice (retd.) Anindita Roy Saraswati to conduct an impartial and comprehensive inquiry into the tragedy. On October 22, five days after the crush, the chairperson and other members of the SIT visited the puja pandal. She pointed out that the lighting inside was woefully inadequate. "It goes without saying that the entrance and exit to the pandal are very narrow, and if a lot of people enter the pandal, an incident is bound to happen," she told mediapersons.

On the same day, the Kolkata Police arrested Sanjeev Raha, who had allegedly been responsible for making announcements at the pandal when the stampede broke out.

By October 23, they had arrested nine people in connection with a suo motu case registered at Girish Park police station. Those arrested and charged with culpable homicide not amounting to murder, among other offences, included Durga Puja committee secretary Raj Kumar Sewda (48), vice-president Santanu Dubey (55), and others responsible for the construction of the pandal's bamboo structure, crowd control and management, and private security.

The police did not take any of the senior BJP leaders named in the pandal's publicity material into custody.

A string of controversies

The Durga Puja celebrations were meant to be special for the BJP government, which had come to power in May this year with a two-thirds majority, ending the previous government's 15-year tenure. Chief Minister Adhikari repeatedly stated that the celebrations would follow tradition and the ritual calendar, accusing the previous government of violating religious practices. Adhikari said that the number of Durga Puja pandals across the State had increased by 25%, from 45,000 in 2025 to 57,400 in 2026.

However, the festival has been mired in controversy from the outset in 2026. Almost a month before the celebrations, Dhirendra Shastri, alias Bageshwar Baba, a godman from Madhya Pradesh, urged Bengalis to switch to a vegetarian diet during Durga Puja.

His remarks did not go down well in the State. A *bonedi bari* (aristocratic household) in north Kolkata's Sovabazar area said that its Durga Puja would continue according to traditions established by its ancestors, and that it would not abide by any diktats from "outsiders".

"She (Durga) is our Ma, our goddess. This is our tradition. Why would we listen to someone who does not belong to this tradition," asked Prabir Krishna Deb, an eighth-generation descendant of Raja Naba Krishna Deb, who started the Sobhabazar Rajbari pujas.

Deb belongs to the *choto torof* (younger branch) of the family, whose pujas began in 1790. He added that while some of their offerings to the goddess are vegetarian, the family eats mutton and fish during the festivities.

The widespread anger against Shastri's remarks prompted the BJP leadership, including the Chief Minister, to publicly consume a fish offering to convey the message that no one could lecture Bengalis on their dietary preferences.

A few weeks ago, the city's flyovers were painted in rainbow colours as part of the Durga Puja beautification drive. Urban Development Minister Agnimitra Paul, who oversaw the painting, had described it as a symbol of brotherhood and love. However, when motorcyclists began skidding on them, the administration went into damage-control mode, attempting to scrub off the paint and install cat's-eye reflectors. Paul said, "The paint that was used was supposed to be anti-skid paint. But since a few bikes still skid, we are now removing the paint. We are also probing how the accidents took place."

The Durga Puja festivities were also marked by attacks on temporary book stalls set up by Left parties at puja pandals. The Left parties have a tradition of setting up book stalls at the pandals, even though their supporters do not participate in the ritual aspects of Durga Puja. While State BJP president Samik Bhattacharya and Finance Minister Swapan Dasgupta denounced the attacks on the stalls, Chief Minister Adhikari said that Left parties did not believe in Durga Puja or any other Hindu festival and had no business setting up book stalls at the pandals.

However, no controversy cast as long a shadow over Durga Puja in 2026 as the Chorbagan stampede. Celebrations were cancelled at the Chorbagan pandal, where the tragedy took place, and the site and pandal came under investigation. Adhikari visited the families of each of the deceased and handed them compensation cheques of ₹25 lakh.

When tragedy struck the north Kolkata puja pandal, Adhikari and senior BJP leaders were receiving Union Home Minister Amit Shah, who had several festival-related events lined up for October 18. Shah had to cancel his plans and return to Delhi that day after meeting the injured. The Chief Minister continued to emphasise how, unlike the previous government, his government had extended all possible support to those caught up in the stampede. Yet, the prevailing sentiment after the tragedy was that the State had never witnessed such a high number of casualties in a stampede during Durga Puja.

"This is a complete administrative failure," said Suman Roy Chaudhuri, a senior Congress leader. "As a north Kolkata resident, I can tell you that there were hardly any police personnel on the ground. This is a sorrow-filled puja. History will remember this."

No joy left

Durga Puja is the most auspicious time of the year for Bengalis, and deaths during the festivities have left people across the State heartbroken. One of the most iconic depictions of the loss of a loved one around the time of the festival is the death of young Durga in Satyajit Ray's classic *Pather Panchali,* shortly before Durga Puja.

From the morning of October 18, relatives of the deceased began queuing up outside the Kolkata Police mortuary, behind another famous Durga Puja pandal at Mohammad Ali Park. A government official called out the names of the deceased, matching them with the serial numbers on the hearse vans as the bodies were loaded.

People looked on, shaking their heads in disbelief. Tears rolled down their cheeks. Amid the smell of the bodies, the strong scent of incense sticks hung heavy in the air.

"We are all in mourning. There is no joy left in Durga Puja," a bystander said at the morgue.

At Medical College Kolkata, Biswajit Biswas, the father of Tamina Biswas, 18, still cannot believe that his daughter is dead. With his wife by his side, he said, "How will we survive after this? There will be no Durga Puja for us ever again."

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From Page One

LAC 'disturbed' by PLA's behaviour, admits MEA

Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge asked PM to explain the "continuing face-offs" between Indian and Chinese troops at several locations along the Arunachal Pradesh border, questioning whether India's patrolling access had been compromised and whether the pre-May 2020 status quo had been restored.

In a post on X, Mr. Kharge said the confirmation by the chief of ITBP forces stationed at the LAC was "deeply alarming". He alleged that Mr. Modi's June 2020 statement that no one had entered Indian territory after the Galwan clashes had emboldened China.

Congress media and publicity department chairman, Pawan Khera, commended the ITBP's 'Shaurya Commandos' for handling the confrontations with China, but accused the government of suppressing information from the border. "The fact that China entered our territory does not bother [the government]; what bothers them is that this has been reported," he said.

The Congress questioned the government's easing of restrictions on Chinese investment and the growing trade deficit.

"India's trade deficit with China zoomed even further to a record $112 billion in 2025-26, up from $99 billion the previous year. This has simply crushed our MSMEs in many industries," Congress leader Jairam Ramesh said in a post, adding, "Make in India has become Import from China. This staggering trade deficit is in itself a very significant threat to our economic security."

Students, activists rally in Delhi against SIR, CEC

Representatives of student organisations, including the All India Students' Association, All India Students' Federation, Students' Federation of India, Krantikari Yuva Sangathan and All India Democratic Students' Organisation, also participated.

Mr. Singh said the Samyukt Kisan Morcha (SKM) decided to support the movement after the protesters, particularly women, were manhandled during earlier demonstrations in Delhi.

Annie Raja accused the Centre of using the SIR exercise to undermine constitutional safeguards and said the protests would continue until the CEC stepped down.

"From Kashmir to Kanyakumari, and from the Northeast to Gujarat, people are organising their own Jantar Mantars. Even if the authorities restrict one protest site, people will find ways to make their voices heard," she said.

Barricades halt march

The protesters began marching towards the ECI but were stopped by multiple barricades and security personnel on Ashoka Road, around 500 metres into the march. They briefly sat down on the road as police personnel warned them about the prohibitory orders imposed under Section 163 of BNSS. The police subsequently pushed the protesters back towards the main road, using whistles and repeated warnings about detention for violating the restrictions. As slogans continued, several protesters were taken away in two detention vehicles near the Gol Dak Khana roundabout. Separately, the SKM said farmers held demonstrations at district and tehsil headquarters across the country, demanding that the SIR be scrapped and Mr. Kumar be sacked and prosecuted.

Govt. to revise labour survey to track gig, household work

Periodic Labour Force Survey to identify households with at least one digital platform worker; it will also have questions to capture engagement in caregiving activities and unpaid trainee work

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Union government has decided to change the design and structure of the Periodic Labour Force Survey (PLFS) to track digital platform workers and capture engagement in unpaid household, caregiving, volunteer, and trainee work. The PLFS will also include additional questions to measure labour underutilisation.

According to a press release and concept note issued here on Friday, the National Sample Survey Office (NSSO), under the Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation (MoSPI), has proposed modifications to the PLFS sampling design starting January 2027. The survey schedule will also change.

The Ministry has invited comments and suggestions from policymakers, researchers, academic institutions, and the public within 15 days from Friday.



Hidden labour: The revised labour survey aims to better capture the economic contribution of women's unpaid work. IMRAN NISSAR

A separate Second Stage Stratum (SSS) will be introduced in the PLFS to identify households with at least one digital platform worker. An additional entry will be added to the questionnaire to determine whether any member of the household has engaged in digital platform work during the specified reference period. "There will be four SSSs in rural areas and five in urban areas, with 14 households canvassed in each selected First Stage Unit (FSU). This revision in SSS formation is expected to improve the coverage of digital platform workers and facilitate more comprehensive data collection on this emerging segment of the labour market," the press release said.

Concept note

According to the concept note, a large proportion of women in India spend considerable time on unpaid household and caregiving activities, such as cooking, cleaning, childcare, and caring for elderly, sick, or disabled family members.

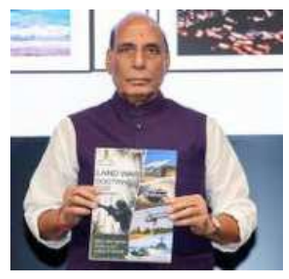
"While such activities contribute significantly to household well-being and facilitate the participation of other household members in paid employment, they have not been measured separately in PLFS until now," it noted, adding that specific questions will be incorporated to capture engagement in own-use production of goods, and unpaid household and caregiving activities.

Additionally, the criteria for sample allocation and stratification have been updated.

"These revisions are expected to improve the efficiency of sample allocation and ensure better representation of population variations, which in turn will minimise operational difficulties during sample selection," the release said.

Army needs flexibility with long-term vision, says Defence Minister

Saurabh Trivedi
NEW DELHI



Rajnath Singh

Defence Minister Rajnath Singh on Friday called on the Army's senior leadership to develop a long-term strategic vision for the next 20-30 years while remaining prepared to respond to immediate and emerging security challenges amid a changing geopolitical and regional environment.

Addressing the Army Commanders' Conference in New Delhi, Mr. Singh stressed the need for dynamic and flexible strategies that can be adjusted to evolving circumstances. He released the *Land Warfare Doctrine*, which provides an overarching framework for preparing the Army to address the evolving character of warfare and future conflicts.

Mr. Singh also called for an integrated approach to modern warfare, emphasising that land operations and ground forces would remain indispensable despite the growing significance of air, maritime, space, and cyber domains.

Commending the armed forces for adapting to changing operational requirements, the Defence Minister said innovative thinking, enhanced synergy, improved coordination, and advanced weaponry had contributed to the success of Operation Sindoor. The operation had sent a clear message that India would not hesitate to take necessary measures to safeguard its national interests, he said. He credited the armed forces' valour, discipline, preparedness, and restraint, along with Prime Minister Narendra Modi's diplomatic efforts for strengthening India's global standing.

NIA case: Delhi court allows accused to extend stay abroad

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

A Delhi court on Friday allowed a U.S. citizen and six Ukrainian nationals linked to the Myanmar arms training case to stay outside India until February 24, 2027. The seven accused were arrested by the National Investigation Agency (NIA) earlier this year.

Special Judge Prashant Sharma of the Patiala House Court passed the order after considering applications filed by the seven accused seeking an extension of their overseas stay.

U.S. national Matthew Aaron VanDyke was arrested by the NIA at Kolkata airport on March 13. The six Ukrainians – Hurba Petro, Slyviak Taras, Ivan Sukmanovskyi, Stefankiv Marian, Honcharuk Maksim and Kaminskyi Viktor – were arrested at airports in Delhi and Lucknow. The accused entered India on tourist visas and travelled to the northeastern region without obtaining mandatory permits. Investigators alleged that they subsequently crossed from Mizoram into Myanmar, where they trained ethnic armed organisations.

The NIA initially invoked provisions of the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act. The agency also claimed that the accused were involved in assembling equipment linked to an alleged plot targeting a passenger aircraft in Myanmar.

However, the agency did not include the UAPA provisions in its initial chargesheet.

At least four dead in blast in Bihar's Siwan district

Amarnath Tewary
PATNA

At least four people were killed in a massive blast at a house where firecrackers were being made in Bihar's Siwan district on Friday.

The area has been cordoned off for security reasons, Siwan Superintendet of Police Bharat Soni said, adding that the toll could increase.

Rescue operations led by town Sub-Divisional Officer (SDO) Ashutosh Kumar Gupta are under way, while top police officials reached the blast site.

According to people in the neighbourhood, the blast occurred at the residence of Mohd. Amaruddin Mian, at whose house manufacturing of firecrackers has been going on for several years.

Audio clip on '₹500-crore' payment to activist will be probed: Maharashtra CM

Vinaya Deshpande Pandit
MUMBAI

Maharashtra Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis on Friday broke his silence over Maratha activist Manoj Jarange Patil recently releasing an audio clip which claimed that Deputy Chief Minister Eknath Shinde allegedly took ₹500 crore from the Bharatiya Janata Party to hand it over to him to stop his agitation. Mr. Patil said that he had neither received the money nor would he stop the agitation.

The Chief Minister said that the purported audio clip will be sent for forensic examination and that the truth will be brought out. The Opposition hit out at the government seeking a thorough probe in the matter. Shiv Sena (UBT) leader Sanjay Raut challenged Union Minister Amit Shah and the Central agencies to investigate the claim. Mr. Shinde has already denied the allegations while his party's delegation has also met the Chief Minister to seek a probe in the matter.



Devendra Fadnavis

"We are all wondering why this clip has been leaked after 2.5 years. What is the purpose behind it? There is a demand for a thorough probe not just by Jarange Patil, but also by the Shiv Sena, but also by the BJP. We will bring out the truth in the matter," Mr. Fadnavis said.

Sources in the BJP have admitted that the 2.5-year old clip has damaged its image among the Maratha community and has upset its alliance partners. "There were some squabbles which already existed. This has only added to them. It is damaging for the alliance. Not just that, it is damaging for the party too. It has distanced us further from the Maratha community. But it will not lead to anything. We have strong numbers," a senior BJP leader said on condition of anonymity.

Navy to host Indo-Pacific meet from November 3

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Indian Navy will host the 2026 edition of the Indo-Pacific Regional Dialogue in New Delhi from November 3 to 5, bringing together maritime practitioners, scientists, academicians, policymakers, and experts from 18 countries to explore cooperation in science, technology, and research, a Defence Ministry release said on Friday.

Defence Minister Rajnath Singh is scheduled to deliver the commemorative address on the opening day of the event which will focus on the theme "Science, Technology, and Academic Cooperation in the Indo-Pacific".

The discussions at the Navy's principal strategic outreach initiative will seek to identify practical measures to strengthen regional cooperation in maritime research, ocean governance, climate resilience, and emerging technologies, against the backdrop of growing maritime vulnerabilities.

Ariha is receiving cultural exposure, learning Hindi: govt.

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI



The Ministry said that Ariha's mother, in picture, and father are visiting her regularly.

Ariha Shah, an Indian child in foster care in Germany, has started speaking some Hindi words, and her parents are visiting her regularly, the Ministry of External Affairs said on Friday.

"This is an issue to which we are attaching considerable importance. Our embassy in Berlin has been in regular contact with Ariha, and as part of our consular visits, they have been regularly visiting the baby," MEA spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal said, in response to a query from the media.

"As I told you before, we have organised Hindi classes for her cultural immersion, along with temple visits and several other cultural exposures. She has started to speak some Hindi words. Her parents are also visiting her regularly, last on October 13. We remain committed to the welfare of the child," Mr. Jaiswal said.

During then-German Chancellor Olaf Scholz's India visit in October 2024, Ariha's case was raised at a meeting between Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Mr. Scholz, Foreign Secretary Vikram Misri had told presspersons then.

Mr. Misri also said that the German Chancellor assured the Prime Minister that he was "very closely following" the issue.

Born in 2021, Ariha was placed in foster care in September that year after she suffered an accidental injury, with allegations of physical abuse.

Her parents, Bhavesh and Dhara Shah, are from Mira Bhayander in Maharashtra's Thane district.

Jaishankar visits Azerbaijan to ease strain in ties over Operation Sindoor

Kallol Bhattacherjee
NEW DELHI

External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar on Friday met Azerbaijani President Ilham Aliyev in Baku and said the visit charted a "pathway" for the future of bilateral ties. The meeting comes more than a year after relations between India and Azerbaijan deteriorated over the latter's opposition to India's Operation Sindoor against Pakistan.

Mr. Jaishankar also met his counterpart Jayhun Bayramov, who said the two countries had "different view points on different issues" earlier, but highlighted new areas of cooperation such as energy, and tourism after what he described as a "fruitful discussion".

"We have common interest in really promoting peace and progress and prosperity. And threats like terrorism, conflict, and instability are our common enemies," Mr. Jaishankar said in his remarks to the media after the meeting with Mr. Bayramov.

"Delighted to welcome the External Affairs Minister of India, Dr. S. Jaishankar, to exchange views on the current state and prospects of Azerbaijan-India relations, including political dialogue, trade and investment, energy, tourism and cultural ties," said Mr. Bayramov, emphasising "continued dialogue and exploration of opportunities for cooperation in areas of mutual interest".



External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar meets Azerbaijani President Ilham Aliyev in Baku on Friday. AFP

Way forward

"Our talks charted a pathway forward for our relationship. Agreed to deepen political consultations, exchange visits, enhance economic activities, build connectivity and foster people-to-people ties," Mr. Jaishankar said. He also extended India's support to the peace process between Azerbaijan and Armenia.

The statement is the first major conciliatory step from the Indian side since Azerbaijan had expressed concern over the India-initiated Operation Sindoor of May 2025.

Azerbaijan Foreign Ministry had, on May 7, 2025, condemned the Indian strikes against Pakistan-based terror targets. "We condemn military attacks against the Islamic Republic of Pakistan that killed and injured several civilians," the Azerbaijani Ministry had said.

Kashmir issue

Azerbaijan has also been vocal on the Kashmir issue at the international level, often calling for its "resolution". Mr. Bayramov in his remarks on Friday downplayed the differences between the two sides. "We have touched upon a number of issues. I believe Azerbaijan-India relations are on their way to developing to a higher level," said Mr. Bayramov.

Mr. Jaishankar's visit to Baku is the first bilateral visit by an Indian External Affairs Minister in eight years. The late External Affairs Minister Sushma Swaraj had visited Azerbaijan in April 2018 for a Non-Aligned Movement (NAM) Ministerial meeting.

Official sources here described the remarks from both sides on Friday as a sign of "diplomatic reset" as India expects to exert pressure on Turkiye and Pakistan by drawing Azerbaijan close.

Will continue to help with critical drugs for Iran: govt.

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) has denied Iranian media reports claiming that India rejected Tehran's request to transport life-saving medicines. It said the two sides remain in contact on the matter as part of a humanitarian effort.

"We remain in contact with our Iranian counterparts to facilitate the transport of life-saving medicines as a humanitarian gesture," Ministry spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal said at a press conference

The clarification followed reports in Iranian media quoting Taher Abdolhay, managing director of Iran Air (Homa), who said on October 19 that the airline was unable to import medicines because India and Singapore had not granted flight permits for Iranian aircraft. "A proposal to transport medicines, including on passenger flights, was submitted, but permits for cargo were not granted," he added.

Supriya Sule alleges use of spy cams in Maharashtra polls

Vinaya Deshpande Pandit
MUMBAI


Supriya Sule

NCP-SP leader Supriya Sule on Friday alleged the use of spy cams during voting for the Legislative Council polls for the Pune Teachers and Graduates constituencies. She said there were accusations that the ruling BJP was using pens equipped with spy cams for distributing money.

"Voters are reporting that such pens are being placed in their pockets, a video is recorded of them casting their vote for the BJP candidate, and after voting, upon showing the video, the promised money is handed over – this is the kind of activity that is underway," she posted on her social media handle X.

Calling these complaints "extremely serious and concerning," she appealed to the Election Commission and the government to take note of them. "It jeopardises the secrecy of voting and independence of voters. Practices that trample upon the fundamental principles of democracy must not be tolerated under any circumstances," she said.

She tagged the Election Commission, Maharashtra State Election Commission and the Chief Minister's Office in her post. Elections to the Legislative Council are conducted by the Chief Electoral Office of Maharashtra.

However, sources in the Maharashtra CEO said there was no formal complaint in the matter so far. "We have not received any complaints. If there are such allegations, we will ask the booth-level staff not to allow pens in the voting centre. Pens are not needed inside," the sources said.

Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis said he was not aware of what a spy pen is. "If Supriya *tai* sends me the details, I will look into it," he said.

AI tools to be used to verify attendance in jobs scheme

The upgraded National Mobile Monitoring System used to capture attendance of workers will now have anti-tampering features, enhanced face verification to confirm on-site presence, says Minister

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI


The new features will help in identifying suspicious photographs or the repeated use of same images from worksites. ARUN KULKARNI

With an aim to plug the gaps that allegedly allowed misuse of the mobile-based application used to capture workers' attendance under the rural employment programme, Viksit Bharat-Guarantee for Rozgar and Ajeevika Mission Gramin (VB-G RAM G), Union Rural Development Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan on Friday announced that an upgraded version with AI-based verification and other enhanced security features that safeguard against tampering and fraudulent attendance, will be used.

Mr. Chouhan, according to a statement issued by the Press Information Bureau (PIB), said the government's priority while ensuring employment for rural workers was to "protect their wages and ensure that public funds were used transparently and for their intended purpose".

Face authentication was introduced in the National Mobile Monitoring System in March 2026 as the Ministry's response to concerns over fake attendance, under MGNREGA, that preceded the current rural programme.

However, despite the face authentication provision, in many cases "photo-to-photo capturing instead of live work images" was being done. There were also mismatches between the actual and recorded worker count. Discrepancies in the gender composition of workers were found at several worksites. Cases of the same photograph of workers appearing in multiple muster rolls, as well as mismatches between workers in morning and afternoon photographs, were also detected.

The latest version, Mr. Chouhan said, includes safeguards against cloning and tampering, along with liveness detection. "These features are designed to verify that the person appearing before the camera is a real, live worker rather than a dummy image or an old photograph. AI-based face verification has also been refined to account for differences across States and geographical regions," he said.

Apart from this, the government has also put in place a "multi-layered verification system" to ensure that payments correspond to genuine work. The system includes an AI-based photo de-duplication module that identifies suspicious or repeated photographs. The Minister explained that where such entries are detected, the wage list and Fund Transfer Order are automatically withheld until the necessary checks are completed.

Offline attendance

Mr. Chouhan also clarified that in areas where network connectivity is unavailable at a worksite, attendance can be recorded offline. An authorised exception mechanism is also available when face authentication fails for elderly workers or persons with disabilities, or when a mobile device encounters technical problems.

Scrap SIR exercise, urge scientists in letter to ECI, Centre

Jacob Koshy
NEW DELHI

A collective of independent scientists has petitioned the Election Commission of India (ECI) and the government to scrap the special intensive revision (SIR) of electoral rolls. They have demanded the immediate restoration of all eligible voters wrongly excluded.

The open letter, as of Friday, was signed by scores of researchers and academics from institutions including the Indian Institute of Science; Indian Institute of Technology, Delhi; Indian Institute of Science Education and Research, Kolkata; Institute of Mathematical Sciences, Chennai, and International Centre for Theoretical Sciences, Bengaluru. The signatories say they have endorsed the statement in their individual capacities, and that their views are personal and do not represent their institutions.

About 13 crore names have been removed from electoral rolls across the country under SIR, sparking mass protests and demands by Opposition parties and youth groups to remove the Chief Election Commissioner, Gyanesh Kumar. After weeks of protests, the ECI has ordered fresh verification in some States and Union Territories, including Delhi.

The scientists said that names of eligible voters, especially the poor and migrant workers, and marginalised communities, are being deleted arbitrarily, and affected citizens face cumbersome procedures. They said that there are inadequate safeguards for restoring names to the rolls and that citizens are denied a meaningful opportunity to establish their eligibility. They underlined that the SIR lacks transparency and accountability. The letter draws a parallel with the legal presumption of innocence, arguing that no genuine revision can strip citizens of their vote through such procedures.

"The right to vote is a fundamental pillar of democracy," the signatories said, adding that "democracy cannot survive when citizens are denied their voice."

Punjab CM seeks probe into electoral roll revision

The Hindu Bureau
CHANDIGARH

The Punjab Assembly on Friday passed an official resolution seeking an independent probe into alleged irregularities surrounding electoral processes and the functioning of the Election Commission of India.

Taking part in the discussion on the resolution in the Assembly, Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann demanded the scrapping of the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls, calling for an impartial investigation into the process.

He alleged the BJP was manipulating electoral rolls in the name of the Election Commission by adding votes in its favour and deleting those of the Opposition, and claimed that elections in Bihar, West Bengal, Haryana and Maharashtra had been won through vote theft.

Meanwhile, noisy scenes were witnessed in the Punjab Assembly as Congress MLAs stormed the Well of the House, demanding the resignation of the Chief Minister, blaming the government for failing to tackle law and order, curb drugs, and rein in gangsterism.

Congress members staged a walkout as they continued to protest.

Congress, allies aim to create 'anarchy' through protest: BJP

Devesh K. Pandey
NEW DELHI


Sudhanshu Trivedi

The Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) on Friday accused the Congress and its allies of choosing November 1 for organising another round of protests in Delhi to foment "anarchy", drawing a parallel with the 1984 anti-Sikh riots.

At a press conference, BJP MP and spokesperson Sudhanshu Trivedi referred to the anti-Sikh violence in Delhi that had followed the assassination of the then Prime Minister Indira Gandhi on October 31, 1984. "They are once again going to hold a protest in Delhi on November 1. In other words, they want to remind people that, just as they pushed Delhi into chaos in 1984, they are again nurturing the thought of creating anarchy on the streets of Delhi on the same day," he claimed.

Mr. Trivedi targeted the Leader of Opposition in Lok Sabha, Rahul Gandhi, describing him as a "failed product". Referring to his reported remarks in the past that his "fight" was also against the Indian state, the BJP leader accused him of undermining constitutional institutions based on false charges.

"Whether it is Europe, France, Italy, or Albania, troublemakers can be seen creating disturbances. However, nowhere do we see the Leader of the Opposition holding a sit-in outside the Prime Minister's residence or entering Akashvani building. India alone is such a case where the Congress party is going to such lengths...," he said.

He described the party as an "executor" for those planning to spread chaos in India, to gain power.

Mr. Trivedi claimed that despite several attempts, the Congress could not establish Mr. Gandhi as its leader and that he had not been able to deliver the expected electoral successes. He questioned the party's internal working and alleged that it had failed to promote younger leaders and was still stuck in "dynastic politics". He pointed out that in the 2024 Lok Sabha elections, the Congress won only 99 seats.

SC backs voters' right to prosecute candidates

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court has held in a judgment that ordinary private citizens can file criminal complaints against candidates for giving false information or concealing information while filing their nomination papers for an election.

The judgment by a Bench of Justices Dipankar Datta and Sheel Nagu said the law does not insist that only public servants or competent authorities were eligible to lodge complaints against electoral candidates.

The court's judgment empowers the vigilant citizen-voter with the *locus standi* to directly act against dishonesty in electoral politics, and ensure transparency in polls right from the stage of filing nominations.

Personal affidavits

Candidates have to file personal affidavits along with their nominations. Senior advocate Sanjay Nuli, who appeared in the case, pointed out that these affidavits were part of legislative efforts to maintain the purity of elections and a healthy democracy.

Voters must be educated and well-informed

Citizens can file criminal complaints against candidates for false information in nominations, it says

about the contesting candidates, including the latter's assets, educational qualifications and criminal antecedents. Concealing personal information or filing false details to hoodwink the voters is a non-cognisable and bailable offence under Section 125-A of the Representation of the People Act, 1951. The Section provides that a guilty party would be liable to face imprisonment for six months, fine or both.

Justice Datta interpreted that the rigour of Section 195 of the Code of Criminal Procedure (CrPC), that only a complaint lodged by a public servant must be taken cognisance of by a court of law, did not affect Section 125-A of the 1951 Act.

"If indeed it were the intention of the legislature that cognisance of any offence relating to the furnishing of false information by a candidate in an affidavit with intent of being elected in an election could only be taken if the complainant were a public servant, the same could have been provided by an amendment of Section 195 CrPC," the court noted.

Interpretation

"No court would be barred from taking cognisance of an alleged offence under Section 125-A, even on the complaint lodged by a private person. This interpretation is fortified by the absence of any provision in any enactment stipulating that a complaint in relation to an offence under Section 125-A can only be lodged by a public servant," Justice Datta, who authored the judgment, held.

Innovation and Entrepreneurship Federation of CCS NIAM
(Section 8 Company under CCS NIAM)
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State: Delhi **Regional Director**

Delhi HC rejects Neha Bora's plea against notice to sign peace bond

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Delhi High Court on Friday rejected a plea by All India Students' Association (AISA) president Neha Bora challenging a police notice asking her to execute a peace bond before a Special Executive Magistrate (SEM).

"I am rejecting the writ petition at this juncture," said Justice Subramonium Prasad, while pronouncing the judgment.

The judge, however, said that he has passed certain directions to the SEM on providing all material to the student leader in the proceedings.

"There are sufficient safeguards given, directions given to the Magistrate to take care. All the material has to be furnished to her," Justice Prasad said.

The court also said that before passing any order, the SEM would consider the issue of whether the bond has to be produced at the very first instance or during the course of the enquiry.

₹10,000 bond

The police notice, issued on October 17 under Section 126 of the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita (BNSS), asked Ms. Bora to appear before the SEM on October 19 and show cause as to why she should not execute a personal bond of ₹10,000 with one surety "for keeping peace for a period of enquiry".

INBRIEF



Saudi security crisis prolongs IndiGo flight suspension

IndiGo has extended the suspension of its flights to and from Saudi Arabia amid escalating security concerns in the region, said the Indian Embassy in Riyadh on Friday. "IndiGo flights to and from Riyadh will remain cancelled until 31 October 2026 (inclusive), while flights to and from Jeddah, Dammam and Madinah will remain cancelled until 27 October 2026 (inclusive)," the mission said. The latest extension of flight cancellations follows a series of Houthi attacks in Saudi Arabia on Wednesday, including a strike on King Fahd International Airport in Dammam that killed an Indian national, and a separate attack on Saudi Aramco's Shaybah oilfield. PTI

India confirms safety of 14 nationals after yacht attack

India on Friday said that its 14 nationals onboard a yacht involved in an incident off the coast of Yemen are safe and it would continue to work to ensure their well-being. Arab media on Thursday quoted spokesperson of the Houthi militia Yahya Saree as claiming that Saudi Arabian forces targeted the Indian yacht near Yuqar Island near the Yemeni coast in the Red Sea."Reports suggest that all 14 Indian nationals are safe and located around Hodeidah in Yemen," the Indian mission in Yemen posted on social media on Friday. The incident comes amid an escalation of hostilities between Houthis and Saudi Arabia, with both sides targeting each other's facilities. PTI

Odisha, A.P. brace for storm as low pressure intensifies

Bay system is likely to cross the southern Odisha-northern Andhra Pradesh coast by October 28, says IMD; Odisha govt. cancels leaves of all officials, keeps disaster response forces on standby

The Hindu Bureau
BHUBANESWAR

The weather system over the Bay of Bengal is likely to intensify into a cyclone and cross the southern Odisha-northern Andhra Pradesh coast by October 28.

A low-pressure area formed over the east-central and adjoining southeast Bay of Bengal at 5.30 a.m. on Friday is expected to become a depression on Saturday, a deep depression on Sunday and a cyclonic storm by Monday morning, the India Meteorological Department (IMD) said. It may then move towards the north Andhra Pradesh and south Odisha coast.

"Under the impact of the low-pressure system, several Odisha districts are likely to witness heavy to very heavy rainfall from October 26. On October 27, a red alert for heavy rain has been issued for Puri, Ganjam, and Gajapati districts," said Suresh Pujari, Odisha's Revenue and Disaster Management Minister, after a high-level meeting. Subsequently, a majority of Odisha districts would experience cyclonic weather on October 27, he said, adding that the IMD was yet to forecast the exact area of the landfall of the predicted cyclone.



Under the impact of the weather system, several districts along the coast are likely to witness heavy rainfall. K.R. DEEPAK

"We have been informed through different weather models that the cyclone may enter the landmass between Odisha's Gopalpur and Andhra Pradesh's Kakinada and move as a depression towards Jharkhand and Chhattisgarh through interior Odisha districts," the Minister said. Mr. Pujari said that depending on the intensity of the weather system, people will be evacuated, and their lives and property safeguarded. "Government employees have been asked to return to their offices. Leaves of officials have been cancelled," he said. Fishermen have been advised to return to the coast. All disaster response forces, including the National Disaster Response Force and Odisha Disaster Rapid Action Force, are on standby.

Meanwhile, K. Naga Ratna, Head of the Amaravati Meteorological Centre, Andhra Pradesh, said, "It would be at least a severe cyclonic storm." Some models indicate a very severe cyclonic storm, with wind reaching a speed of up to 145 kmph, she added, and a storm surge of 1 to 2 metres is expected. The IMD's sea warning for October 27 is higher, at 120 to 165 kmph, gusting to 185 kmph, off the north A.P. coast.

The landfall point remains uncertain. "The system could cross anywhere between West Godavari and Srikakulam districts, with some models pointing to Visakhapatnam and others to Kakinada and Konaseema," she said.

The IMD has issued a red warning for extremely heavy rain at isolated places in Visakhapatnam and Anakapalli districts on October 27.

On October 28, red warnings cover Alluri Sitharama Raju, Anakapalli, Kakinada, East Godavari, Konaseema and West Godavari, while Visakhapatnam is under an orange alert for heavy to very heavy rain.

(With inputs from Visakhapatnam)

Ladakh talks fail to resume amid rift over govt. proposal

Peerzada Ashiq
SRINAGAR

Original agenda adopted by civil society groups now stands hijacked, a new forum alleged

The proposed talks between the Union Home Ministry and representatives from Ladakh failed to take place on Thursday amid growing differences among civil society groups over the Centre's draft proposal for the Union Territory.

Leh's civil society groups, particularly the Leh Apex Body (LAB) and the Kargil Democratic Alliance (KDA), had termed the 32-page draft, which proposes a new governance structure for Ladakh, "a departure from the earlier promises".

A sub-committee of the Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA), mandated to talk with Ladakh representatives, was scheduled to meet on Thursday in New Delhi to further discuss the 32-page draft shared with the LAB and KDA on October 15 in Leh. However, the talks did not take place.

The Civil Society Forum of Ladakh (CSFL), a Leh-based civil society group, is projecting itself as a new stakeholder in the issue. "This forum observes with deep concern that the original agenda adopted by LAB for constitutional safeguards for land, jobs, culture and environment stands hijacked. The dialogue is now dominated by one individual (climate activist) Sonam Wangchuk and KDA, compromising the genuine interests of districts and the Buddhist community," said the members of CSFL in a joint statement.

The group comprises BJP leader and ex-Member of Parliament Thupstan Chhewang, ex-chief executive councillor of the Ladakh Autonomous Hill Development Council-Leh (LAHDC-Leh) Rigzen Spalbar; ex-legislator Tsering Samphel, representatives of Thiksey and Thuksey Rinpoche, and also members of the Ladakh Buddhist Association (LBA).

"The LAB and KDA no longer represent inclusive voice of all districts," the forum said, while appealing to the Centre to hold panchayat elections and "enhance powers of hill councils till Union Territory-level constitutional settlement is reached".

RSS affiliate opposes Starlink's India entry

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Swadeshi Jagaran Manch (SJM) has urged Prime Minister Narendra Modi to deny operating permissions for SpaceX's satellite internet service, Starlink, in India. SJM is an affiliate of the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS) and the recommendation follows a protest march led by SJM members.

"It's unfortunate that instead of responding to clarifications sought from his company, on national security grounds, Shri Elon Musk has chosen to make allegations on Indian businesses and the government indirectly," Ashwani Mahajan, SJM's national co-convener said. The government is yet to approve requests from three companies for spectrum allotment.

Driving licence rule amendments seek to raise bar for learner's test

Jagriti Chandra
NEW DELHI

The Union government has proposed changes to driving licence rules that could make the learner's test more rigorous while moving several services online and making some of them free.

The draft amendments to the Central Motor Vehicles Rules, 1989, propose raising the pass mark for the preliminary learner's test from 60% to 75%. Applicants will get 15 days, instead of seven, to complete the learner's licence process, and will have to take a safe-driving tutorial of at least 30 minutes.

Applicants will have to submit separate proof of address, age and identity. The list of acceptable documents will include Aadhaar, voter ID, passport, e-ration card and certain government-issued identity documents. Electricity and household gas bills issued within the past three months can also be used as address proof. Foreign applicants should show that they are legally present in India.



The draft amendments propose raising the pass mark for the preliminary learner's test from 60% to 75%. FILE PHOTO

A new Form 2A is proposed to bring together applications for licence renewal, duplicate licences, changes to names or addresses, updates to personal details and the addition of vehicle categories. The draft also proposes no fee for changing a licence holder's name, address or other recorded details.

Medical disclosure

As per the draft amendments, applicants will have to provide more medical information, including whether they have epilepsy or other seizure disorders, hearing impairment, night blindness, medication allergies or surgical implants. People who report epilepsy or a seizure disorder, along with a seizure in the previous three years, or who are on anti-epileptic medication at present, will not be eligible for a driving licence.

The rules say that details about medicine allergies, implants and certain other medical information will be used only if the person is hospitalised after a road accident.

The draft also proposes collecting information such as blood group and emergency contact details in licence applications.

The draft was put up on the government website earlier this week. The Centre has invited feedback from public and other stakeholders within 30 days, after which it will be taken up for consideration.

UN Security Council faces a 'legitimacy deficit', says India

Press Trust of India
UNITED NATIONS

India has highlighted the United Nations Security Council's struggles to deliver peace in some of the "gravest" global conflicts, emphasising that authority derived from victory in the Second World War cannot compensate for a "deficit in legitimacy" of an unrepresentative UNSC today.

India's Permanent Representative to the UN, Ambassador Harish Parvathaneni, while addressing the 'Question of Equitable representation on and increase in the membership of Security Council' in the UN General Assembly, said on Thursday that an organisation that cannot renew its principal organ will find it ever harder to command authority in a world that has moved far beyond 1945.

"History can be a guide for what not to do. It cannot determine today's choices," he said. He added that the credibility of the UN is "called into question" as conflicts multiply and the council struggles to respond.



Harish Parvathaneni

India also called out the deliberate suppression of sacrifices made by nations in the world wars while an organisation "crafted of the victors, for the victors and by the victors" did not include concerns of the victims.

India, which is vying for a non-permanent UNSC seat for the 2028-29 term, said that the Asia-Pacific Group accounting for more than 60% of the world's population has no choice but to be limited in its representation. "Nowhere else would the injustice of this gross under-representation have continued for so long," he said.

'Central imbalance'

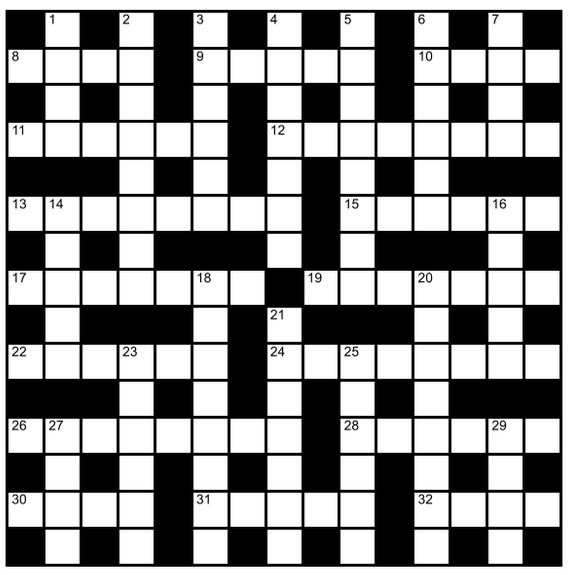
The 15-nation council has five permanent veto-wielding members – China, France, Russia, the UK and the U.S. while 10 members are elected to sit at the horseshoe high-table for two-year terms. India has been calling for an expansion in both the permanent and non-permanent categories of UNSC membership, as Parvathaneni emphasised that a reform that expands only the non-permanent category leaves the central imbalance untouched and further entrenches the status quo.

TH CROSSWORD + 14931

(set by Incognito)

Solve this puzzle online and access more puzzles at *https://thehindu.com/crosswords*

SCAN TO PLAY



Across

8 Juliet is in front of sick girl tumbling after Jack (4)
9 Kind of taste satsuma might possess (5)
10 Before 9, United Nations gets operating system (4)
11 Cheese maker's tenner returned (6)
12 Exaggerated usage, perhaps, about slaughter (8)
13 Where one may find figure eights left by sportspersons... (3,5)
15 Distress call from vessel after vessel (3,3)
17 Frank, a singer playing sitar around North America (7)
19 In absence of a coach, diced and covered with gin cocktail to make pasta-like dumplings (7)
22 Name child under guardian after editor (6)
24 Wrongly indicate a series of elements (8)
26 Disfigured Thane cop's memorial (8)
28 John and Theodore plundered (6)
30 Put it in big enchilada initially and sink teeth in (4)
31 With love, new elm may produce citrus fruit (5)
32 Give out loan instalment before time (4)

Down

1 Pest is in custody of policeman (4)
2 Horrible rain near plot results in flatworms (8)
3 Boy leaves dustbin for Hoffman (6)
4 Oddly move Amos, after dropping Mike, and go away (7)
5 Tailless feline goes around mineral spring resort for period from birth till death (8)
6 Hide behind Russian, Mr Bond (6)
7 Advertisement may be seen on board behind him (4)
14 Spoiled rice before commencement of dinner and sobbed (5)
16 Pest from Andhra Pradesh covered (5)
18 Shattered emerald strewn around front of pine tree (3,5)
20 Means from criminal with pieces of paper currency (8)
21 Amish is cooking Japanese delicacy (7)
23 Animal having crushed ego in climax (6)
25 Story book is a gift (6)
27 Lake in Madikeri estate (4)
29 Ruler's firearm is damaged after throwing far away (4)

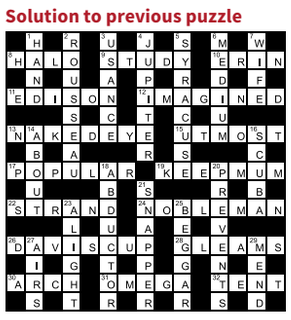
SUDOKU

5			6	7	1	2		
			8				1	7
			2					6
	6				4	3		
		5				1		
		2	5				8	
1					6			
7	9				8			
		4	7	5	3			1

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★★

No.SS7040 Distribution: www.knightfeatures.com

Solution to previous puzzle



Solution to yesterday's Sudoku

1	2	6	5	9	3	8	4	7
7	4	8	6	1	2	3	9	5
3	5	9	4	8	7	6	2	1
4	1	5	8	7	9	2	3	6
6	9	7	3	2	5	4	1	8
8	3	2	1	6	4	7	5	9
5	6	4	7	3	1	9	8	2
9	7	1	2	4	8	5	6	3
2	8	3	9	5	6	1	7	4

FAITH

Always serving the Lord

Garuda is always with Lord Narayana. In Brindavana, wherever Krishna went, Garuda flew above Him, sheltering Him from the sun. In his Stotra ratna, Alavandar enumerates the ways in which Garuda serves the Lord, said Thenthirupperai Aravindalochanan in a discourse. Alavandar points out that Garuda is the Lord's servant, His friend, His vehicle, His seat, His flag, His canopy, and His fan. Alavandar further says that Garuda is the embodiment of the Vedas. In all Vishnu temples, we find a shrine for Garuda, where Garuda faces the Lord.

During the war against Ravana, Indrajit used the naga pasa to bind Rama and Lakshmana. But when Garuda appeared, the snakes, which as arrows had bound Rama and Lakshmana, fled, thus releasing the two princes. Garuda then touched them, and the brothers' wounds healed, and they became stronger than before. Garuda then lifted them and embraced them. Rama said that meeting Garuda gave Him the feeling that He was meeting His father Dasaratha.

Tirumala, where Lord Srinivasa resides, is also called Garudadri. When Bhu Devi requested Varaha to remain on the earth, the latter asked Garuda to bring seven hills that He had in Sri Vaikunta. Because Garuda brought the seven hills from Sri Vaikunta, the hills came to be called Garudadri. Although we now have the practice of referring to just one of the seven hills as Garudadri, all of them have the name Garudadri. The Garuda sevai festival of Kanchipuram Varadaraja Perumal temple is famous, although all temples have the processional deity carried on Garuda vahana during the main temple festival.

INBRIEF



BPCL Q2 net profit falls 22.5% amid volatile crude prices

Bharat Petroleum's standalone net profit in the September-ended quarter fell 22.5% on a year-on-year basis as volatile crude following the reignited conflict in West Asia prices impacted margins. The Mumbai-headquartered refiner's net profit declined to ₹4,993.17 crore in the quarter compared with ₹6,442.5 crore in the same period last year. The State-owned oil company's cost of materials consumed soared 44.2% during the period to ₹74,969 crore.

IndusInd Bank posts net profit of ₹1,242 crore in Q2

IndusInd Bank Limited posted a net profit of ₹1,242 crore for the quarter ended September, up 20% sequentially, and trimming net loss of ₹437 crore for the same quarter of the preceding year. The bank had incurred net loss for the same period in previous year due to an increase in microfinance provisioning and write-offs. The bank's bottom line for Q2 FY27 was supported by a rise in net interest income, which stood at ₹4,569 crore as against ₹4,409 crore a year ago.

Dr. Reddy's Q2 net falls 32% to ₹913 cr. on lower revenue

Dr. Reddy's Laboratories reported September quarter consolidated net profit declined more than 31% to ₹913.2 crore compared with ₹1,336.8 crore a year earlier on lower global generics revenue, particularly a sharp dip in the mainstay North America market. Revenue from operations for the Hyderabad-based multinational stood at ₹8,697.8 crore, down from ₹8,828.3 crore a year earlier, according to results prepared under Indian Accounting Standards (Ind AS).

Oil prices extend rally to a near six-month high

Brent crude futures touched intra-day high of $117 a barrel on Friday, a day after Houthi attacks on Saudi's civilian and energy infra; India's crude basket has averaged $120.08 so far this month

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Oil prices extended their rally from Thursday, inching closer to a six-month high and the $120 per barrel-mark, a day after the Houthi attacks on Saudi Arabia's civilian and energy infrastructure.

The latest attacks have renewed tensions over disruptions to global oil supplies. At the time of writing this report on Friday evening, benchmark Brent crude futures for December delivery had accelerated about 3.8% from its previous close to an intra-day high of $117.42 per barrel.

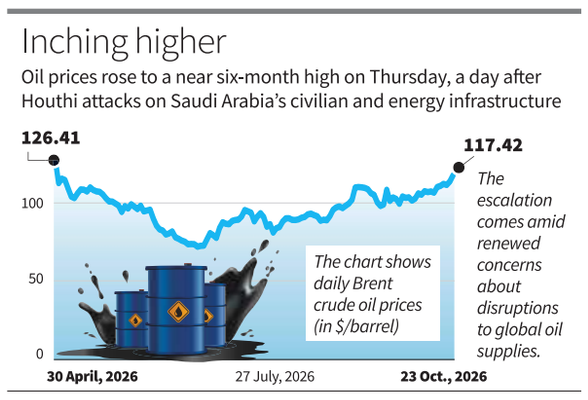
West Texas Intermediate (WTI) was also up 3.64% at $103.09 per barrel. India's crude oil basket averaged $119.99 per barrel on Friday, according to data from the Petroleum Planning and Analysis Cell (PPAC). The Indian basket has averaged $120.08 per barrel till date in the ongoing month.

The latest benchmark prices are much higher than the Reserve Bank of India's projections of crude oil prices being at $95 per barrel in the second half of the fiscal year.

An increase in crude oil prices elevates concerns of persisting inflation.

According to estimates by Vipul Jindal and Tanay Dalal, economists at private sector lender Axis Bank, public sector support of approximately 1.7% of GDP would cushion shocks when average oil prices stay at $100 per barrel this year.

"Every $10 per barrel increase in crude [but pump prices steady], will raise support by 20 bps," the economists estimate.



Adani raises CNG prices

Amid higher input gas pressures, Adani Total Gas on Friday increased the prices of compressed natural gas (CNG) at its retail stations by ₹4.45 per kg.

CNG at its outlets in Gujarat's Ahmedabad is now priced at ₹98.47 per kg, ₹102.6 per kg in Haryana's Faridabad and ₹106.4 per kg in Rajasthan's Udaipur.

On a standalone basis, the company operates 723 refuelling outlets across the country.

'Crude oil sourcing volatile at present'

Saptaparno Ghosh
NEW DELHI


Vikas Kaushal

Crude oil sourcing at present is highly volatile and unpredictable, and HPCL is procuring more on a delivered basis than on free-on-board (FOB) and term contracts, Vikas Kaushal, Chairman and Managing Director (CMD) of the State-owned oil-marketing company told analysts in an investor call on Friday.

Purchases on delivered basis entail the seller to bear the shipping cost and associated risks until it reaches the buyer's port or facility.

"All I can say if you look at crude premiums and landed cost: there are times when there are premiums and there are times when you can even pick it up at discounts. It is a very 'Wild West' right now," Mr. Kaushal said.

He also said that there could be instances where discounts exist though freight cost is very high.

Srividya Venkataraman, Director (Finance), informed analysts that freight costs had doubled between the first and the second quarter.

She observed that shipping costs on a Suezmax tanker went up to $9 per barrel in Q2FY27, from about $4 per barrel in June.

Mr. Kaushal also stated that the landed price may not be as high as it might appear. Ms. Venkataraman informed that under-recoveries on LPG stood at ₹245 per cylinder in October and is projected at ₹327 per cylinder in November.

'Informed customers of data breach individually'

The Hindu Bureau
MUMBAI

State Bank of India on Friday said that it had informed all customers individually regarding the recent data breach through email and/or WhatsApp.

The country's largest commercial bank had come under criticism for not informing affected customers, though it intimated the incident to stock exchanges. In a statement, the SBI said "We reiterate that your account balances and funds are safe with us."

"Customers are advised to follow safe digital banking practices, never share their OTP, PIN or password with anyone, and remain vigilant against suspicious calls, messages and emails," it stated.

Markets snap one-week rally following surge in crude prices, FII outflows

Gowri Lakshmi
MUMBAI

Indian markets snapped the one-week rally on Friday, with most indices ending in the red following a surge in crude prices and foreign fund outflows.

The 30-share BSE Sensex fell more than 1% during the day before settling at 73,123.83, down 125.56 points from its previous close. Nifty declined to the 22,400-level before unwinding some losses, and ended at 22,600, down 87.65 points, or 0.4%.

"Benchmark indices closed in negative territory as elevated Brent crude oil prices and weak global cues continued to weigh on investor sentiment. Selling pressure remained broad-based, with the broader market witnessing a sharper decline than the frontline indices," Pabitro Mukherjee, deputy VP – Research, Bajaj Broking, said in a note.

Brent crude prices hit a near six-month high of $117.42 per barrel after the Houthi attacks in Saudi Arabia. Heightened worries over geopolitical tensions continue to fuel risk-averse sentiments toward emerging market economies among global investors. Foreign institutional investors remain net sellers in Indian equities.

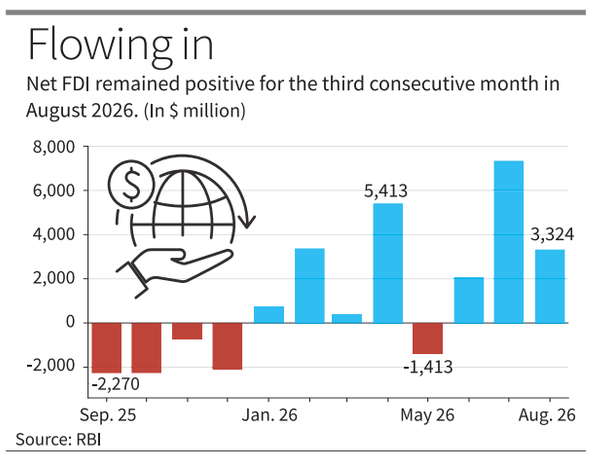
They withdrew ₹3,459 crore from the bourses on Thursday, though IPO-linked flows and domestic institutional buyers offset the sustained outflow.

Net FDI at $3.3 bn in August, stayed positive for third consecutive month: RBI bulletin

T.C.A. Sharad Raghavan
NEW DELHI

Net foreign direct investment (FDI) was positive for the third consecutive month in August with inflows exceeding outflows by $3.3 billion, as per latest data from the Reserve Bank of India (RBI). This was driven by robust inflows even as outward investments by Indian companies slid.

"FDI flows continued to remain robust in August supported by strong gross inflows and moderation in outward FDI," the RBI said in its monthly Bulletin. "Communication, miscellaneous services and manufacturing received more than two-thirds of the FDI inflows."



Net FDI, which is the difference between the total direct investment coming in and the total going out, was positive in seven out of the last eight months. This is a significant turnaround from the five consecutive months of negative net FDI India saw during August-December 2025.

Money flowing in

The data shows that gross FDI into India, or the total that entered the country as direct investment stood at $11.1 billion in August, which was 24% lower than in the previous month but almost 68% higher than in August last year. "The U.S., Singapore and Mauritius were the major source countries, accounting for about 72% of FDI inflows."

Total outflows rose a tad to $7.7 billion in August vis a vis $7.2 billion in July and $6.7 billion in August 2025. However, in this, the driver was the repatriation by foreign firms operating in India than outward investment by Indian firms.

Less investment outflow

"Outward FDI flows moderated in August with more than half being directed towards Singapore, the Netherlands, and the U.S," the RBI said. "The major sectors of outward FDI were agriculture & mining, financial, insurance & business services, and manufacturing accounting for more than two-thirds of the outward flows."

Remittances rose to $5.8 billion in August or almost 52% higher than in July, and 28% higher than in August 2025. This was largely balanced out by a fall in outward FDI to $1.9 billion. This was over 43% lower than in July and 11% lower than in August 2025.

In the longer time-period of April-August, gross and net FDI flows were higher. A slowdown in the pace of outward FDI with sustained higher gross FDI inflow supported net FDI flows," the RBI said.

'Broad-based food price increase seen'

Lalatendu Mishra
MUMBAI

High-frequency data collated by the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) for October (till 19th), suggest broad-based rise in food prices, said RBI officials in the October edition of RBI Bulletin.

"Among cereals, rice and wheat prices continued to rise. Prices of major pulses also went up sequentially. Edible oil prices also recorded a slow and broad-based increase, led by mustard and palm oil," they wrote in the 'State of the Economy' article.

Among vegetables, potato prices slid while pace of onion price rise dipped. Tomato prices rose.

Surprisingly, inflation in rural areas has been rising more than in urban areas.


Rice and wheat prices continued to increase.

While inflation stood at 4.9% and 6.1% respectively, in urban and rural areas in September against 4.3% and 5.2% in August.

Stating WPI inflation logged its first double-digit rate in the new series (Base 2022-23) at 11.4% in September from 9.9% in August reflecting a broad-based price rise, they said industrial and farm input costs remained elevated.

Tata Motors turns Q2 net profit of ₹1,257 crore

Lalatendu Mishra
MUMBAI

Tata Motors Ltd, the commercial vehicles firm of the Tata Group, for the second quarter ended September 30 reported consolidated net profit of ₹1,257 crore against net loss of ₹867 crore a year earlier.

The turnaround was led by lower mark-to-market loss on investments in Tata Capital Ltd. Consolidated revenue rose 36% to ₹25,232 crore. The firm said it was going ahead with Iveco acquisition as planned and raised the offer price to €14.4, up €30 cents, to compensate shareholders for the 4-month delay in getting regulatory approvals for the deal.

'Panama a Latam base for T.N. firms'

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The unparalleled connectivity, professionalism and platform that Panama possesses can be utilised by brands and firms from Tamil Nadu to promote products and expand markets, according to Alonso Correa Miguel, Ambassador of Panama to India.

Panama is the natural bridge between North and South America and the logistic link between the Pacific and the Atlantic oceans, he said while speaking to businesspersons in Chennai on Friday.

Maritime and pharmaceutical businesses from Chennai explored opportunities in Panama and the Latin American region at the event.

Single base in Latam

Panama connects world trade through the Canal, the Colón Free Zone, one of the largest ship registries and a dollar economy serving 20 Latin American markets.

"Tamil Nadu, with an economy about four times the size of Panama's, exported around $59 billion worth of goods in 2025-26 and accounted for a third or more of India's electronics and vehicle exports. Panama can give Tamil Nadu's manufacturers a single base for Latin America," he added.

Infosys Q2 net rises 6% to ₹7,823 crore, announces ₹26/share interim dividend

Mini Tejaswi
BENGALURU

Infosys reported a 6.2% year-on-year growth in net profit to ₹7,823 crore in the second quarter of FY27 while revenue rose 10.7% to ₹49,244 crore. In Q2, it won large deals worth $5.2 billion, with 62% of the wins being net new.

Cautious on overall market environment, the firm trimmed revenue growth projection for FY27 to 1%-2%, down from previous 1.5%-3% though it retained full-year operating margin guidance at 20%-22%.

The company indicated guidance was cut due to various factors, including a softer second quarter, subdued volumes, pricing pressure and higher productivity expectations from clients in addition to weakness in discretionary spending across retail and high-tech sectors, even as the IT services major reported strong AI and large deal wins in the September quarter. It also said the revised revenue outlook reflected the challenges of converting AI-led productivity gains into incremental revenue while managing competitive intensity in traditional services unit.



Keeping pace: Q2 also saw a rise in AI-related revenue at 10.5% of total revenue, up from 8.2% a year earlier. REUTERS

Jayesh Sanghrajka, CFO, in an earnings call said, "Q2 has been softer and volume continues to remain softer. We have also seen pricing pressure on the back of competitive intensity and higher ask on productivity."

Q2 also saw a rise in AI-related revenue at 10.5% of total revenue, up from 8.2% a year earlier. It delivered operating margins of 21% in Q2. The board announced an interim dividend of ₹26/share. Infosys reported a net addition of 4,000 staff in Q2, including 8,000 fresh graduates.

Jio IPO sees a record over 1 cr. applications

Gowri Lakshmi
MUMBAI

Jio Platforms Ltd's initial public offering (IPO) crossed a milestone on the closing day when it became the first issue globally to secure over one crore applications crossing Waaree Energies' 97 lakh.

The ₹30,213 crore IPO closed on Friday with a total demand of more than ₹7 lakh crore. Investors bid for more than 20.5 times the issue, making it the highest-value bid in India.

Jio Platforms Ltd., the largest company by market share in India's telecom sector, opened for subscripton on Wednesday with investors fully subscribing in 100 minutes making it one of the fastest-subscribed IPOs in India.

Typically, foreign investors and institutional buyers wait until the last day before bidding to gauge investor sentiment.

However, Jio Platform's issue was bid over 10 times by qualified institutional buyers on day 2. As per latest data from NSE, QIB demand rose as high as almost 15 times. Retail investors' demand crossed 2.03 times with biddings worth 17.29 crore shares.

According to latest reports, bids were largely placed at the upper end of the price band of ₹1,119 with total demand exceeding $15 billion.

TAIPEI

China using militia ships to expand reach into western Pacific: Taiwan



REUTERS

China is combining militia vessels with coast guard ships to expand "battlefield preparation" around Taiwan and into the western Pacific, Taiwan said, warning the operations were also putting pressure on Japan and the Philippines. A Chinese militia boat was spotted off Taiwan's Pacific coast in mid-August. REUTERS

KYIV

Two soldiers died after arrested girl sent Russian poison: Ukraine



AP

Ukrainian police said they had detained a 17-year-old girl after she sent "free drugs" to soldiers on the instructions of a Russian handler in exchange for money and that two had died. Ukraine and Russia have throughout their war since 2022 accused each other of recruiting minors for sabotage acts including poisoning. AFP

SAO PAULO

Brazil court orders govt. to ensure indigenous people get to vote



AFP

A federal court in Para state ordered Brazil's government on Thursday to ensure indigenous people nationwide can vote in Sunday's presidential runoff. The lawsuit said local governments denied transportation for political reasons and ranchers prevented indigenous workers from leaving farms to vote. AP

ATHENS

Greece passes legislation banning social media for children under 15



REUTERS

Greece's Parliament passed a law on Friday banning children under 15 from social media, joining a growing number of countries imposing curbs on young people's use of the apps. The Bill, set to take effect on January 1, will require age verification on social networks and impose penalties if companies fail to comply. AFP

Israel plans West Bank offensive after shooting kills two soldiers

Netanyahu orders lockdown in occupied West Bank, says Army preparing for an operation on a scale unseen in decades; Hamas praises the attack as a heroic operation; latest escalation occurs as Israel goes to national elections on Tuesday

Agence France-Presse
HEBRON

Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu threatened a military operation in the occupied West Bank on a scale unseen in decades after Palestinian gunmen killed two Israeli soldiers on Friday in an attack days before national elections.

The attack at the Farsh al-Hawa checkpoint near Hebron in the southern West Bank wounded three other soldiers, the Israeli military said in a statement. Israeli forces eventually shot and killed the two armed Palestinian men.

Mr. Netanyahu visited the site of the attack and said the military would force Palestinians out of a Hebron neighbourhood from which he said the attackers had emerged.



Israeli soldiers at the scene of a fire exchange between armed Palestinians and Israeli forces in Hebron on Friday. AFP

He likened the tactic to Israel's devastating military assaults on two Palestinian refugee camps in 2025, operations that displaced tens of thousands of Palestinians. Human Rights Watch said those expulsions amounted to war crimes, something Israel rejects.

"That is exactly what we will do here," Mr. Netanyahu said. "We will evacuate the residents, we will go house-to-house, we will also confiscate the weapons there, and all terrorist infrastructures will be dealt with and destroyed."

Mr. Netanyahu lauded the soldiers' response, crediting them with having "prevented what could have been a major attack", and ordered a lockdown in the West Bank.

'Exactly like in Gaza'

Prior to Mr. Netanyahu's announcement, far-right Israeli Finance Minister Bezalel Smotrich had called for a fresh military offensive in the West Bank "exactly like in Gaza".

"There is no other option but a comprehensive military campaign in Judea and Samaria to dismantle the Palestinian Authority" said Mr. Smotrich.

National Security Minister Itamar Ben Gvir also called for the Ramallah-based Palestinian Authority to be "dismantled and demilitarised, and its terror infrastructure wiped out completely".

No evidence suggests that the Palestinian Authority, the Palestinian government in West Bank, was connected to Friday's attack.

Meanwhile, Hamas, without claiming responsibility, hailed Friday's shooting. The Gaza-based group called the shooting a "natural and legitimate response to the ongoing crimes and brutal attacks against our people".

It called on supporters to "mobilise fully and turn the land into a fire beneath the feet of the invaders".

(With inputs from Reuters)

France, U.K. stage first joint nuclear air strike simulation

Agence France-Presse
PARIS



The exercise involved RAF Typhoon fighter jets alongside French Rafales over the Mediterranean Sea. AP

French and British air forces have for the first time staged a joint exercise simulating a nuclear strike, the countries' Defence Ministries said in a statement on Friday.

The exercise, codenamed 'Rummy', took place on Tuesday and involved RAF Typhoon fighter jets alongside French Rafale aircraft over the Mediterranean Sea, it said.

The exercise did not involve any actual nuclear weapons and was aimed at enhancing coordination between western Europe's two nuclear powers, the statement added.

After taking off from a base in northeastern France, "the French Rafales, escorted by RAF Typhoons, conducted a simulated nuclear strike", it said.

French President Emmanuel Macron has offered to extend the protection of France's nuclear deterrent to other European allies, as the European Union's only nuclear power since Brexit.

French Defence Minister Catherine Vautrin noted that "possessing independent nuclear forces does not preclude coordination".

The joint exercise showed "our nuclear forces demonstrate that they can contribute even more significantly to the overall security" of NATO, she said.

U.K. Defence Minister Wes Streeting said the exercise marked a "new chapter" in the relationship between Britain and France on nuclear defence.

Writing on his X, he said: "It's a landmark step in U.K.-France defence cooperation, and a clear signal that we stand shoulder to shoulder with our allies on European security and credible deterrence."

First Russian diesel tanker from Putin deal heading for U.S.

Agence France-Presse
PARIS

A tanker filled with Russian diesel is headed for New York, maritime trackers and the Kremlin confirmed on Friday, after the U.S. eased sanctions in a deal that shocked Ukraine and its European allies.

U.S. President Donald Trump struck the deal with President Vladimir Putin this month as Russia's war against Ukraine dragged on and as his relations with Ukrainian leader Volodymyr Zelenskyy plummeted.

The agreement is widely seen as an attempt by Mr. Trump to lower U.S. fuel prices ahead of mid-term elections next month.

The tanker *Agioi Fanendes* was located off Helsinki on Friday and indicated "New York" as its destination on its AIS transponder signal, according to maritime tracking firm Kpler. The ship left Russia's Baltic port of Primorsk overnight, after loading nearly 300,000 barrels of diesel, Kpler said. It was due to reach New York around November 7.

Kremlin spokesman Dmitry Peskov confirmed that the "first tanker set sail for its intended recipients, its buyers".

Search on for survivors after deadly quake in China's Tibet region kills 16

Associated Press
BEIJING

Rescuers combed through a remote area in the Chinese region of Tibet on Friday after a magnitude 7 earthquake that killed at least 16 people, injuring 76 and collapsing hundreds of homes, according to Chinese state media.

The disaster struck Nagqu, a city north of Tibet's capital Lhasa that's some 4,800 metres above sea level, on Thursday. At least 339 homes collapsed, and officials were concerned about further building collapses from aftershocks, as well as casualties from rockslides.

More than 5,000 people from three local counties were deployed for rescue efforts.

As of Friday afternoon, rescuers had done three rounds of searches, said Dunzhu, the acting Mayor of Nagqu city.



In the aftermath: An aerial drone photo shows damaged houses after a quake struck Nagqu in China's Tibet autonomous region. AP

The U.S. Geological Survey said the quake occurred at 10:33 p.m. local time on Thursday, with its epicentre 191 kilometres east-northeast of Nagqu. It put the earthquake's depth at 18 kilometres.

The U.S. agency recorded at least seven aftershocks with magnitude between 4.3 and 5.2.

'All-out efforts'

Chinese President Xi Jinping called for all-out efforts in rescue operations and medical relief work on Friday morning.

Mr. Jinping said the tremor caused "significant casualties" and took place at a "high-altitude location" in cold weather.

"(We) must go all-out to carry out search and rescue operations and do our utmost to treat the injured, so as to minimise casualties," Xinhua quoted Mr. Xi as saying.

(With inputs from AFP)

French authorities to deploy 70,000 police ahead of new protests

Reuters
PARIS

France will deploy 70,000 police for protests on Saturday, Interior Minister Laurent Nunez said on Friday, accusing ultra-left groups of encouraging violence and looting after unrest shocked the country last weekend.

"We will be uncompromising with rioters, looters and all those who commit acts of violence," Mr. Nunez told reporters on Friday.

Mr. Nunez said authorities had identified numerous online calls from hard-left groups encouraging attacks and urging activists to target public buildings.

Police have authorised only a union demonstration in Paris on Saturday, rejecting requests for rallies lodged by France's main student union, UNEF, and the Yellow Vest movement, an anti-establishment force that first emerged in 2018.

Fears of renewed turmoil prompted several of Paris' best-known cultural institutions, including the Louvre, to close on Saturday. Business groups also urged shops to stay shut after some 3,000 stores and businesses were ransacked last weekend.

Melania forges ceasefire for Ukrainian city

Reuters
WASHINGTON

U.S. first lady Melania Trump has secured a ceasefire between Russia and Ukraine in the Russian-controlled city of Oleshky, which will begin on October 29, the White House said on Friday.

"Both nations agreed to temporarily stop all military action in Oleshky to allow for humanitarian aid to enter," a White House statement said.

"Oleshky is a front-line war city. Its remaining population is primarily elderly residents who need medical attention and food," Ms. Melania said.

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INVITATION FOR BID (IFB) - Bid Identification No. WATCO(W)-21/2026-27, Dtd.16.10.2026
WATCO No. 11739 / Date: 16.10.2026
- Name of the work :-
1. Design, Drawing, Construction, Testing & Commissioning of Sewerage System, 01 No. of 220 KLD Effluent Treatment Plant (ETP) & 02 Nos of 10 KLD Effluent Treatment Plant (ETP) for VSS Medical college & Hospital, Burla including Operation & Maintenance for a period of Five Years.
2. Design, Drawing, Construction, Testing & Commissioning of Sewerage System, 390 KLD Sewage Treatment Plant (STP) for Acharya Harihar Post-graduate Institute of Cancer, Kataka including Operation & Maintenance for a period of Five Years.
3. Design, Drawing, Construction, Testing & Commissioning of Sewerage System, 225 KLD Sewage Treatment Plant (STP) & 75 KLD Effluent Treatment Plant (ETP) for Shishu Bhawan Hospital in Kataka including Operation & Maintenance for a period of Five Years.
- Estimated Cost : Rs.336.99 Lakhs to Rs.609.87 Lakhs
- Period of completion : 12 (Twelve) Months
- Date & Time of availability of bid document in the portal. : From 5.00 PM of Dt. 28.10.2026 to 5.00 PM of Dt. 17.11.2026
- Last date / time of receipt of bids in the portal : 5.00 PM of Dt. 17.11.2026
- Date & Time of opening of technical bids : 12.30 PM of Dt. 19.11.2026
- Name and Address of the Officer Inviting Bid : MD, WATCO, Telefax:- 0674-2571444, E-Mail : mdwatcoodisha@gmail.com
- The bidders have to participate in ONLINE bidding only.
Further details can be seen from the web site www.tendersodisha.gov.in .
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El Clasico: Flick, Mourinho and the morbo of all morbos

The iconic fixture that pits Barcelona versus Real Madrid continues to stop the world. Why does it evoke such interest? Why is there such 'needle' between the sides? And how will the managers of the two Spanish giants set their sides up for the latest edition of this bitter rivalry?

Srinivasan Ramani

When Real Madrid turns out against Barcelona on Sunday, expect a global audience of more than 600 million, much higher than even the largely India-based viewership of close to 400 million for the IPL final.

Why does El Clasico command such a vast, loyal following? One reason is football excellence: the two clubs have dominated Spain and Europe over the last two decades. Another is that they hosted two of the world's most famous athletes – Lionel Messi (Barcelona) and Cristiano Ronaldo (Madrid). The fan-bases built during that period have outlasted the two superstars.

What gives the fixture its heft is the rivalry's intensity – an antagonism that springs from historical, political and cultural divisions

Proxy battles

What gives the fixture its heft, though, is the rivalry's intensity. Phil Ball in 'Morbo: the Story of Spanish Football' describes "morbo" as a uniquely Spanish brand of antagonistic "needle" that turns football matches into proxy battles over historical, political and cultural divides.

El Clasico is the morbo of all morbos. Real, the capital city's main club, symbolises central Spain's grandeur, but reminds detractors of patronage from dictator Franco's regime. Barcelona, 'mes que un club' (more than a club), is a voice for Catalan identity which the dictatorship suppressed. But both are owned by members and run by business elites – the contrast is sharper in perception than in fact.

On the pitch, though, the difference is real. It dates back to Dutch great Johan Cruyff, who played for Barcelona (1973-78) and returned as coach in 1988 with totaalvoetbal, or total football. His 'Dream Team' won Barcelona's first European Cup in 1992 with a young Pep Guardiola at its heart.

When Guardiola became the coach in 2008, he took Cruyff's ideas to their furthest point with a team built largely on homegrown talent such as Xavi, Andres Iniesta, Sergio Busquets and Messi. It won 14 trophies in four seasons, humiliating Madrid 6-2 at the Bernabeu in 2009 and 5-0 at Camp Nou in 2010.

Madrid's answer was to hire Guardiola's antithesis, Jose Mourinho. His Madrid was fast, direct and physical, content to cede the ball and strike on the break. The results were mixed. Madrid won the 2011 Copa del Rey and the 2011-12 league with a record 100 points, and an exhausted Guardiola left soon after. But Barcelona won the 2011 Champions League, and Mourinho departed in 2013 with a split dressing room.

In the decade after the coaching stalwarts left, Madrid won the Champions League six times, while Barcelona won more league titles before a financial crisis forced it to let Messi go in 2021. The revival came after Hansi Flick's appointment in 2024, built out of necessity on La Masia graduates such as teenagers Lamine Yamal and Pau Cubarsi. Barcelona has since won two successive league titles, while Madrid has gone two seasons without a major trophy. So president Florentino Perez turned to the coach he had once hired to stop Guardiola, Mourinho.

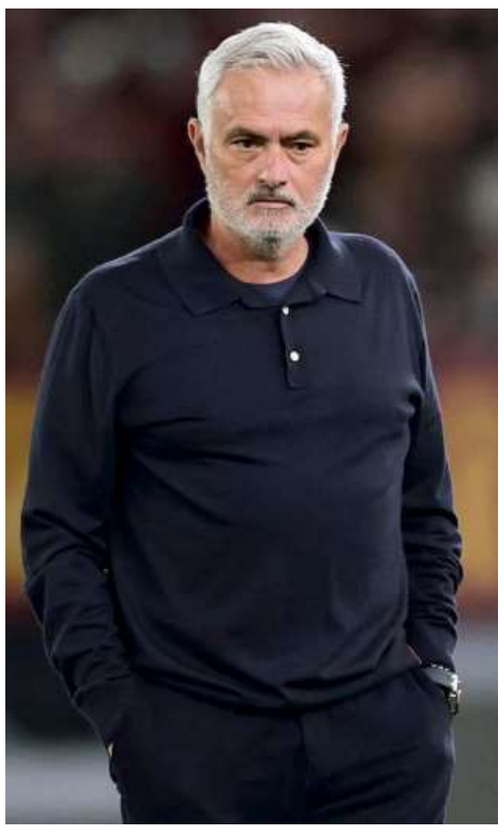


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HANSI FLICK



JOSE MOURINHO

This season, Barcelona has won all nine of its league games, scoring 39 goals and conceding just nine. Having lost three strikers in the off-season, it is led by winger Raphinha, who now plays as a No. 9 and has scored 12 goals in seven games. With Yamal and Anthony Gordon alongside, the forwards harass defenders with relentless pressing. Barcelona averages 21 shots a game, and its expected goals (xG) stands at 33.6, a high 0.18 per shot.

The Yamal effect

Raphinha may be the tip of the spear, but this well-oiled Barca is lifted by Yamal who comes closest to what Messi was in the club's heyday: a dribbler who can cut through defences at will from the right wing, and a terrific passer with a repertoire of tricks. With eight goals and six assists in nine games, he has been decisive at just 19.

Behind the forwards, former Ballon d'Or winner Rodri, who chose Barca over Real, has provided the steadiness that Barca lacked after Busquets left in 2023, freeing the precocious Pedri to orchestrate play.

Under Flick, the system is built to take risks. Barcelona holds 69.4% of the ball, according to data from MarkStats, and its 'field tilt', the share of touches in the final third, is 72.7%, by far the highest in LaLiga. A high defensive line works as an offside trap: Barcelona catches opponents offside 3.1 times a game and allows only 6.8 shots.

But when opponents do get through, usually in transition, their chances are good ones, worth 0.18 xG each. The risk is mitigated by goalkeeper Joan Garcia, who sweeps behind his defence. Flick's style is far more vertical than Guardiola's patient possession, moving the ball quickly to wingers who take on their full-backs.

Mourinho's Madrid, in contrast, has struggled to recreate the hallowed Kroos-Modric midfield and a gulf remains between the midfield and a formidable forward line. Madrid's field tilt is just 51.5%, seventh in the league. It has scored 23 league goals, 16 fewer than Barcelona.

Kylian Mbappe remains lethal, but Vinicius Jr. has slumped badly, and the two often crowd each other on the left. Both are reluctant pressers which is partly why Madrid paid up to €140 million for 19-year-old winger Yan Diomande, who works hard without the ball.

Mourinho was brought back, by most accounts, because the club's hierarchy had tired of a dissonant dressing room that had too much power. But his methods may be outdated. In 2021, tactics writer Michael Cox argued that Mourinho's approach was out of step with modern football, which is 'about universality': pressing from the front, attacking from the back. His football has evolved since but his philosophy remains reactive.

Spain's football has largely been a duopoly because Madrid and Barcelona keep adapting to each other, never letting the other dominate for long

Playbook with potential

But that one win, a 2-1 victory at the Bernabeu a year ago under Xabi Alonso, was instructive. Alonso played Federico Valverde at right-back and Arda Guler in a three-man midfield. Mourinho used a similar playbook against Sevilla. A midfield that holds the ball, wide players who track back, and Mbappe attacking the space behind Barcelona's high line is a blueprint that gives Madrid a better chance of competing. Vinicius' absence through suspension seems a blessing in disguise.

Spain's football has largely been a duopoly because Madrid and Barcelona keep adapting to each other, never letting the other dominate for long. Under Flick, Barcelona has updated Cruyffian principles with modern-day pressing. Star-studded Madrid has bet on Mourinho, who once managed, at least for a while, to compete against Guardiola.

Yet as Guardiola said in 2011, Mourinho might be the "boss" in the press room, but Barcelona would fight it out on the pitch. On Sunday, we will know if the pitch is still the answer to the Mourinho question.

STACKING UP

ATP Men's Top 15

#	Player	Age	Points	Events
1	Jannik Sinner	25	10,950	17
2	Alexander Zverev	29	10,070	20
3	Carlos Alcaraz	23	5,610	17
4	Ben Shelton	24	4,720	22
5	Daniil Medvedev	30	3,660	23
6	Flavio Cobolli	24	3,640	25
7	F. Auger-Aliassime	26	3,590	22
8	Alex de Minaur	27	3,430	24
9	Frances Tiafoe	28	3,380	22
10	Arthur Fils	22	3,325	19
11	Rafael Jodar	20	3,234	21
12	Novak Djokovic	39	3,090	16
13	A. Davidovich Fokina	27	2,880	24
14	Taylor Fritz	28	2,880	22
15	Tommy Paul	29	2,575	22

Top Indians ▶



Sumit Nagal
Rank 281 ▼ 28 spots



Manas Dhamne
Rank 393 ▲ 9 spots

WTA Women's Top 15

#	Player	Age	Points	Events
1	Elena Rybakina	27	9,196	20
2	Aryna Sabalenka	28	7,550	20
3	Mirra Andreeva	19	6,306	20
4	Jessica Pegula	32	6,235	19
5	Coco Gauff	22	5,974	19
6	Elina Svitolina	32	5,229	19
7	Karolina Muchova	30	4,833	19
8	Linda Noskova	21	4,678	19
9	Iga Swiatek	25	4,389	19
10	Marta Kostyuk	24	3,920	18
11	Maja Chwalinska	25	3,031	22
12	Iva Jovic	18	2,931	22
13	Diana Shnaider	22	2,663	22
14	Belinda Bencic	29	2,662	18
15	Elise Mertens	30	2,540	21

Top Indians ▶



Vaishnavi Adkar
Rank 365 ▲ 1 spot



Sahaja Yamalapalli
Rank 378 ▼ 19 spots

English Premier League Standings

#	Team	GP	W	D	L	GF	GA	GD	PTS
1	Man. City	7	7	0	0	19	7	12	21
2	Arsenal	7	6	0	1	11	5	6	18
3	Brighton	7	5	1	1	23	5	18	16
4	Chelsea	7	4	1	2	17	13	4	13
5	Liverpool	7	3	3	1	9	8	1	12
6	Brentford	7	2	4	1	13	8	5	10
7	Leeds United	7	2	4	1	9	6	3	10
8	Everton	7	2	4	1	8	7	1	10
9	Hull City	7	2	3	2	8	7	1	9
10	Ipswich Town	7	3	0	4	11	15	-4	9
11	Newcastle	7	2	2	3	10	14	-4	8
12	Aston Villa	7	2	2	3	7	11	-4	8
13	Man. United	7	1	4	2	10	10	0	7
14	Crystal Palace	7	2	1	4	9	17	-8	7
15	Bournemouth	7	1	3	3	9	13	-4	6
16	Tottenham	7	1	3	3	6	10	-4	6
17	Coventry City	7	2	0	5	6	14	-8	6
18	Fulham	7	1	2	4	7	10	-3	5
19	N. Forest	7	1	2	4	5	9	-4	5
20	Sunderland	7	1	1	5	6	14	-8	4

Italian Serie A Standings

#	Team	GP	W	D	L	GF	GA	GD	PTS
1	Inter Milan	7	6	1	0	21	9	12	19
2	Lazio	7	6	1	0	14	4	10	19
3	Roma	7	5	2	0	16	3	13	17
4	AC Milan	7	4	3	0	14	7	7	15
5	Como	7	4	2	1	12	7	5	14
6	Frosinone	7	4	1	2	13	9	4	13
7	Cagliari	7	4	1	2	6	7	-1	13
8	Juventus	7	3	2	2	9	8	1	11
9	Napoli	7	3	1	3	10	7	3	10
10	Torino	7	3	1	3	10	9	1	10
11	Atalanta	7	3	0	4	10	11	-1	9
12	Lecce	7	3	0	4	9	12	-3	9
13	Sassuolo	7	2	2	3	12	14	-2	8
14	Monza	7	2	1	4	13	15	-2	7
15	Bologna	7	1	2	4	6	10	-4	5
16	Udinese	7	1	1	5	9	16	-7	4
17	Genoa	7	1	1	5	5	13	-8	4
18	Fiorentina	7	1	1	5	8	17	-9	4
19	Parma	7	1	1	5	4	13	-9	4
20	Venezia	7	1	0	6	6	16	-10	3

Spanish LaLiga Standings

#	Team	GP	W	D	L	GF	GA	GD	PTS
1	Barcelona	9	9	0	0	39	9	30	27
2	Atletico Madrid	9	7	1	1	19	8	11	22
3	Real Madrid	9	7	0	2	23	9	14	21
4	Real Betis	9	6	1	2	16	14	2	19
5	Real Sociedad	9	5	1	3	17	17	0	16
6	Sevilla	9	4	2	3	14	16	-2	14
7	Alaves	9	3	2	4	13	10	3	11
8	Celta Vigo	9	2	5	2	10	7	3	11
9	Deportivo	9	2	5	2	13	12	1	11
10	Osasuna	9	3	2	4	10	18	-8	11
11	Levante	9	2	4	3	15	17	-2	10
12	Villarreal	9	2	3	4	13	13	0	9
13	Athletic Club	8	2	3	3	8	9	-1	9
14	Rayo Vallecano	8	2	3	3	12	17	-5	9
15	Getafe	9	2	3	4	5	11	-6	9
16	Espanyol	9	2	2	5	11	12	-1	8
17	Racing Santander	9	2	2	5	13	25	-12	8
18	Elche	9	1	4	4	11	17	-6	7
19	Valencia	9	1	3	5	6	15	-9	6
20	Malaga	9	0	4	5	6	18	-12	4

German Bundesliga Standings

#	Team	GP	W	D	L	GF	GA	GD	PTS
1	Bayern	6	4	2	0	22	5	17	14
2	Dortmund	6	4	2	0	11	4	7	14
3	SC Freiburg	6	4	1	1	15	6	9	13
4	Leverkusen	6	4	1	1	16	9	7	13
5	Mainz	6	3	1	2	14	10	4	10
6	Elversberg	6	3	1	2	12	11	1	10
7	RB Leipzig	6	3	0	3	16	11	5	9
8	Werder	6	2	3	1	12	12	0	9
9	Hamburg	6	3	0	3	6	15	-9	9
10	FC Augsburg	6	2	2	2	16	12	4	8
11	E. Frankfurt	6	2	2	2	10	16	-6	8
12	Cologne	6	2	1	3	8	11	-3	7
13	Stuttgart	6	2	0	4	8	10	-2	6
14	Hoffenheim	6	2	0	4	11	14	-3	6
15	Schalke	6	1	2	3	4	7	-3	5
16	SC Paderborn	6	1	2	3	5	9	-4	5
17	Union Berlin	6	1	2	3	5	17	-12	5
18	M'gladbach	6	0	0	6	8	20	-12	0

Test Batting

#	Player	Rating	Career best
1	Harry Brook	861	898
2	Steve Smith	822	947
3	Joe Root	816	932
4	Travis Head	778	884
5	Rachin Ravindra	740	740
6	Temba Bavuma	735	806
7	Rishabh Pant	713	801
8	Daryl Mitchell	710	804
9	Shubman Gill	709	807
10	Aiden Markram	706	759

Test Bowling

#	Player	Rating	Career best
1	Mitchell Starc	865	872
2	Matt Henry	861	870
3	Ollie Robinson	856	856
4	Jasprit Bumrah	853	908
5	Pat Cummins	846	914
6	Marco Jansen	831	831
7	Josh Hazlewood	818	864
8	Kagiso Rabada	799	902
9	Scott Boland	796	820
10	Noman Ali	777	853

ODI Batting

#	Player	Rating	Career best
1	Shubman Gill	841	855
2	Daryl Mitchell	794	840
3	Virat Kohli	781	908
4	Rohit Sharma	770	879
5	Ibrahim Zadran	719	756
6	Shai Hope	710	782
7	Babar Azam	689	894
8	Kusal Mendis	674	675
9	Joe Root	660	810
10	K.L. Rahul	653	676

ODI Bowling

#	Player	Rating	Career best
1	Rashid Khan	742	775
2	Abrar Ahmed	662	675
3	Keshav Maharaj	660	737
4	Mitchell Santner	644	656
5	Kuldeep Yadav	620	757
6	Maheesh Theekshana	616	680
7	Jofra Archer	611	682
8	Shaheen Afridi	601	691
9	Mehidy Hasan	596	722
10	Jayden Seales	591	591

T20I Batting

#	Player	Rating	Career best
1	Ishan Kishan	893	916
2	Abhishek Sharma	884	931
3	Sahibzada Farhan	883	883
4	Shreyas Iyer	798	829
5	Harry Brook	793	793
6	Jos Buttler	789	794
6	Dewald Brevis	789	806
8	Phil Salt	775	881
9	Shai Hope	759	766
10	Tilak Varma	726	745

T20I Bowling

#	Player	Rating	Career best
1	Rashid Khan	720	828
2	Adam Zampa	700	746
3	Adil Rashid	695	747
3	Abrar Ahmed	695	757
5	Nathan Ellis	675	678
6	Jamie Overton	674	674
7	Nasum Ahmed	661	661
8	Mahedi Hasan	654	654
9	Liam Dawson	648	652
10	Axar Patel	646	667

Hitting hard came naturally to me; but today, I wouldn't be in the top 100

Saurabh Tiwary made the journey from under-19 champion to cricket administrator in less than two decades. Along the way, he had his moments in the IPL, represented India and excelled at the domestic level. He speaks in this interview about the benefits of ex-cricketers running the game, the evolution of the IPL and his memories of playing with Kohli and Tendulkar

INTERVIEW

Saurabh Tiwary

P.K. Ajith Kumar

Saurabh Tiwary was often compared to M.S. Dhoni, as much for his big hitting as his long mane. The left-hander was a part of the Virat Kohli-led Indian team that won the Under-19 World Cup in 2008. He promised a lot, but played only three ODIs. He also has a stellar First Class record (8,076 runs, average of 47.22, 22 hundreds and 34 fifties). Tiwary now heads the Jharkhand State Cricket Association. Excerpts from an interview he gave *The Hindu* at Jamshedpur:

What made you take up cricket administration?

Some members of the JSCA approached me and said that I should fight the election. I said, 'Okay, I will fight.'

You won the election quite comfortably.

Yes, and I am grateful to all the members who have supported me. I decided to contest because I wanted to do something for the players. And as a player, I know what they need. When you have played cricket for 24 years, you know that. I have been trying to help the Jharkhand players since I took over as the JSCA secretary last year.

I believe a cricket association is there because of cricketers, and not the other way around. I ensure our players are given all the opportunities. Since facilities are less in Jharkhand, our players, male or female, are free to use the Ranchi stadium whenever they want.

I have won the Vijay Hazare Trophy, but never the Ranji Trophy or the Syed Mushtaq Ali Trophy. I want Jharkhand to win those tournaments. People often ask – What is the difference between a sportsperson and an administrator? The only difference is that a player can understand their emotions, because he has gone through that experience.

One of our players, Rajandeep Singh, is not fit, but he has been coming to our Ranchi stadium for the last three months. We have never abandoned any of the players who are injured. We have given them treatment.

> There are some memories that you have in cricket for a lifetime. One of them is batting with Sachin Tendulkar

So you would like more former cricketers to come into administration?

I think that when any player who has played for his State comes into administration, he will know how he can help his team develop.

In your time, there weren't many hard-hitting batters like you.

Hitting hard came naturally to me. I liked to bat that way. But if I were to play today, I wouldn't be in the top 100. Every second batsman is hitting so well. Even a 15-year-old Vaibhav Sooryavanshi is dominating in the IPL. We didn't have that much T20 cricket back then. Then scores like 140 or 150 used to be defended. Now even 250 cannot be defended. Power-hitting has taken over.

PHOTO: K.R. DEEPAK



SAURABH TIWARY

> Today's boys are all very strong. They hit continuously and do not get tired

Do you see any change in technique?

It is all the mindset. People have played so much T20 cricket, they know they can come back into a match. Sometimes I see the score in an IPL match after 10 overs is 70 for five. If you switch off the TV and move a little here and there, and you turn the TV on again, you will see the score is 210 for seven.

Today's cricket has almost become a game of power-hitting. They hit continuously and do not get tired. In ODIs, you see teams chasing down scores like 370. And batters are hitting double hundreds inside 43 overs.

Today's boys are all very strong. The kind of training they do at gyms is also a factor. If you want to become strong, then you have to do weight-training.

PHOTO: K. BHAGYA PRAKASH



You played for more than a decade in the IPL right from its inaugural edition in 2008. How much has it changed over the years?

Now it is very difficult to predict which team would be good. Earlier, every year one or two new players would emerge from the IPL. Now I think every year two or three players emerge from a team. Now India has such good bench strength because of the IPL. If you perform well there, you are in the limelight. You can play for India. If you play for five or six years in the IPL, you have financial security. Your life becomes better. There are a lot of players who have not played for India, but you still know their names. The IPL is the reason for that. When I started playing in the IPL, I did not imagine it would become this big. The full credit goes to the BCCI.



PHOTO: P.K. AJITH KUMAR

You were the emerging player of 2010. You scored an unbeaten 52 off 31 balls to help Mumbai Indians beat Royal Challengers Bangalore (as it was known then) in the semifinal.

I also remember playing a crucial innings [38 not out] against RCB in the Champions League T20 in South Africa that year. There are some memories that you have in cricket for a lifetime. One of them is batting with Sachin Tendulkar. It was my dream to play with him.

You were part of an Indian team that won the Under-19 World Cup in Malaysia. Your teammates included Virat Kohli, Ravindra Jadeja and Abhinav Mukund...

Winning that World Cup was a dream come true for me. If you win anything for India, it is a big achievement. All those things, and memories ... they will be with you as long as you live.

It was fun. If you look at the whole batch, many players went on to play for India [the senior team].

Did you imagine at the time that Kohli would develop into the cricketer and the leader he became?

I am not at all surprised. He played with the kind of hunger that we still see today. He plays his cricket with so much passion and honesty. As for his leadership quality, it was the first time that he became the captain. But there was no doubt about his dedication and focus.

How do you look back at the final against South Africa?

Please don't remind me of it. I got run out. I will never forget that. But overall, that World Cup was a very good experience.

Your international career didn't last long...

When I was playing, it was already a packed Indian team. I remember I used to come to the team when someone got injured. It was very difficult to get into the team. But at the same time, I didn't perform that well. And I didn't perform that well in the IPL after 2010. But I have no regrets. Cricket has given me everything. Sometimes I even wonder if I deserve all this. Everything is cricket for me. Today, I am talking to you because of cricket.

GAME THEORY

Relentless excellence at the wheel

With back-to-back wins in Malaysia and Singapore, Max Verstappen extended his streak of Formula One seasons with a race victory to 11. This is also the longest ongoing unbroken string of campaigns with at least one finish on the podium's top step. How does the four-time World champion stack up against the giants of the sport in this regard?

MOST CONSECUTIVE SEASONS WITH AT LEAST ONE WIN

Driver	Seasons	Total
Michael Schumacher	1992–2006	15
Lewis Hamilton	2007–2021	15
Max Verstappen	2016–2026 (ongoing)	11
Alain Prost	1981–1990	10
Ayrton Senna	1985–1993	9
Nelson Piquet	1980–1987	8
Stirling Moss	1955–1961	7
Jim Clark	1962–1968	7
David Coulthard	1997–2003	7
Jackie Stewart	1968–1973	6
Sebastian Vettel	2008–2013	6



MICHAEL SCHUMACHER



LEWIS HAMILTON



MAX VERSTAPPEN



ALAIN PROST



AYRTON SENNA

SOURCE: F1

PICTURE THIS



GETTY IMAGES

Sunlit run

An athlete competes in the run portion of the Ironman World championship earlier this month in Kailua Kona, Hawaii.

The Ironman triathlon, which comprises a 3.9-km swim, a 180.2-km bicycle ride and a 42.2-km marathon, is widely considered one of the most arduous one-day competitions in all of sport.

The Ironman World championship was the original Ironman triathlon, and it has been held annually in Hawaii since 1978. First staged in O'ahu, it moved to Kailua-Kona in 1981.

The event is popular enough to merit television coverage in multiple continents.

"Swim in the turquoise waters of Kailua Bay, bike across the raw, volcanic landscapes of the Queen Ka'ahumanu Highway, and run under the radiant Hawaiian sun toward the finish line on Ali'i Drive," says the race's official website, painting an alluring picture.

But while the setting is gorgeous, the athletes — tested to breaking point by the harsh conditions — are more concerned with surviving the race than taking in the sights. The course record was set in 2024 by Patrick Lange (7 hrs, 35 min, 53 sec).

OUT AND IN

Kishan unavailable for second game, Kushagra added as cover



X@BCCI

India batter Ishan Kishan will be unavailable for the second T20 International against New Zealand in Christchurch owing to a right adductor strain that he suffered in the series-opener. "Ishan Kishan is ruled out due to a low grade right adductor strain," the BCCI said. Kumar Kushagra has been added to the squad as cover.

KEEPING IT SIMPLE

There was not really anything to overcomplicate, says Dhir



AP

Actually, we discussed that if we hit two good shots, just proper cricketing shots, two boundaries, then the game would end right there. There was not really anything to overcomplicate — India all-rounder Naman Dhir, who made an unbeaten 15-ball 42, on the conversation with skipper Shreyas Iyer in the middle.

BELOVED'S DISTINCTION

Biza becomes second youngest to make a half-century against India



X@ZIMBABWECRICKET

Zimbabwe's Beloved Biza, at 17y 9m 19d, became the second youngest after England's Sarah Taylor (17y 3m 5d) to make a 50-plus score against India in women's ODIs. Her 92-ball 62 kept the Indian bowlers at bay and took the visitors to 197. "I was looking to play straight and bat as many overs as I could," said Biza.

AT THE HELM

Awana to head the BCCI junior selection committee



BCCI

Former India pacer Parvinder Awana, who played two T20Is, was on Friday appointed chairman of the newly formed BCCI junior selection committee. The other members of the panel are Krishna Das, Rakesh Patel and N. Arjun Yadav. "The fifth member will be appointed shortly," said the BCCI.

Bowlers under the lens as another run-fest beckons

Sooryavanshi likely to get an opportunity in India's playing XI in place of the injured Kishan; New Zealand skipper Santner says the biggest challenge will be to contain the visiting team's top-order which ran riot in the opener

INDIA IN NZ

Press Trust of India
CHRISTCHURCH



Blazing away: Samson and Abhishek's blistering start provided the ideal launchpad for the big chase. AFP

The rescue act by the batters was impressive but India's bowling attack needs to find its rhythm and figure out a way to contain a rather destructive New Zealand in the second T20 International here on Saturday.

As has been the case of late, the batters saved the day for India after the bowlers endured another ordinary outing. The record chase of 226 gave the visiting team a crucial 1-0 lead but it also highlighted frailties that can cost the side heavily in the remainder of the five-match series.

A concern

The fifth and sixth bowling options have been a concern for India with the all-rounders not yet doing justice to those roles in the absence of an injury-prone Hardik Pandya.

Finn Allen and his fellow opener Tim Seifert were able to pick Bhuvneshwar and Arshdeep Singh for boundaries at will in the PowerPlay, putting the seasoned duo under immense pressure.

Like on Thursday night, the conditions are expected to be ideal for batting, leaving the bowlers with very little room for error. Axar Patel, too, would be under pressure, having given away the most runs in the first T20.

On the batting front, the Indian and New Zealand supporters will, in all likelihood, get to see Vaibhav Sooryavanshi bat. The space in the playing XI has been created due to Ishan Kishan's injury. In Mitchell Santner's own words, his team's biggest challenge on Saturday night would be to contain the in-form Indian top-order.

In top gear

Sanju Samson and Abhishek Sharma wreaked havoc in the PowerPlay, putting the New Zealand bowlers to the sword.

Considering the depth of the Indian batting, New Zealand will surely need to bowl better to make a match of it.

The teams (from):
New Zealand: Mitchell Santner (Capt.), Finn Allen, Michael Bracewell, Mark Chapman, Devon Conway, Jacob Duffy, Lockie Ferguson, Zak Foulkes, Matt Henry, Bevon Jacobs, Kyle Jamieson, Adam Milne, Daryl Mitchell, Glenn Phillips, Tim Seifert, and Nathan Smith.

India: Shreyas Iyer (Capt.), Tilak Varma (Vice-capt.), Abhishek Sharma, Sanju Samson, Vaibhav Sooryavanshi, Axar Patel, Shivam Dube, Nitish Kumar, Naman Dhir, Kumar Kushagra, Prince Yadav, Mayank Yadav, Arshdeep Singh, Bhuvneshwar Kumar, Varun Chakaravarthy, and Kuldeep Yadav.

Match starts at 12.30 p.m. IST.

Kotak praises 'fearless attitude' of the openers

Press Trust of India
CHRISTCHURCH



Marauding southpaws: Abhishek and Sooryavanshi can take the game away from the opposition in a jiffy. ANI

India batting coach Sitanshu Kotak, on Friday, lavished praise on openers Sanju Samson and Abhishek Sharma, saying that the big-hitters have immense control over their minds apart from "power, talent and intent".

Kotak added that the think-tank should be "appreciated" for sticking with Samson and Abhishek despite the social media-fuelled clamour for the inclusion of 15-year-old sensation Vaibhav Sooryavanshi.

"There is a lot of speculation on social media about the three openers. So, sometimes, social media should also appreciate that the management calls are for the good of the team. People want to play their own XI, but it does not work like that," Kotak said on the eve of the second T20I against New Zealand here.

"Sanju is outstanding, he is a power-packed player. If you ever put yourself in the place of a batter and think that you have to hit three or four sixes in the first two overs, you will be afraid of getting out. If you get out early in two or three games, you would think that you would get dropped. So, overcoming all that and the intent they (openers) are showing... that excites me.

"It is amazing that on top of power, talent and intent, they are controlling their minds. To get them into that fearless attitude... it is unbelievable," added Kotak.

The coach felt that the hype surrounding a young player like Sooryavanshi was not good for him. "Everyone is saying that he should play, but he is not getting the space. He is too young. It is sad and it is sad for the other players who are performing. People related to cricket, they should think about it," Kotak said, adding that the teenager was constantly learning and had never complained about being left out.

NEW ZEALAND
VS
INDIA
2ND T20 | TODAY | 11:30 AM
SONY SPORTS 1 | SONY SPORTS 3 | SONY liv
हिन्दी

Pratika's unbeaten century makes it a walk in the park

ZIMBABWE IN INDIA

Lavanya L.
VADODARA



Terrific trio: Pratika and Shafali piled on Zimbabwe's misery with an unbroken 106-run stand after Shree Charani kept the away team in check. BCCI

On October 23, 2025, Pratika Rawal and Smriti Mandhana registered stunning centuries against New Zealand to bring a struggling ODI World Cup campaign back on track in Navi Mumbai.

Exactly a year later, Pratika (100 n.o., 96b, 15x4), with help from a marauding Shafali Verma (64 n.o., 33b, 5x4, 4x6), raised her bat once more to earn India a crushing nine-wicket win over Zimbabwe in the first ODI at the BCA Stadium here on Friday.

A struggle

Zimbabwe avoided a collective slow roast under the scorching sun and India's big-hitting prowess by opting to bat first, but struggled to get going on the red-soil pitch.

The home team's tight lines and smart use of early swing condemned the visitor to a nervy crawl.

The Lady Chevrons managed three partnerships of over 40 runs. Chipo Mugeri-Tiripano and Modester Mupachikwa resisted the host's charge, after which 17-year-old Beloved Biza took over, making best use of India's wavering concentration to notch up her fourth ODI fifty.

Also useful for the away side were a few blips in the field and the occasional width given, especially by Deepti Sharma and debutant Jintimani Kalita.

N. Shree Charani (four for 23), however, punctuated any audacity shown with a miserly effort and four wickets to record her best figures in the format.

An enterprising cameo by Michelle Mavunga kept alive Zimbabwe's dream of a total in excess of 200, only for it to guttingly fall short of that mark by three runs.

Chasing a meagre 198, Smriti and Pratika's 94-run opening stand reduced Zimbabwe to a herd of deer in the headlights. Olinder Chare dismissed Smriti in the 16th over, but Shafali, batting at No. 3 for only the second time in the format, didn't disappoint.

Her 106-run unbroken partnership with Pratika sealed the contest with 137 balls to spare, getting India off to a winning start in the ICC Championship.

The scores: Zimbabwe 197 in 49.5 overs (Beloved Biza 62, N. Shree Charani 4/23, Kranti Gaud 3/42) lost to India 200/1 in 27.1 overs (Pratika Rawal 100 n.o., Shafali Verma 64 n.o.). **Toss:** Zimbabwe; **PoM:** Pratika.

Good to be back in the room and score runs, says Pratika

Lavanya L.
VADODARA

Who will open with Smriti Mandhana? This was the big question on the lips of those watching along as India set out to chase 198 in the first ODI against Zimbabwe here on Friday.

Smriti, recently appointed full-time skipper, opted to open with Pratika Rawal, sending Shafali Verma to No. 3, a spot usually occupied by Jemimah Rodrigues, who is missing due to injury.

The results will have no one complaining, though, with Pratika scoring a solid century and Shafali blitzing away to a half-century, securing a simple win for India in the process.

"Before going in to bat, I saw highlights on the TV of the game against New Zealand (from the 2025 World Cup), and I thought that was the game where I scored my last hundred," Pratika said after the game.

"Good to be back in the room, always good to score runs and contribute to a team's victory by batting as long as I can. It was one of those days when the ball went where I wanted it to. Luckily, it turned out really good," she added.

Happy to learn

Shafali, barely made for the slow-steady mode, was aware of the limitations of the no.3 role.

"Of course, I didn't get that 10 over PowerPlay with just two fielders outside. I just tried to take the singles and I will learn these things. ODIs are testing my patience, but I am really happy to learn," she quipped.

The win was set up by N. Shree Charani's career-best figures of four for 23, which included three maiden overs on a pitch that didn't have much turn for the tweakers. "I bowled to my strengths. I just focused on my lengths. In our bowling meetings before every game, we work on sticking to the channel and on attacking the stumps. We did that today," the 22-year-old said.

INBRIEF



Mona and Nishad to be India's flag-bearers

Shooter Mona Agarwal and jumps specialist Nishad Kumar will be India's flag-bearers at the closing ceremony of the Asian Para Games, scheduled for Saturday. They won two gold each at the Games. The 38-year-old Mona contracted polio at the age of nine, affecting both her lower limbs and leaving her dependent on a wheelchair. The 27-year-old Nishad's right arm was severed by a grass-cutting machine at his family's farm in Himachal Pradesh when he was six years old.



Asian TT: India's long wait for a mixed doubles medal ends

Harmeet Desai and Yashaswini Ghorpade ensured India's first mixed doubles medal at the Asian table tennis championships in 72 years by reaching the semifinals here on Friday. The Indian pair battled past South Korea's Park Ganghyeon and Lee Daeun 3-2 (11-6, 8-11, 8-11, 11-9, 11-9) in a gripping quarterfinal to secure at least bronze. India's previous mixed doubles medals at the event came in 1952, when Gool Nasikwala and Kalyan Jayant won gold, and in 1954, when Yatin Vyas and Meena Parande secured silver.

Anahat enters maiden PSA Gold-level semifinal

India's Anahat Singh entered her maiden PSA Gold-level semifinal at the Silicon Valley Open squash in Redwood City, the USA. The 18-year-old recorded a thrilling five-game victory (4-11, 11-8, 4-11, 11-2, 11-5) over Egyptian sixth seed Salma Hany in 42 minutes.

AFC supports Infantino's re-election as FIFA president

The head of the Asian Football Confederation on Friday said the region supported Gianni Infantino's bid for re-election as FIFA president following fierce criticism of his aborted World Cup sell-off plan. The 56-year-old Swiss was present at a Tokyo meeting of the AFC when president Sheikh Salman bin Ebrahim al-Khalifa gave his unequivocal backing. The AFC, in August, had joined UEFA (Europe) and CONCACAF (North and Central America and the Caribbean) in condemning Infantino over his plan to open FIFA's premium competitions such as the World Cup to private investors.

India surpasses expectations with best haul of 114 medals

Nitesh and Naveen win in badminton men's singles while Thulasimathi and Manasi top in women's doubles; Mona triumphs in shooting; Sandeep runs to a 400m World record

ASIAN PARA GAMES

Press Trust of India
NAGOYA

India's para-athletes surpassed all expectations to deliver their best ever show at the Asian Para Games, ending with 114 medals, including 30 gold, following a record-shattering final day flourish here on Friday.

India had sent 168 athletes for this edition, which was nearly half of the contingent size that went to Hangzhou in 2023 and returned with the then best ever of 108 medals, including 27 gold.

The overall tally closed with 30 gold, 35 silver, and 49 bronze.

India is currently placed fourth on the table but that might change as a few finals are slated for Saturday and the country does not have a presence in them.

On Friday, India collected nine gold medals, its highest single-day haul in this edition.

The shuttlers delivered three golds through Nitesh Kumar and Naveen Sivakumar.

Nitesh beat compatriot and Tokyo Paralympic gold-medallist Pramod Bhagat 21-18, 21-16 in men's singles SL3 final before securing the mixed doubles SL3-SU5 silver with partner Thulasimathi Murugesan.



Mona (50m rifle 3p). PTI



Thulasimathi & Manasi. X@MEDIA_SAI

Naveen then defeated Indonesia's Fredy Setiawan 21-9, 21-17 in the men's singles SL4 category.

Thulasimathi then combined with Manasi Joshi to win the women's doubles SL3-SU5 title, beating China's Yang Qiuxia and Xiao Zuxian 21-16 21-13 in the final.

Thulasimathi had earlier lost the women's singles SU5 final 18-21 11-21 to Yang Qiuxia to get silver.

In athletics, Sandeep and Haney won gold medals with world record performances in the men's



Proud moment: Sandeep came up with a stellar show. X@MEDIA_SAI



Naveen (badminton SL4). X@MEDIA_SAI

400m T64 and men's javelin throw F37/38 events. Sandeep clocked 52.28s, a world record, while Ajay Kumar took bronze in 53.61s. Haney produced a world record throw of 60.49m.

Sumit Antil led an Indian sweep of the men's javelin throw F42-44/61-64 combined event with a best effort of 72.46m. Finishing behind him were Mahendra Gurjar (59.03m) and Sanjay Sandeep Sargar (64.48m).

The wheelchair-bound Pranav Soorma won the men's club throw event with a Games record of 32.87m.

Nimisha Chakkungalparambil and Parmod Bijarnia claimed the women's long jump T47 and men's 1500m T46 silvers.

Para-shooter Mona Agarwal with 357.5 shattered the world record to win the women's 50m rifle 3 positions SH1 competition. She earlier won the women's 10m air rifle standing SH1 event with a Games-record score of 250.0, while Avani Lekhara bagged silver with 249.6.

In recurve archery Harvinder Singh and Vijay Sundi defeated China's Yun Duo and Zhao Lixue 5-1 in the men's doubles final while Bhawna Choudhary and Pooja Jatyan lost to China's Gao Zihan and Wang Xueqian 0-6 in women's doubles final.

In swimming, Himanshu Nandal completed a hat-trick of bronze medals, adding another podium finish in men's 100m freestyle S11 clocking 1:5.90s.



Climbing the ladder: An improved performance helped Pranavi bounce back strongly. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Chiara remains on top; Pranavi tied second

INDIAN OPEN GOLF

Uthra Ganesan
GURUGRAM

Chiara Tamburlini managed to hold on to her slender lead at the top even as Pranavi Urs stayed within striking distance and local favourite Vani Kapoor willed herself back into contention on day two of the Hero Women's Indian Open.

The tricky and challenging DLF Golf and Country Club stayed true to its reputation, testing the best and punishing every mistake as the overnight leaders struggled and the disciplined stroke-players survived on Friday. After a roller-coaster opening round, Chiara was more in control, starting the day with a birdie on the 10th hole. She followed it with an uneventful back nine, parring the remaining eight to make the turn on one-under 35. A bogey-birdie to finish off on the last two holes helped her end with 71 for a two-day total of 138, two shots adrift of Pranavi and Magdalena Simmermacher of Argentina at tied second.

Pranavi, who bogeyed the 10th to start with, had a better outing on the second day, sinking three birdies on the front nine to finish with a two-under 70 for the second day running even as Magdalena parred for the day. But the biggest cheer was for Vani on her home course.

The 32-year-old ensured she would maintain her record of never missing the cut here in her 14th outing, shooting a 69 for the day – the lowest score of round two and one of only two golfers to do so. That included an eagle on the par-4 14th.

Defending champion Shannon Tan, meanwhile, slipped to tied-15th after a horror run – five bogeys and a double bogey – on the front nine for a five-over 73 for the day.

Top scores (day two):
138: Chiara Tamburlini (Sui);
140: Pranavi Urs, Magdalena Simmermacher (Arg); **141:** Sara Kouskova (Cze), Dorthea Forbrigd (Nor), Camille Chevalier (Fra).

Sindhu in semifinals; Ashmita crashes out

BADMINTON

Press Trust of India
PARIS

P.V. Sindhu cruised into the women's singles semifinals with a straight-game win, while Ashmita Chaliha's impressive run ended in the quarterfinals of the French Open Super 750 badminton tournament here on Friday.

The former World champion was in complete control and took 39 minutes to brush aside Taiwan's Chiu Pin-chian 21-13, 21-14 in the quarterfinals of the $950,000 tournament.

"I think I learnt a lesson in the first round. I was leading and then I let her come into the match and it was very crucial in the end. After that, I was more aware while leading. I didn't think that it was easy, or that the game was over (against Pin-chian)," Sindhu said.

However, it was the end of the road for the 27-year-old Ashmita, who had stunned three-time World champion Akane Yamaguchi of Japan in the pre-quarterfinals on Thursday.

The World No. 36 Indian went down fighting 10-21, 21-17, 16-21 to former World champion Nozomi Okuhara of Japan.

The results (quarterfinals):
Women: P.V. Sindhu bt Chiu Pin-chian 21-13, 21-14; Nozomi Okuhara bt Ashmita Chaliha 21-10, 17-21, 21-16.

Advani edges Hall, wins 29th World title; Shruthi completes a hat-trick

BILLIARDS

Press Trust of India
BIRMINGHAM

Pankaj Advani proved that he remains a formidable force on the circuit to pocket a staggering 29th career World title by winning the WBL World billiards championship here. The 41-year-old beat England's Robert Hall 1906-1206 in the final.

In the five-player women's draw, India's Shruthi L defeated Eva Palmius of Sweden 414-153 to complete a hat-trick of titles.

Advani was the only Indian in the last-four. Hall had reached the World billiards championship final five times before this without crossing the finish line. For Advani, it was about extending his unparalleled record of world titles in cue sports.Advani defeated fellow Indian Sourav Kothari 1134-575 in the three-hour quarterfinal earlier and got the better of in-form David Causier 1607-1271 in the last-four stage.

Making a switch

Advani will now start preparing for the IBSF World snooker championship that will be held in Indore mid-November.

The results (final):
Men: Pankaj Advani bt Robert Hall (England) 1906-1206.
Women: Shruthi L bt Eva Palmius (Swe) 414-153.



Pankaj Advani. WORLD BILLIARDS



Shruthi. WORLD BILLIARDS

LIVE TELECAST

New Zealand vs India: Second T20I, Sony Sports Ten 1 & LIV, 12.30 p.m.
Premier League: SS Select 1, 2 & JioHotstar, 5, 7.30 & 10 p.m.
LaLiga: FanCode, 5.30, 7.45, 10 p.m. & 12.30 a.m. (Sunday)
Serie A: Unite8 Sports 1, 2 & Z5 App, 6.30, 9.30 p.m. & 12.15 a.m. (Sunday)
Bundesliga: Unite8 Sports 1, 2 & Z5 App, 7 & 10 p.m.
ISL: Sony LIV app, 7.30 p.m.
Formula One: United States GP, Qualifying, F1 TV, F1 TV Pro App & FanCode, 2.30 a.m. (Sunday)

Stud Poker can repeat in the Derby; Time And Tide for Sprinters' Cup; Red Bishop appeals most in Stayers' Cup

MYSURU: Stud Poker, who is in fine nick, may score an encore in the Zavaray S Poonawalla Mysore Derby (2000m), the well-tuned Time And Tide is expected to score in the Zavaray Poonawalla Sprinters' Cup (1200m) and Red Bishop, who maintains form, appeals most in the Zavaray Poonawalla Stayers' Cup (3000m), the chief attractions of the races to be held here on Saturday (Oct. 24). False rails (width about 2m from 1,600m to the winning post) will be in position.

1 MADRAS RACE CLUB MILLION (1,600m), rated 20 to 45, 1-00 p.m.: 1. Golden Sabre (2) Neeraj 61, 2. Versace (16) Indrajeet K 60, 3. Desert Shield (1) S. Sachin 57.5, 4. Sensuous (11) Suraj 57.5, 5. Holy Valor (15) S. Saqlain 57, 6. Misty Warrior (4) B. Dharshan 55.5, 7. Tyaaraa (5) Vinod Shinde 55.5, 8. Valor Queen (14) Trevor 55.5, 9. Military Code (8) B.R. Kumar 55, 10. Wanganui (6) Antony 55, 11. Kallania (12) Lave Kumar 54.5, 12. Sunlit Path (7) Varun 54, 13. King Scarface (13) S.G. Prasad 53, 14. Alluring Beauty (3) S.F. Ansari 52.5, 15. Lex Luthor (10) Shreyas S 51.5 and 16. Eco System (9) Shyam K 51. **DESERT SHIELD:** *A comfortable winner over (1,400m), in the lower class; retains form.* **SENSUOUS:** *A faraway second to Moon Oracle over (1,400m), tracking well.* **VALOR QUEEN:** *Found Stud Poker (1,400m) was too good on her debut run; has improved since.* **WANGANUI:** *A good second to Tipped Off over (1,600m), in fine condition.*
1. DESERT SHIELD, 2. SENSUOUS, 3. WANGANUI

2 COROMANDEL GROMOR JUVENILE MILLION (1,200m), 3-y-o only, (Terms), 1-30: 1. Astraeus (6) G. Vivek 56, 2. Haboob (3) Saddam H 56, 3. V Cash (1) Indrajeet K 56, 4. Amber Storm (5) Vinod Shinde 54.5, 5. Celtic Goddess (7) Trevor 54.5, 6. Crazy Love (2) Neeraj 54.5, 7. First Choice (14) N.S. Parmar 54.5, 8. Garzian (11) Jagadeesh 54.5, 9. Mandalay (12) Antony 54.5, 10. Mother's Gift (15) Akshay K 54.5, 11. Mysore Pak (16) A. Baandal 54.5, 12. Osaka (13) Yash 54.5, 13. Sindoor (8) Mukesh K 54.5, 14. Speed Company (4) Salman Khan 54.5, 15. Tejash (9) Inayat 54.5 and 16. Youreoneandonly (10) H.M. Akshay 54.5. **ASTRAEUS:** *First run; judiciously prepared.* **CELTIC GODDESS:** *Fit for the fray.* **MANDALAY:** *Looks fit and well.* **OSAKA:** *A consistent runner; continues to shine in the trails.*
1. ASTRAEUS, 2. CELTIC GODDESS, 3. MANDALAY

3 MYSORE MILLION (1,200m), rated 20 to 45, 5-y-o & over, 2-00: 1. Master Way (7) Md. Talib 61, 2. Tigerking (2) Prabhu K 61, 3. Mriga (9) H.M. Akshay 59, 4. My Solitaire (15) Antony 59, 5. Satin Lass (6) Rafique S.K 58.5, 6. Furious Fun (4) Asirvatham 58, 7. Major Saab (10) Aleemuddin 58, 8. Amazing Joy (16) Abhishek Mhatre 55, 9. Star Symphony (5) B.R. Kumar 55, 10. Black Rainforest (12) Mukesh K 54, 11. Feeling Good (11) A. Asbar 54, 12. Absolute Katrina (13) Salman Khan 53.5, 13. Amazing Storm (8) Indrajeet K 52, 14. Elevado (1) A. Bandaal 52, 15. Glowing Moonlights (3) B. Dharshan 50 and 16. Golden Stride (14) Shyam K 50. **SATIN LASS:** *A failed favourite in Cosette's 1,400m; may make amends.* **MAJOR SAAB:** *An easy winner over 1,400m in the lower class; may repeat.* **STAR SYMPHONY:** *Twice second; may raise a winning gallop.* **FEELING GOOD:** *May spring a surprise.*
1. MAJOR SAAB, 2. STAR SYMPHONY, 3. SATIN LASS

4 ZAVARAY POONAWALLA SPRINTERS' CUP (1,200m), 4-y-o & over, 2-30: 1. Black Eagle (7) Gaurav S 57, 2. Crown Drive (2) G. Vivek 57, 3. Echoes Of Time (6) A. Asbar 57, 4. Encino (4) Suraj 57, 5. Money Bags (5) Trevor 57, 6. Rieko (3) Akshay K 57 and 7. Time And Tide (1) Sandesh 57. **ENCINO:** *An impressive winner of his last start at Pune; retains form.* **MONEY BAGS:** *A rousing performer; in fine nick.* **TIME AND TIDE:** *Fit for the fray.*
1. TIME AND TIDE, 2. MONEY BAGS

5 ROYAL CALCUTTA TURF CLUB MILLION (1,200m), rated 60 to 85, 3-10: 1. Sicyon (5) Trevor 60, 2. Crosswater (10) Aleemuddin 58.5, 3. Grizzly (9) Rafique S.K 58.5, 4. N R I Ace (15) Md. Talib 56.5, 5. Silver Quest (2) H.M. Akshay 56.5, 6. Vibrant Queen (1) A. Hangal 56, 7. Flight On (8) Akshay K 55, 8. All Attraction (4) Salman Khan 54, 9. Gloriousness (14) M. Prabhakaran 54, 10. The Flying Feet (13) H. Rahul 54, 11. Art Collector (6) Faiz 53.5, 12. Malet Spring (16) C.A. Brisson 53.5, 13. Flaming Sword (11) Neeraj 53, 14. Storm Majesty (3) Sandesh 53, 15. Selma (12) Vinod Shinde 52 and 16. Eagle Eye (7) A. Asbar 51.5. **SICYON:** *Winner of his last two starts; may make it three in a row.* **FLAMING SWORD:** *A last outing winner; retains form.* **STORM MAJESTY:** *An easy winner of his previous start; in fine trim.* **EAGLE EYE:** *Appeals on weights.*
1. STAR MAJESTY, 2. EAGLE EYE, 3. SICYON

6 ZAVARAY S POONAWALLA MYSORE DERBY 2026 (2,000m), 3-y-o only, (Terms), 3-40: 1. Arc Of Life (8) Darshan 56, 2. Black Irish (10) Trevor 56, 3. Edison (11) N.S. Parmar 56, 4. Garfunkle (3)Mukesh K 56, 5. Stud Poker (7) Suraj 56, 6. The Archer (6) Shreyas S 56, 7. Tipped Off (5) Yash 56, 8. Madante (4) Sandesh 54.5, 9. Mahogany (9) G. Vivek 54.5, 10. Royal Legacy (1) Akshay K 54.5 and 11. Yarra Yarra (2) Antony 54.5. **BLACK IRISH:** *A good second to Stud Poker; may trouble the best.* **STUD POKER:** *Winner of his last two starts; may make it three in a row.* **MAHOGANY:** *Winner of her last two starts; in fine nick.* **ROYAL LEGACY:** *Won three races in a row; track movements pleasing.*
1. STUD POKER, 2. BLACK IRISH, 3. MAHOGANY

7 ZAVARAY POONAWALLA STAYERS' CUP (3,000m), 4-y-o & over, (Terms), 4-20: 1. Dream Alliance (2) Akshay K 57, 2. Dyf (4) Yash 57, 3. Natural Diamond (1) S. Saqlain 57, 4. Ramiel (–) (–) 57, 5. Red Bishop (5) G. Vivek 57 and 6. Victor Hugo (3) L.A. Rozario 57. **DYF:** *A stout stayer; may trouble the best.* **RED BISHOP:** *Winner of the Indian St. Leger (2,800m) at Pune; is in great heart.*
1. RED BISHOP, 2. DYF

8 HYDERABAD RACE CLUB MILLION (1,400m), rated 40 to 65, 5-00: 1. Money Fair (8) R. Pradeep 60.5, 2. Shining Ways (9) Suraj 59.5, 3. Ziva (1) S. Sachin 59, 4. Balgownie (2) Inayat 58.5, 5. Pilot Officer (15) S. Saqlain 58.5, 6. Crimson Pirate (16) Sandesh 57.5, 7. Refined Aggression (5) Trevor 57.5, 8. Final Call (13) Akshay K 57, 9. Waitara (3) Antony 56, 10. Badshaah (–) (–) 55.5, 11. Charlie Brown (4) S. Imran 55, 12. Beautiful Bloom (6) Vishal S 54.5 13. Chief Admiral (7) S.F. Ansari 54, 14. Hazel (12) H. Rahul 54, 15. N R I Victory (10) Neeraj 54 and 16. Seize The Grey (11) N.S. Parmar 51.5. **MONEY FAIR:** *A comfortable winner of his last start; may repeat.* **SHINING WAYS:** *A good second to Iron Mirage over (1,400m); continues to shine in the trails.* **REFINED AGGRESSION:** *A consistent runner; in good shape.* **FINAL CALL:** *Has improved after her second to Mister Brown (1,600m).* **SEIZE THE GREY:** *Comes into the reckoning on his fourth to Stud Poker (1,600m); well in at the weights.*
1. SHINING WAYS, 2. SEIZE THE GREY, 3. REFINED AGGRESSION
Day's best: **STUD POKER**
Double: **ASTRAEUS – STORM MAJESTY**
Jkt: 4, 5, 6, 7 and 8; Mini Jkt: 5, 6, 7 and 8; Tr (i): 1, 2 and 3; (ii): 3, 4 and 5; (ii): 6, 7 and 8.

Can youthful Moneybags stem Time And Tide?

RACING

Cyrus J. Madan

The Mysore Race Club has conjured up a truly magical weekend, with five Grade-1 and one Grade-2 race scheduled to be run in a span of 48 hours. It is a watershed moment for the country's youngest Turf Authority. The last time we witnessed something like this was in December 2019, when the RWITC encapsulated 5 Grade 1 Races, one Grade 2 and one Grade 3 into a single afternoon.

Saturday (October 24) will see three Grade-1 races being run and each wears a very open outlook. Time And Tide, the six-year-old champion sprinter, will look to carve out a bit of history in the Zavaray Poonawalla Sprinters' Cup. He is bidding for a third successive Sprinters crown, a feat that has not been achieved since the race came into being in 1979.

Taking him on, with age on their side, will be two four-year-olds – Moneybags and Encino. Moneybags has the home advantage and is on a six-race winning streak. Although the heart goes with Time and Tide, form seems to point to Moneybags. Has the time come for youth to stem the tide?

Intriguing

The Zavaray S Poonawalla Mysore Derby is even more intriguing. Only three of the 11 three-year-olds have ever gone over 2000 metres, but none has won over the distance. The got-abroad gelding Stud Poker, who won the Mysore 2000 Guineas, should have first call despite the fact that he's going over this trip for the first time. The fillies Royal Legacy and Mahogany could run him close.

With defending champion Ramiel withdrawn, Red Bishop and 2024 winner Dyf are the prime contenders for the gruelling 3000m Zavaray Poonawalla Stayers' Cup. Red Bishop, the only four-year-old in the field, is the Indian St. Leger winner and his form looks good. It's age against experience, and although Red Bishop is taking on one of the finest stayers in the land, he could prevail.

Live broadcast

The live broadcast of the Invitation Cup weekend races, including the awards night, will be available free of charge on YouTube and the Mysore Race Club website. It is being arranged by Zavaray S. Poonawalla in association with Mysore Race Club.

Barcelona aims to extend lead as Real arrives

With Raphinha fit again and winger Yamal enjoying a state of grace, Flick will be confident of getting a positive result over Mourinho & Co.

LALIGA

Agence France-Presse
BARCELONA

For weeks LaLiga leader Barcelona has been eagerly awaiting Sunday's Clasico as a chance to stretch the gap between itself and rival Real Madrid to a massive nine points.

Some turbulence in the final approach to the clash at Camp Nou has complicated the picture for Hansi Flick's Spanish team, which suffered its first defeat of the season at Paris Saint-Germain in the Champions League on Tuesday.

By contrast Real Madrid has won four consecutive matches, thrashing RB Leipzig on Wednesday, and starting to look, for the first time since Jose Mourinho's arrival this summer, like a team. Despite that, the equation remains favourable for Flick. With Raphinha fit again and teenage winger Lamine Yamal enjoying a state of grace, Barcelona will be confident of building on its six-point lead over third-placed Real.

A Clasico often proves a fork in the road. Last season Real won the first meeting but Vinicius Junior's outraged reaction at being substituted pulled apart the fragile seams of Xabi Alonso's new era.

On Sunday Brazil international Vinicius is suspended. Even aside from his underwhelming performances, his absence may help Real in terms of providing a clearer path for Mourinho. The good news for Barcelona is that it still has the Midas touch – everything turns to goals.

Mbappe and Yamal are both hoping they will be crowned the planet's best player on Monday at the Ballon d'Or ceremony, but the bigger prize for their teams would be a Clasico victory.





Battle of the No. 10s: With the Ballon D'Or looming, leading contenders Yamal and Mbappe will hope to make a statement. AFP

We showed great character: Kusal Mendis

ODI TRI-SERIES

Agencies
RAWALPINDI

Sri Lanka captain Kusal Mendis hailed his teammates for showing great character and belief during the historic 430-run pursuit against England in the tri-series thriller here on Thursday. The Lankans pulled off the second highest successful chase in ODI cricket, achieving the target with a ball to spare.

"We chased very well, I enjoyed it as the captain. The coach (Gary Kirsten) and I spoke to the batters and asked them to play normally in the first couple of overs. We had to look at how we were going to play thereafter. Everybody showed character and believed that we could do it," said a delighted Kusal.

A century from Pavan Rathnayake and explosive knocks from Avishka Fernando, Dasun Shanaka and Janith Liyanage were crucial to Sri Lanka's triumph. "In every team meeting, we talk about showing character... it is about showing that we can get any score."

England captain Harry Brook, who had smashed the fastest double century earlier in the day, was disappointed that his stunning knock was not enough for a win.



Sheer brilliance: Rathnayake's ton kept Sri Lanka on track. AP

Australia faces selection headache for Cape Town decider

AUS IN SA

Agence France-Presse
SYDNEY

Australia captain Pat Cummins admits it is hard to "paper over the cracks" after a thumping second Test defeat to South Africa, with the fate of at least three players hanging in the balance.

"Clearly need to be a lot better than that if we want to compete," Cummins said.

"I think a loss can sometimes kick you into gear. You can maybe paper over the cracks sometimes in a win. Whereas I think in a loss, it makes you ask questions as a player of yourself."

Heading into the third Test, there are question marks around at least three players, not least the underperforming Marnus Labuschagne who has gone three years without a Test century.

"He's actually doing the hard bit, he's getting to 30," Cummins said of Australia's No. 3 batter.

"I think he's got to find a way to turn those into bigger scores – 30s aren't going to win you many matches.

"So, again, we'll work on that in the next couple of days. It's one Test match left in the series, we've got to win this."

Cummins admitted some hard decisions would have to be made.

"That's the challenge. Do you give someone one more game, or do you feel like now is the right time to make a move?" he said.

"Does it feel like someone's just about to turn the corner, and they're going to be away, or does it now feel like the right time for a change-up?"

Sambudla climbs to the top of the F4 Indian championship

MOTORSPORTS

Sports Bureau
CHENNAI

Luviwe Sambudla emerged as the weekend's standout performer, claiming two victories and a third-place finish to move to the top of the standings in the third round of the F4 Indian championship at the Madras International Circuit here on Friday.

Sambudla turned a five-point deficit into a 21-point championship advantage, moving to 138 points ahead of Aris Kyriakou (117). Across the 3.717-kilometre circuit, Sambudla showcased exceptional pace and racecraft, winning the opening two races from sixth on the grid before completing his weekend on the podium. Ntiyiso Mabunda finished second in all three races while 15-year-old Aaron Mehta delivered a composed performance under pressure in the final race to become the youngest winner in the championship's history.

Meanwhile, Speed Demons Delhi's Shahan Ali Mohsin converted pole position into victory in a closely contested opening race of the Indian Racing League (IRL), holding off Goa Aces JA Racing's Raoul Hyman by just 0.506 seconds over eight laps. Chennai Turbo Riders' Shane Chandaria completed the podium 2.690s behind the winner, while Hyderabad Blackbirds' Mohammed Ryan recovered from seventh to finish fourth.



Third-round honours: Winner Sambudla flanked by runner-up Mabunda (left) and third Narola. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

GOVERNMENT OF ARUNACHAL PRADESH
OFFICE OF THE EXECUTIVE ENGINEER: TALI DIVISION
PWD A.P :TALI

No. TD/W- 12/2026-27/939-44 Dated Tali the 22/10/2026

NOTICE INVITING E- TENDER

The Executive Engineer, Tali Division, PWD A.P, Tali, on behalf of the Governor of Arunachal Pradesh invites online item rate tender in Single stage bidding Process from all eligible registered contractors in appropriate class domiciled within Kra-Daadi District as per Arunachal Pradesh District based Entrepreneurs and professionals (incentives, development and promotional) Act 2015 and subsequent amendment published vide notification published in Arunachal Pradesh extra ordinary Gazette vide no. 247Vol-XXVII dated 2nd November 2020 for following work(s).

TABLE

Sl. No.	NIT No.	Name of Work	Estimated Cost Put to Tender (Rs.)	Earnest Money Deposit (Rs.)	Cost of Tender Document (in Rs.)	Period of Completion.
1	2	3	4	5	6	7
1	TD/W-12/2026-27/04	**C/o Permanent Infrastructure Development of Nyokum Ground at Tali..**	**Rs. 4,88,11,586.00**	**Rs. 4,88,116.00 (APST), Rs. 9,76,232.00 (Non APST)**	Rs. 5000.00	24 (Twenty four) Months

The bids are to be submitted both **Online** in the website. **http://arunachaltenders.gov.in** and in **Hard Copies** of the same to the **office of the Executive Engineer, Tali Division, PWD, AP, Tali.** The bid form and other guidelines can be downloaded from our website **http://arunachaltenders.gov.in, w.e.f 22/10/2026 to 30/10/2026 (1230 Hours).** Last date of received of tender documents shall be **30/10/2026 at 12.30 PM** and same will be opened on **30/10/2026 at 1.30PM at Office Chamber of Chief Engineer, SID&P PWD, Nirman Bhawan, Itanagar.**
Those contractors not registered on the website mentioned above are required to get registered beforehand. The intending e-tendering bidder must have valid digital signature with facility of signing & encryption to submit the bid. The interested bidders shall have to read terms & conditions carefully before participating tender.
For details visit:- **http://arunachaltenders.gov.in**

Note: Detail information of the work and conditions of contract may be seen in the tender document. The completion period for execution of work is **24(Twenty four) months.**
Payment will be done according to phasing and release of fund.

1. Tender documents can be Download from - **http://arunachaltenders.gov.in w.e.f 22/10/2026(1000hrs) to 30/10/2026 (1230 hrs)**
2. Last Date and time tor receipt of bids **30/10/2026 up to 12.30 PM** and shall be opened on the same day at 1.30 PM in presence of intending contractors or their authorized representatives.
3. The Original Copy of Earnest Money Deposit as specified in Clause 9 to 9.1 of NIT (CPWD Form-6) of bid document in favor of the Executive Engineer, Tali Division, PWD AP, Tali, shall be enclosed with the tender document in separate sealed envelope.
4. Eligibility Criteria: The participants must have successfully executed three similar works each of value 40% of the estimated cost or two similar works each of value 60% of the estimated cost or one similar work of value 80% in Central/State Govt. organizations/PSU's during last five years.
5. The Participants must submit proof of possessing T & P as which are likely to be used in carrying out the work as required under SCHEDULE - F of the tender document failing which the tender shall be rejected by employer as Non Responsive.
6. The intending firms/Contractors shall furnish a No Due Certificate (NDC) from Arunachal Pradesh State Co-Operative Apex Bank Limited, duly issued on or after 31/02/2026 by the Managing Director Cum Chief Executive Officer, Naharlagun. No tender paper shall be issued to any intending bidder without submission of aforesaid certificate from Arunachal Pradesh State Co-Operative Apex Bank Limited.
7. The Arunachal Pradesh District Based Entrepreneurs Professionals, Incentive. Development & Promotional Act 2015 shall be applicable in this tender.
8. The Earnest Money Deposit (EMD) from APST contractors shall be accepted as per Government Order No. SPWD/W-182/2013(pt)/ dated 06/07/2015 on production/ submission of valid document In original as proof of his/her being as APST Contractor.
9. The Tender without Earnest Money in proper form shall be summarily rejected.
10. The competent authority reserves the right to reject any or all the Tender without assigning any reason.
11. The bidder has to submit an affidavit regarding litigation and the competent authority reserves the right to reject the bid if the bidder found to be in litigation as and when detected without assigning any reason.
12. The Eligibility of Contractor shall be as per conditions laid down in Arunachal Pradesh District Based Entrepreneurs and Professionals (Incentives, Development and Promotional) Act, 2015 published in Arunachal Pradesh Gazette Vide No. 224 Volume XXII Naharlagun 11th September 2015. **and subsequent amendment.**

Executive Engineer,
Tali Division PWD A.P
Tali

DIPR/ARN-221

CENTRAL RAILWAY
Pune Division
CORRIGENDUM
TENDER NOTICE NO.: PUNE_ELECT_TRD_2026_09, DTD. 01.10.2026
The tender was published in the newspaper on 07.10.2026.
Revised similar nature of work definition has been incorporated on Revised tender document as well as on IREPS technical Eligibility criteria condition & same has been uploaded on IREPS website & Tender closing date & time for subject Tender has been extended from **30.10.2026 12:00 Hrs to 30.11.2026 12:00 Hrs**. For details please visit on website **www.ireps.gov.in**
SAN- 44 **Sr. DEE (Traction), Pune**
Traveling with dangerous and explosive goods is a punishable offense

NORTH EASTERN RAILWAY
Tender Notice
Dy. CME/Plant for Chief Workshop Manager, N.E. Railway, Mechanical Workshop, Gorakhpur for and on behalf of President of India invites tender through online E- Open Tender for the following work:- **S.No. (1),** E-Tender Notice No. & Name of the work: Tender No.- "29-GKP-MWS-2026-27" "DPT of Under Slung Components Brackets at Mechanical Workshop, Gorakhpur." Estimated cost (In Rs.) : 2847300.00, Earnest Money (In Rs.) : 57000.00, Cost of the Tender forms: Zero, Last date of tender submission : Up to 11.00, Date : 13.11.2026 Period of Contract : 12 Months. The details of above tenders are also available on Indian Railway Website http://www.ireps.gov.in
Dy. CME/Plant, Mechanical Workshop,
CPRO/Mech-96 **N.E. Railway, Gorakhpur**
"Never travel on roof and foot boards"

BHAKRA BEAS MANAGEMENT BOARD
NOTICE INVITING E-TENDER

Name of Office	NIT No. Name of Work	Starting Date (Time) Closing Date (Time) Opening Bid (Time)	Estimated Cost Earnest Money in (Rs.)
Additional Superintending Engineer, Operation & Maintenance Division, BBMB Bhiwani	**E-NIT-07/O&M/BWN/2026-27 Date 15.10.2026** (E-Tender for Renovation of Control Room at 220 KV SubStaion BBMB Charkhi Dadri).	15.10.2026 at 10:00 Hrs 17.11.2026 at 15.00 Hrs 18.11.2026 at 15.00 Hrs	Rs. 25.26 Lakhs Rs. 25,300/-
Executive Engineer, Bhakra Dam Division, BBMB, Nangal Township	**NIT No. 253/BDD/2026** Construction of road to connect the existing road Barmala to Neilla through Tunnel at Bhakra Dam Nangal.	21.10.2026 at 09.00 AM 21.11.2026 at 03.00 PM 23.11.2026 at 12.00 PM	Rs. 1,17,62,428.00 Rs. 2,35,250.00
Executive Engineer, O&M, Division, BBMB, Delhi	**E-NIT 15/OMD/2026-27 Dated: 16.10.2026** Maintenance of caretaker room of officer rest house & security check post at 220kV substation, BBMB, Delhi.	From 16.10.2026 at 18:00 hrs. upto 11.11.2026 at 12:00 hrs	Rs. 7,75,380/- Lakhs Rs. 7,755/-
	E-NIT 16/OMD/2026-27 Dated: 21.10.2026 Mtc. of Non-Residential Buildings at 220 KV Sub-Station, BBMB, Delhi.	From 21.10.2026 at 18:00 hrs. upto 11.11.2026 at 12:00 hrs	Rs. 9,99,990/- Lakhs Rs. 9,990/-
	E-NIT 17/OMD/2026-27 Dated: 21.10.2026 Estimate for water proofing treatment of roof top control room at 220 KV Sub-Station, BBMB, Delhi.	From 21.10.2026 at 18:00 hrs. upto 11.11.2026 at 12:00 hrs	Rs. 4,91,700/- Lakhs Rs. 4,920/-

Note: Detailed tender invitation notice can be downloaded from BBMB Website **www.bbmb.gov.in** & **www.etenders.gov.in**.
If there is a need for any extension in the due date, its corrigendum will be posted on the website itself.
333-PR-Board Sectt.-4 **FOR YOUR BETTER TOMORROW SAVE ENERGY TODAY**

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Supply of 950 nos of Jewel Safe to various branches of IOB Pan India
Detailed advertisement is available in the Bank's website **www.iob.bank.in** under the Tender section.
Last Date: 13.11.2026
Deputy General Manager

SANJAY GANDHI POST GRADUATE INSTITUTE OF MEDICAL SCIENCES
Raebareli Road, Lucknow-226014
NOTICE
Stage-II Examination - Advt. No. I/08/1-12/Rectt/2025-26
(Nursing Officer and Hospital Attendant Grade-II)
All the candidates are hereby informed that the Stage-II Examination for the posts of Nursing Officer and Hospital Attendant Grade-II against Advertisement No. I/08/1-12/Rectt/2025-26 will be held on 01 November 2026 (Sunday) in Lucknow District.
The examination will be conducted in Offline Mode (Pen & Paper Based) on OMR Sheet.
The Admit Cards will be available for download on the Institute's website **www.sgpgims.org.in**, 48 hours prior to the examination.
Candidates are requested to regularly visit the Institute's website for further information and updates.
ADVT.No.: I/56/Rectt/2026-27

GOVT. OF BIHAR
BIHAR COMBINED ENTRANCE COMPETITIVE EXAMINATION BOARD
I.A.S. Association Building, Near Patna Airport, Patna-14.
Website : bceceboard.bihar.gov.in / Helpdesk : helpdesk.bceceboard@bihar.gov.in
POST GRADUATE DENTAL ADMISSION COUNSELLING (PGDAC)-2026
for MDS in Govt./ Private Dental colleges of Bihar
Advt. No.- **BCECEB(PGDAC)-2026/07 Dated : 23.10.2026**
Notice regarding Extended Round-3 Online Application & Choice Filling

Pursuant to the public Notice of Ministry of Health & Family Welfare (Dental Education) Govt. of India, New Delhi Letter No. V.1 2025/84 12024-DE dated 12.10.2026 regarding lowering down the qualifying cut-off percentile for NEET - MDS-2026 for each category, all eligible candidates as per Revised NEET(MDS)-2026 Result / Cut-off may do Registration and submission of Application form for admission in Govt. as well as Pvt. Dental Colleges of Bihar on vacant seats of MDS Courses after admission on the basis of PGDAC-2026 Round-2 Counselling which was held from 29.09.2026 to 30.09.2026.

As per above letter of Deptt. of Health and Family Welfare, Govt of India dt. 12.10.2026 qualifying cut-off percentile for admission in MDS courses has been lowered down as follows;

S.No.	Category	Revised Cut-off Percentile	Revised Cut-off Marks
i.	General (UR/EWS).....	29.424	234
ii.	UR-PwBD	24.424	218
iii.	SC / ST / OBC (Including PwBD of SC/ ST/ OBC).....	19.424	200

2. The candidates who have already given their Consent or submitted fresh application as per Adv. No. BCECEB(PGDAC)-2026/04 Dated 02.10.2026 need not to apply again but if want to edit their Application Form Data / Choices may edit their Application Form Data / Choices / Consent as per instructions provided in Adv. No. BCECEB(PGDAC)-2026/04 Dated 02.10.2026.
3. Eligibility criteria for counselling, Fee payment procedure, instructions, Extended Important Dates and other details are available in the prospectus of PGDAC-2026 and **Advertisement No. BCECEB(PGDAC)-2026/06 Dated 23.10.2026 & 2026/04 Dated 02.10.2026 which can be downloaded from the Board's website : bceceboard.bihar.gov.in.**

Controller of Examination

HARYANA POWER GENERATION CORPORATION LIMITED
RAJIV GANDHI THERMAL POWER PLANT, KHEDAR, HISAR
(A Unit of Haryana Power Generation Corporation Limited)
EXPRESSION OF INTEREST (EOI)
For Long-Term Sale of Dry Fly Ash through Auction and Linked Utilisation of Pond Ash from RGTPP, Khedar
Memo No. Ch-11/XEN/CMD-II(DFA)/2026-27/RGTPP/F-29
Dated: 15.10.2026

RGTPP, HPGCL proposes to explore a long-term arrangement for sale of Dry Fly Ash (DFA) through a transparent auction process. This EOI is being issued to obtain market inputs from cement manufacturers and fly ash / ash-based product manufacturers regarding the annual DFA quantity they can lift, the preferred tenure of the long-term arrangement and the indicative rate at which they would be willing to purchase DFA. HPGCL is also planning to link utilisation of Pond Ash with the long-term DFA arrangement. The agency lifting DFA may also be offered Pond Ash (optional) from the RGTPP ash dyke on requirement basis and on an "as is where is" basis, subject to availability and applicable statutory requirements. Excavation / loading and transportation of Pond Ash shall be in the scope of the agency. The agency is requested to indicate the quantity of Pond Ash proposed to be lifted and whether it is willing to lift the same on chargeable basis, free of cost, or against some incentive in the form of rebate in the applicable DFA rate.
Interested agencies may visit the official website of HPGCL at **https://hpgcl.org.in** for detailed information regarding the EOI, including the prescribed format for furnishing the required information and the important terms and conditions. The interested agencies shall submit their offers in the prescribed format as per the following details: -

Last Date & Time for Submission	**7 days from date of issue of EOI**
Mode of Submission	**By e-mail and/or sealed hard copy**
Submission / Contact	**Executive Engineer/CMD-II, RGTPP, HPGCL, Khedar, Hisar**

————sd————
Executive Engineer/CMD-II,
For Chief Engineer/RGTPP,
1187/11/39/2027/50458/C/199/7 **HPGCL, Khedar, Hisar.**

Wasteful Railways pips Indian Army

The three-time defending champion lacks incisiveness in front of goal, even as it emerges victorious; BPCL beats Hockey Unit of Tamil Nadu 5-1

MURUGAPPA GOLD CUP

S. Prasanna Venkatesan
CHENNAI



Leaving it late: If not for Rawat's 57th-minute goal, Railways would have had to settle for a draw. R. RAGU

Indian Railways (RSPB), the three-time defending champion, was far from its best but edged Indian Army 2-1 in the Pool-A match of the 97th edition of the All-India MCC-Murugappa Gold Cup hockey tournament at the SDAT Mayor Radhakrishnan Stadium on Friday.

While Railways showed some impressive defensive work, its attack lacked the incisiveness expected of a side that has won three consecutive titles. Army, in contrast, pressed higher and advanced with greater purpose for much of the contest.

Railways took the lead in the 12th minute when Lovepreet Singh, after taking a penalty corner, positioned himself in front of the goal to deflect Jasjit Singh's drag-flick past the goalkeeper.

In the second quarter, Pratap Lakra's drag-flick off Arjun Sharma's penalty corner struck Rahul's arm on the goal-line, earning Railways a penalty stroke. However, Lakra hit the crossbar. Army made Railways pay for its missed opportunity when Ankush tapped in from close range in the 28th minute to restore parity.

Railways squandered two penalty corners in the fourth quarter, with Lakra's flicks being thwarted by the goalkeeper. It finally found the breakthrough in the 57th minute, when Yogember Rawat converted Lovepreet's penalty-corner delivery with a drag-flick past the goalkeeper.

The results: Pool-A: Indian Railways 2 (Lovepreet Singh 12-pc, Yogember Rawat 57-pc) bt Indian Army 1 (Ankush 28).

Indian Oil Corporation Ltd. 4 (Gurjinder Singh 19-pc, 38-pc, Gazee Khan 37, Sunil Yadav 57) drew with Punjab National Bank 4 (Gursimran Singh 21-PC, Thounaojam Ingalemba Luwang 24, Sanjay 27-pc, Abhimanyu 33).

Pool-B: Bharat Petroleum Corporation Ltd. 5 (Devindar Walmiki 4-pc, Mandeep Singh 5 & 57, Subhan Abid 24, Charanjeet Singh 54) bt Hockey Unit of Tamil Nadu 1 (K. Muthukumar 49).

47 titles. One name. An Se-young

BADMINTON

J.B. Sadhana
CHENNAI



Striving hard: An Se-young wants to keep rising the bar and refuses to rest on her laurels. GETTY IMAGES

A record that stood for decades fell in Odense last weekend, and it took the one opponent who has tested An Se-young more than any other to make her earn it.

History was one win away. Across the net stood Akane Yamaguchi, the rival who has pushed the South Korean to the brink time and again. An fought for every point, and when she rallied past Yamaguchi to defend her crown, her title count stood at 47, surpassing Susi Susanti's 46.

She has no plans to stop there. "I want to make a lot of history and break records, but I focus on one match at a time. That is my motivation," An said after the Denmark Open 2026.

At 24, the reigning Olympic and World champion has spent more than 100 consecutive weeks at World No. 1.

This season, she has won nine titles, with 61 wins and just one defeat, against China's Wang Zhiyi in the All England Open final.

It has been a golden year for An, and three more titles would top her 11 titles from 2025, starting with the French Open in Paris. Some champions are made by winning. An was made by losing. In 2021, she left her first Olympics in the quarterfinals, beaten by China's Chen Yufei at 19. Within months, she won three straight titles.

The pattern repeated, and so did the pain. At the 2023 Asian Games final, her right knee was failing her, yet she refused to stop and beat Chen for gold. In 2024, she became South Korea's first Olympic women's singles champion since 1996. This year, she won her second World Championship singles title, a first for a South Korean woman.

Susanti retired in 1997, and Marin arrived roaring, but An simply keeps rebuilding, one match at a time.

India batter Meghana retires from all forms of cricket

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI



Meghana. GETTY IMAGES

India's top-order batter Sabbhineni Meghana on Friday announcement her retirement from all forms of cricket at the age of 30.

Hailing from Andhra Pradesh, Meghana last played for India in November 2022. She played for RCB and Gujarat Giants in the Women's Premier League. She last played for India in November 2022.

"As I announce my retirement from all formats of cricket as a player, my heart is overflowing with gratitude," Meghana wrote in an Instagram post. "The field has been my second home, teaching me resilience, humility, and giving me memories and friendships that I will carry for a lifetime," she wrote.

> While my cricket days come to an end, my bond with cricket will never break

"While my cricket days come to an end, my bond with cricket will never break. I will always stay deeply connected to the game and intend to dedicate my life to giving back to the sport, mentoring the next generation, and serving the game that gave me everything," she added.

She made her India T20I debut against the West Indies back in 2016. Six years later, she played her first ODI. She scored a fifty each in both the formats.

Mhatre undergoes hamstring surgery

Press Trust of India
MUMBAI

India under-19 World Cup winning skipper and Mumbai vice-captain Ayush Mhatre has undergone surgery for his right hamstring injury and is likely to remain on the sidelines for two-three months.

Grade 4 tear

Mhatre had suffered a Grade 4 tear in his right hamstring while running between the wickets on the first day of Mumbai's Ranji Trophy season opener against Chandigarh here on October 11.

It was his first game since being sidelined from a left hamstring injury during the IPL while playing for Chennai Super Kings against Sunrisers Hyderabad on April 18.

"Ayush Mhatre underwent right hamstring surgery yesterday (on Thursday)," a BCCI source added.

Loba fires EBFC to big win over Inter Kashi

ISL

Press Trust of India
PUNE



Ramirez celebrates after scoring the opener. X@EASTBENGAL_FC

Ake Loba scored a brace as East Bengal FC produced a commanding performance to thrash Inter Kashi 5-1 in an Indian Super League match here on Friday.

Dani Ramirez, P.V. Vishnu and Lukasz Zwolinski too found the back of the net for East Bengal in a lopsided contest.

The defending champion made a dominant start, with Ramirez scoring in the eighth minute. After receiving the ball on the right side of the penalty area, Ramirez lifted it over Albino Gomes to put East Bengal ahead.

The Torchbearers doubled their advantage in the 16th minute through Vishnu, who finished a swift counterattack with a left-footed strike into the bottom-left corner.

East Bengal extended its lead in the 22nd minute when Loba converted a penalty, awarded after Ramírez was brought down by Wayne Vaz.

Inter Kashi pulled one back in the 28th minute after Lalchungnunga scored an own goal.

However, East Bengal continued to attack, with Loba completing his brace to make it 4-1 before halftime. Lukasz Zwolinski came off the bench and scored his first goal in the ISL for East Bengal in the 81st minute.

The result: Inter Kashi 1 (Lalchungnunga 28-og) lost to East Bengal 5 (Ramirez 8, Vishnu 16, Loba 22-pen, 35, Lukasz Zwolinski 81).

Senthamizh Arasu keeps his senior Indian team dream alive

S. Prasanna Venkatesan
CHENNAI



Senthamizh Arasu.

At 25, Indian Army goalkeeper Senthamizh Arasu has not given up on his dream of playing for the senior Indian hockey team. The native of Arcot town in Vellore, who won bronze with the Junior India team at the 2017 Sultan of Johor Cup, is still waiting for an opportunity to prove himself at the highest level.

"I keep playing, trying to give my best at all National-level tournaments. I'm waiting, working hard and practising every day," he said on the sidelines of the 97th All-India MCC-Murugappa Gold Cup hockey tournament here on Friday.

Ready

"I am ready for the opportunity whenever it comes. Even an opportunity for the National team trials would do. I'm only 25, I still have a lot to do."

Arasu, whose heroics in the penalty shootout against Karnataka helped Tamil Nadu win bronze at the 2023 senior Nationals, said he learnt a great deal from former Ireland goalkeeper David Harte at the Accord Tamil Nadu Dragons camp in HIL.

"I have watched David Harte since childhood, and learnt a lot from him in HIL. He taught me about quick reactions and, more importantly, the mindset. When we concede a goal, we sometimes dwell on it. He taught me that the team keeps playing and we must be ready for the next ball," he said.

A regular at the Murugappa tournament, Arasu is determined to overcome a familiar stumbling block.

"We have lost in the semifinals for three consecutive years. This is my fourth season, and we will see what happens this time. We are ready," he said, hoping the tournament would bring him closer to his long-cherished India dream.



Nikkhil and Divyanshi. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Nikkhil beats Somdev; Divyanshi downs Ishita

TABLE TENNIS

Sports Bureau
CHENNAI

Nikkhil Mannath edged past Somdev Sengupta 12-10,11-5, 2-11, 7-11, 11-5, while Trishal Surapureddy got the better of Ronald Sarkar 12-14, 12-10, 11-7, 13-11 in the boys' singles on the opening day of the WTT Youth Contender Chennai 2026 at the Tamil Nadu Physical Education and Sports University here on Friday.

In the under-17 girls' singles, India's Divyanshi Bhowmick cruised past Ishita Colaso 11-4, 11-8, 11-9, while USA's Satya Aspathi fought back to beat Preetika Prabhu 9-11, 11-7, 11-9, 6-11, 11-4.

The biggest upset of the day came from unranked Avisha Karmakar, who stunned Shreya Limaye 11-5, 11-6, 11-2 in straight games.

Bayern coach Kompany in hospital after collapsing

Agence France-Presse
BERLIN

Bayern Munich coach Vincent Kompany was taken to hospital by an emergency medical team on Friday after collapsing during training, the club said.

"Vincent Kompany had to seek medical attention on Friday after collapsing during a training session with FC Bayern's reserve team," Bayern said.

"Kompany is undergoing thorough examinations at the hospital and will remain under medical care."

Kompany, the 40-year-old former Manchester City defender, missed training and a press conference on Tuesday ahead of Bayern's Champions League draw against Arsenal at the Allianz Arena.

SOOPER

Chennai Petroleum Corporation Limited
(A Government of India Enterprise and a group company of IndianOil)
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Tel: 044-24349833 / 24346807
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CPCL A Navratna Company

EXTRACT OF THE STATEMENT OF AUDITED STANDALONE AND CONSOLIDATED FINANCIAL RESULTS FOR THE QUARTER AND HALF YEAR ENDED SEPTEMBER 30, 2026

(₹ in crore)

Sl. No.	Particulars	STANDALONE						CONSOLIDATED						
		QUARTER ENDED			SIX MONTHS ENDED		YEAR ENDED	QUARTER ENDED				SIX MONTHS ENDED		YEAR ENDED
		30.09.2026	30.06.2026	30.09.2025	30.09.2026	30.09.2025	31.03.2026	30.09.2026	30.06.2026	31.03.2026	30.09.2025	30.09.2026	30.09.2025	31.03.26
		Audited	Audited	Audited	Audited	Audited	Audited	Audited	Unaudited	Audited	Audited	Audited	Audited	Audited
1	Total income from operations	22109.22	29376.45	20069.09	51485.67	38761.70	78705.24	22074.34	29376.45	20476.14	20039.86	51450.79	38732.60	78676.14
2	**Net Profit / (Loss) for the period (before Tax, Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)**	**3031.57**	**1365.56**	**994.29**	**4397.13**	**914.19**	**4121.62**	**3007.31**	**1380.24**	**1912.55**	**981.93**	**4387.55**	**918.53**	**4162.47**
3	Net Profit / (Loss) for the period before tax (after Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	3031.57	1365.56	994.29	4397.13	914.19	4121.62	3007.31	1380.24	1912.55	981.93	4387.55	918.53	4162.47
4	Net Profit / (Loss) for the period after tax (after Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	2271.29	1016.67	731.55	3287.96	674.93	3061.85	2247.03	1031.35	1421.85	719.19	3278.38	679.27	3102.70
5	**Total Comprehensive Income for the period [Comprising Profit / (Loss) for the period (after tax) and Other Comprehensive Income (after tax)]**	**2285.90**	**1011.64**	**739.67**	**3297.54**	**689.68**	**3055.11**	**2261.64**	**1026.32**	**1396.64**	**727.31**	**3287.96**	**694.02**	**3096.15**
6	Paid up Equity Share Capital (Face Value - ₹ 10 each)	148.91	148.91	148.91	148.91	148.91	148.91	148.91	148.91	148.91	148.91	148.91	148.91	148.91
7	Reserves (excluding Revaluation Reserve)				12894.49	8154.77	10401.07					13194.10	8427.26	10710.26
8	Securities Premium Account				250.04	250.04	250.04					250.04	250.04	250.04
9	Networth				13293.44	8553.72	10800.02					13593.05	8826.21	11109.21
10	Debt Equity Ratio				0.16	0.22	0.18					0.16	0.22	0.18
11	Earnings Per Share (of ₹. 10/- each) (for continuing and discontinued operations)													
	(i) Basic (₹ / share)	152.53	68.27	49.13	220.80	45.32	205.62	150.90	69.26	95.48	48.30	220.16	45.62	208.36
	(ii) Diluted (₹ / share)	152.53	68.27	49.13	220.80	45.32	205.62	150.90	69.26	95.48	48.30	220.16	45.62	208.36

Note:

1 The above is an extract of the detailed format of Quarterly Financial Results filed with the Stock Exchanges under Regulation 33 of the SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015. The full format of the Financial Results are available on the Stock Exchange websites: www.bseindia.com and www.nseindia.com. The same is also available on the company's website www.cpcl.co.in

2 For the other items of the Listing Regulations, pertinent disclosures have been made to stock exchanges (BSE and NSE) and can be acessed on www.bseindia.com and www.nseindia.com

3 The Board of Directors at its meeting held on 22nd October 2026 has declared an interim dividend of ₹ 25.00 per Equity share (Face value : ₹ 10.00 per Equity share) and has fixed Friday, 30th October 2026 as the "record date" for the purpose of ascertaining the eligibility of shareholders for payment of Interim Dividend for FY 2026-27.

BY ORDER OF THE BOARD
Rohit Kumar Agrawala
Director (Finance)
DIN: 10048961

Place : Chennai
Date : October 22, 2026